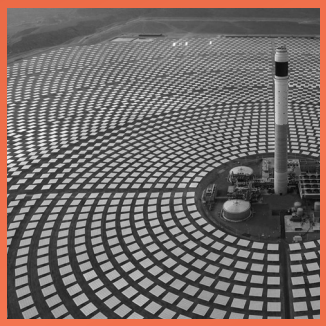
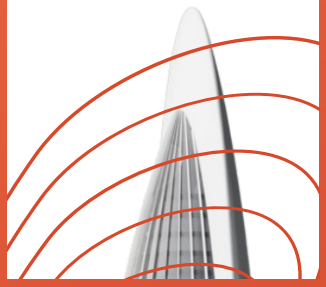
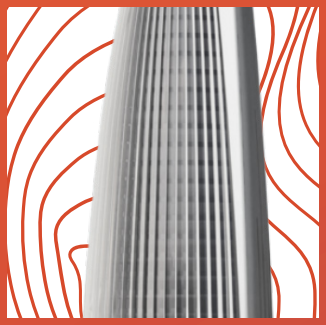
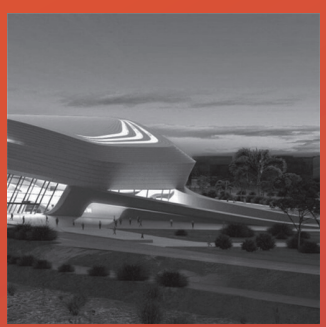
MOROCCO STARTUP ECOSYSTEM

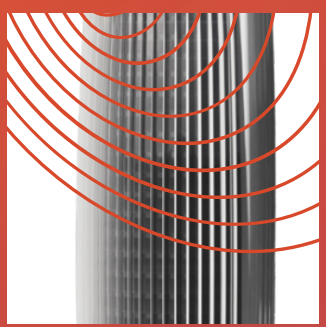


2025 REPORT









UM6P
University Mohammed VI Polytechnic

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04

Foreword

Beyond the Funding Record

Funding is an input, not an outcome. Morocco's next challenge is to become a platform from which globally relevant companies are repeatedly created and scaled, with each success making the next one more likely.

YASSINE LAGHZIOUI
Chief Entrepreneurship & Venturing Officer, UM6P
CEO, UM6P Ventures

An ecosystem is not mature simply because capital enters. It is mature when capital circulates: from investment into growth, from growth into liquidity, and from one generation of companies into the next. Morocco made real progress in 2025. But the cycle is still incomplete.

Moroccan startups raised a record $108 million across nearly 50 disclosed rounds. Just as importantly, funding became less concentrated. Three deals represented almost two thirds of total funding in 2024. In 2025, the top three accounted for roughly one third. More companies are attracting investment, and the market is becoming less dependent on a few exceptional rounds.

The harder question is what follows.

> **Morocco recorded six disclosed Series A rounds in 2025. No Series B round was disclosed. That gap says more about the state of the market than the headline total.**

The ecosystem can increasingly finance a company's launch and first phase of growth. When companies need larger amounts to enter new markets, strengthen their teams or build infrastructure, the range of local financing options narrows quickly.

The constraint is not founder quality. Four in five founders in the 2025 funded cohort had observed foreign academic or professional exposure, and almost two thirds of surveyed startups report good or very good market reception. Many of these companies are built to compete across borders from the outset.

As companies prepare for larger international rounds, their legal, financial and governance structures naturally evolve to accommodate cross-border investment and a broader shareholder base. This is part of scaling globally. Morocco's opportunity is to establish itself as a launchpad from which globally relevant ventures can repeatedly emerge: conceived here, validated in Morocco and across Africa, and connected to the capital and markets that allow them to grow wherever opportunity lies. Each success expands the network, experience and credibility available to the next generation.

Capital, however, cannot compensate for friction in the operating environment. More than 60% of surveyed founders say clients or partners do not pay them on time. A company with months rather than years of runway cannot carry procurement, validation and payment cycles that stretch indefinitely. Recruitment is delayed, product development slows, and management attention shifts from customers to cash collection.

Young companies compete through speed. When commercial processes take months, capital intended for innovation is consumed by waiting. The cost of slow procurement and payment is not only cash. It is the loss of a startup's most important advantage: speed.

The other incomplete part of the cycle is exits. Our 2024 report had already shown how rare they remained, with most venture funds having completed no more than one. Venture investing becomes sustainable when part of a portfolio eventually returns to cash. That evidence allows funds to raise again, gives founders and employees the capacity to build or back other companies, and provides credible reference points for buyers. Without recurring liquidity, portfolio valuations remain largely on paper.

There was meaningful movement in 2025. ORA's acquisition of Cathedis, financed with local capital, delivered liquidity to existing investors. Moroccan-Senegalese, pan-African Logidoo acquired Kamtar, reinforcing its position as a regional consolidator. Cash Plus's IPO provided liquidity to an existing shareholder and gave Morocco its first fintech listing.

These transactions matter because markets are built through precedent. But three transactions do not yet constitute an exit market. A durable environment will require more acquisitions by Moroccan corporates, more consolidation among startups, more secondary transactions and, for the right companies, clearer paths to public markets.

The objective is not exits for their own sake. It is to make success repeatable and bring capital, experience and ambition back into the ecosystem.

The next milestone is therefore not another funding record. It is what happens to the companies already financed. Series A companies should reach Series B. Pilots should become repeat orders. Regional expansion should create jobs and capabilities in Morocco. Investors and founders should begin reinvesting returns in new ventures.

That is how an ecosystem moves from activity to depth. Until then, higher funding totals will say less than we think.

06

Partners

INTELLIGENCE PARTNER

Startup Researcher

INSTITUTIONAL PARTNER

AMIC

INSTITUTIONAL CONTRIBUTORS

Technopark

CGEM

MOROCCO FINTECH CENTER

NATIONAL INVESTORS

212 Founders

AFRIMOBILITY

AMV

ALPHAVEST VENTURES

AZUR INNOVATION

BMCE CAPITAL

CASHPLUS | Ventures

DOMSEEDS

EMTECH

First Circle

KALYS VENTURES

FOUNDERS

MNF VENTURES

OUTLIERZ VENTURES

SEEDBOX

U-investors

UM6P VENTURES

INTERNATIONAL INVESTORS

500

AFRICINVEST

PLUGANDPLAY

RENEW CAPITAL

08

Executive Summary

Morocco's startup ecosystem became more structured and increasingly interconnected in 2025. Beyond the growth in investment activity, the year was marked by clearer funding stages, stronger sector specialization, more coordinated investor participation, and continued development of the institutional support environment. Together, these developments point to an ecosystem gradually moving from a collection of individual initiatives and transactions toward a more established and recognizable startup market.

Record funding was distributed more widely

$108.44M

Raised across 48 disclosed rounds

Moroccan startups raised $108.44 million across 48 disclosed rounds in 2025, making it the strongest year on record by both funding and deal count. Funding increased by 14.20% and deal count by 20% compared with 2024. The three largest rounds represented 33.66% of total funding, down from 64.70% in 2024, indicating that investment was distributed across a broader base of companies and that the ecosystem was less dependent on a small number of exceptional transactions.

A clearer financing pathway

$0.53M → $7.50M

Median ticket progression from pre-seed to Series A

The funding data reflects the emergence of a clearer financing pathway. Pre-seed remained the most active stage, followed closely by seed, while the growing number of pre-Series A and Series A transactions created greater continuity between company formation, market validation, and institutional growth financing. Median round sizes progressed from $0.53 million at pre-seed to $1.10 million at seed, $3.28 million at pre-Series A, and $7.50 million at Series A. These increasingly distinct ticket bands provide founders and investors with clearer market reference points and suggest that financing stages are becoming more closely aligned with company maturity and capital requirements.

Further deepening growth-stage financing

6 Series A rounds

Creating a foundation for future Series B activity

Morocco's financing pathway is becoming clearer through Series A, with six Series A rounds raising a combined $51.41 million in 2025. Series B activity had not yet emerged during the year, highlighting an opportunity to further deepen the availability of growth-stage capital. Expanding domestic financing options and strengthening connections with international follow-on investors could help more Moroccan startups pursue regional and global growth while maintaining their strategic and economic anchoring in Morocco.

A broader and more specialized sector base

Fintech

Leading venture category in 2025

Sector activity also became more closely connected to Morocco's economic priorities and technological capabilities. Fintech was the leading venture category in 2025, supported by activity across payments, lending, embedded finance, and digital financial services. Agritech strengthened its position as one of the ecosystem's most credible non-fintech verticals, reflecting the importance of agriculture, water efficiency, and climate resilience to the national economy. Proptech demonstrated the capacity to attract larger investments, while cybersecurity, healthtech, hrtech, AI and data, and sustainability showed encouraging signs of category development. This broader sector base is creating a more diversified ecosystem, even as Casablanca continues to play a central role in capital formation and startup activity.

Casablanca continues to anchor startup activity

75.12%

Of disclosed funding came from Casablanca-based startups

Casablanca continued to play a central role in Morocco's startup ecosystem, accounting for 28 of the 48 disclosed rounds and 75.12% of disclosed capital. Rabat and other Moroccan cities also contributed to the country's expanding entrepreneurial footprint. Building on this momentum through stronger regional access to investors, corporate customers, talent, and support networks could help more local ecosystems develop repeatable startup pipelines.

More coordinated investor participation

84.72%

Of disclosed capital came from rounds involving multiple investors

Investor behavior provides another indication of growing market sophistication. Larger rounds increasingly brought together several investors with complementary capabilities. Transactions involving at least two counted investor participations represented 56.25% of funding rounds but 84.72% of disclosed capital. All Series A rounds involved multiple investors, underlining the role of syndication in supporting larger transactions. This approach allows startups to combine local market knowledge, sector expertise, commercial relationships, regional networks, and potential follow-on capacity within the same financing round.

Domestic and international capital are becoming more complementary

67.92%

Of disclosed funding involved at least one international investor

International investors were also firmly embedded in the market. Rounds involving at least one international investor represented 56.25% of transactions and 67.92% of disclosed funding. Their participation was particularly visible in seed and larger rounds, where international expansion and future financing requirements become increasingly relevant. Moroccan investors nevertheless remained essential, particularly during company formation and early validation. The emerging model is therefore one of greater complementarity between domestic and international capital. Further deepening the number of investors able to structure and lead sizeable transactions would strengthen this model and expand the financing options available to growing companies.

New liquidity precedents are beginning to emerge

3 key milestones

Across acquisitions and public markets

Several important transactions demonstrated the emergence of more diverse pathways for company growth and investor liquidity in 2025. ORA's acquisition of Cathedis, financed with local capital, generated a return for an investor. Logidoo's acquisition of Kamtar strengthened a Moroccan company's position as a regional consolidator, while Cash Plus's IPO provided secondary liquidity and gave Morocco its first fintech listing. These developments represent encouraging precedents that could be reinforced through additional corporate acquisitions, startup consolidations, secondary transactions, and public listings.

An experienced founder base

98 founders

Across 47 funded startups

The founders who attracted investment in 2025 were predominantly experienced and highly educated. The report profiles 98 founders behind 47 funded startups. Nearly 85% held a graduate-level qualification, while computer science, data, AI, engineering, business, and finance accounted for most academic backgrounds. Almost 80% had accumulated at least five years of professional experience before founding, and half had worked for ten years or more. Morocco's funded founder base is therefore largely composed of professionals bringing established technical, commercial, or managerial expertise into entrepreneurship.

Participation remains uneven

15.31%

Of funded founders were women

At the same time, the data highlights opportunities to broaden participation across the ecosystem. Women represented 15.31% of founders in the funded cohort, and nearly three quarters of the startups were founded entirely by men. Among those who raised capital, women held CEO roles at approximately the same rate as men, demonstrating their capacity to assume the highest levels of company leadership. Female founders were, however, more likely to be building their first company and were less represented in technical professional backgrounds. Expanding access to technical pathways, entrepreneurial networks, mentorship, and investor relationships could help a larger and more diverse group of founders progress toward funding.

Operating conditions remain challenging

Talent gap

Technical, product and senior managerial roles remain difficult to fill

The founder survey provides a complementary view of the conditions in which Moroccan startups operate. Personal savings and bootstrapping remained the primary source of financing for most respondents, reflecting both the commitment of founders and the importance of strengthening early external financing options. Recruiting qualified talent remained challenging for many companies, particularly across technical, product, and senior managerial roles. Continued investment in specialized skills, experienced management, and links between startups, universities, and established companies could help address these needs as the ecosystem develops.

Improving payment conditions would support startup growth

60.71%

Experienced payment delays from clients or partners

Payment timelines remain an important area where further progress could strengthen startup resilience. Among the 56 respondents who answered this question, 35.71% experienced delays occasionally and 25% frequently. The most commonly cited reasons were client cash-flow constraints and lengthy validation or procurement processes. Continued efforts to streamline commercial processes and encourage more predictable payment practices could support startup cash flow, recruitment, product development, and long-term growth.

Commercialization and internationalization need to deepen

Nearly 59%

Generated no revenue outside Morocco

Commercialization also represents an important area for further progress. Market awareness and customer trust were cited more frequently than competition or pricing as barriers to growth. This indicates that many startups are developing new products in markets where they must also build understanding, demonstrate credibility, and establish effective relationships with larger customers. Internationalization remains at an early stage for much of the ecosystem, with nearly 59% of surveyed startups generating no revenue outside Morocco. Respondents highlighted access to foreign markets, regulatory requirements, payment mechanisms, certification, and dedicated expansion support as areas where additional guidance and infrastructure could accelerate cross-border growth.

Public support must become more visible

Just over one third

Had benefited from a public support mechanism

Founder feedback on public support points to opportunities to further improve the visibility, accessibility, and business impact of existing initiatives. Just over one third of respondents had benefited from a public grant, financing mechanism, or acceleration program, while others had applied without receiving support or were not aware of the programs available to them. Founders consistently expressed interest in support models connected to tangible business outcomes, including customer access, revenue generation, financing readiness, and job creation. Greater coordination, clearer communication, and continued evaluation of program results could therefore enhance the contribution of the support environment.

Institutional foundations continued to strengthen

Broader infrastructure

Financing, regulation, research and digital policy

At the institutional level, 2025 brought continued progress across financing, regulation, infrastructure, research, and digital policy. The Morocco Fintech Center strengthened the interface between financial innovators and regulators. New venture-building and financing mechanisms broadened the range of instruments available to startups and investors. DirectEntreprise improved business-registration infrastructure, while StartGate Rabat added an important physical platform for entrepreneurship, research, and innovation. Developments in AI cooperation, fintech guidance, technology regulation, and ecosystem convening also demonstrated a growing capacity among institutions to engage with emerging sectors and evolving entrepreneurial needs.

The overall picture is one of an ecosystem with substantial momentum and increasingly solid foundations. Morocco is developing clearer financing pathways, a more diverse sector base, stronger connections between local and international investors, an experienced founder population, and an expanding institutional framework. The next phase will be to translate these foundations into a larger number of sustainable companies, recurring commercial relationships, stronger regional and international growth, and wider participation across genders and geographies. Achieving this will depend on continued collaboration between founders, investors, corporates, universities, and public institutions, with an increasing focus on accessibility, coordination, and measurable business outcomes.

Investment Activity and Market Dynamics

13

Funding Activity in Morocco's Startup Ecosystem

Morocco's 2025 funding cycle marks a clear step forward in both capital formation and market depth. Startups raised $108.44 million across 48 disclosed rounds, making 2025 the strongest year in Morocco's history by both total funding and deal count. The headline growth is important, but the more meaningful signal is structural. Funding volume and transaction count increased at the same time, suggesting that the market was not simply lifted by one exceptional round, but supported by a broader base of investable companies.

This distinction matters. In earlier cycles, Moroccan startup funding often appeared strong in years where one or two large transactions distorted the overall picture. In 2025, the ecosystem showed a healthier pattern. More companies raised capital, more sectors attracted investor attention, and the growth-stage pipeline became less dependent on isolated breakout cases. The result is a funding cycle that looks less like a statistical spike and more like the early formation of a repeatable investment market.

The year also confirms that Moroccan venture activity is becoming more layered. Pre-seed and seed rounds continued to drive transaction volume, while pre-Series A and Series A activity expanded enough to show that a larger cohort of startups is progressing beyond the earliest stages. Fintech returned as the leading sector, but capital also flowed into proptech, agritech, healthtech, cybersecurity, hrtech, AI and data, and sustainability. Geographically, however, the market remains heavily concentrated, with Casablanca still absorbing the majority of disclosed capital.

$108.44M
2025 total funding

48
Disclosed rounds in 2025

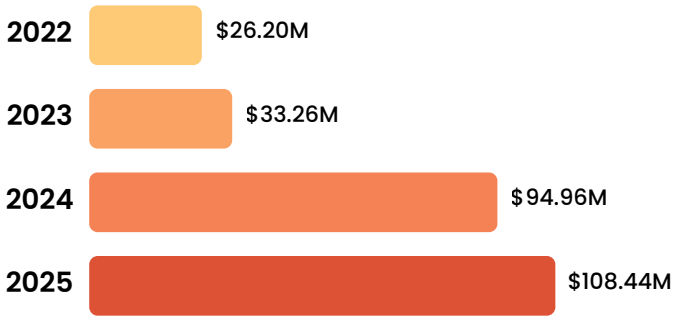
+14%
Funding YoY vs. 2024

+20%
Deal count YoY vs. 2024

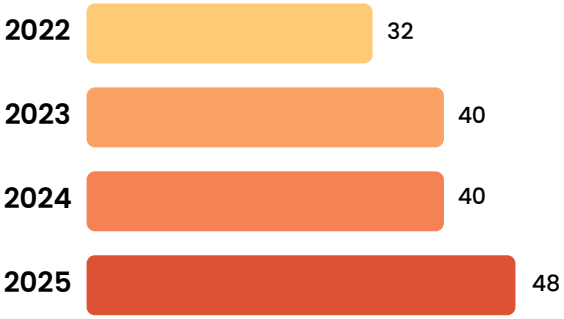
The 2025 Funding Cycle in Historical Context

Moroccan startups raised $108.44 million across 48 disclosed rounds in 2025, compared with $94.96 million across 40 rounds in 2024 and $33.26 million across 40 rounds in 2023. This represents a 14.20% increase in funding and a 20% increase in deal count versus 2024. The increase in deal count is especially important because annual transaction activity had remained flat at 40 rounds in both 2023 and 2024.

This creates a different reading of the market than a simple funding-growth headline would suggest. In 2024, capital increased sharply, but the year was heavily shaped by a small number of large rounds, especially the traveltech outlier that absorbed a significant share of total funding. In 2025, growth came from a wider transaction base. The ecosystem raised more money, but more importantly, it produced more fundable companies. That is a stronger signal of market development than a single large transaction.



Morocco Startup Funding by Year, 2022 to 2025



Number of Funding Rounds by Year, 2022 to 2025

The relationship between funding growth and deal growth also points to a shift in market composition. Since deal count grew faster than total capital, the average round size declined slightly on a headline basis compared with 2024. This should not be interpreted as investor retreat. It reflects the opposite: more capital was distributed across more companies, with less dependence on one exceptional transaction. In a market still building its venture pipeline, broad-based capital allocation is a stronger indicator of market maturity than headline investment figures driven by one or two exceptional deals.

Capital concentration fell materially in 2025. In 2024, the three largest rounds represented nearly 64.70% of all funding. In 2025, the top three rounds accounted for 33.66%, while the top five represented 46.11%. This is one of the strongest signs that the market is becoming more balanced. Large rounds still matter, but they no longer explain the entire year. A wider set of companies is now capable of attracting institutional capital, particularly at pre-Series A and Series A.

The composition of 2025 also suggests a market moving from episodic validation to early repeatability. Morocco is still not a late-stage venture market, and the absence of Series B activity remains a clear gap. However, the number of Series A and pre-Series A rounds shows that more startups are surviving the early-stage funnel and reaching a point where larger institutional checks become relevant. This is important because ecosystem maturity is not only measured by how much capital is raised. It is measured by whether companies can progress from formation to traction, from traction to institutional funding, and from institutional funding to scale.

« While we still have ground to reach the scale of Africa's largest tech hubs, 2025 stands out as a year of early consolidation for Morocco. We've always believed our market's greatest strength is "le temps long" (or "the long game"). Long before it was a trend, we mobilized local institutional capital because bridging real gaps requires patient, deep-rooted conviction. The catalysts driving this new phase are clear: deploying deep research to de-risk technical plays, co-constructing the continent's missing infrastructure alongside key strategic partners, and leveraging Morocco as a highly effective stepping stone into Africa. You see this patient execution paying off today. DeepEcho is building FDA-cleared health tech from our local hospitals, Userguest is exporting software globally, and SOWIT is advancing climate-resilient agriculture. This is what early consolidation looks like: patient, homegrown belief turning into lasting impact. »

Omar Laalej
Managing Director at Al Mada Ventures

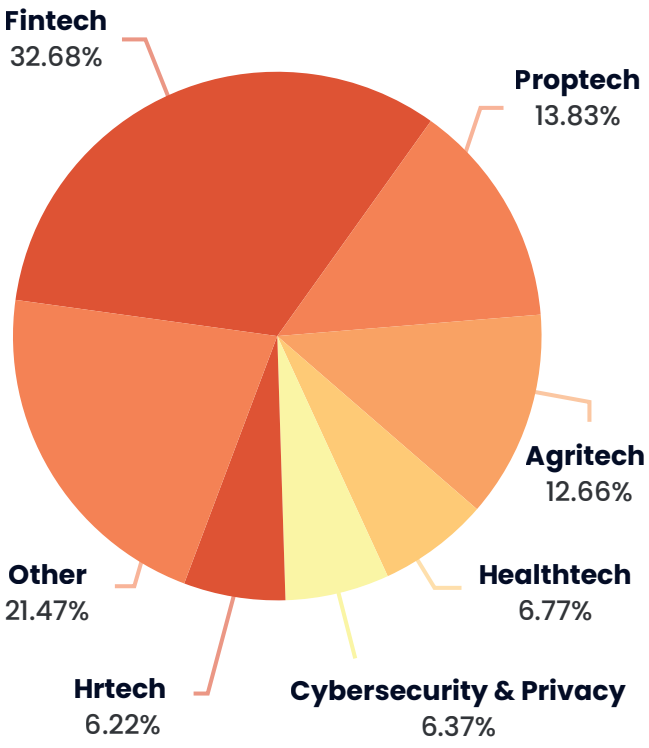
Ticket-size patterns reinforce the emergence of a clearer funding ladder. Pre-seed rounds averaged $0.57 million, while seed rounds averaged $1.52 million. Pre-Series A rounds averaged $2.97 million, creating a more visible intermediate layer between seed and Series A. Series A rounds averaged $8.57 million, with a median of $7.50 million, indicating that Morocco's growth-stage market is beginning to settle around a more recognizable Series A band.

The main implication is that Morocco's funding cycle is becoming more coherent. The market is no longer only producing isolated early-stage rounds and occasional large exceptions. It is starting to show a chain of progression across stages. The challenge over the next funding cycles will be whether this chain can extend beyond Series A. Meeting that ambition will require deeper growth-stage capital, stronger links to international follow-on investors, and structured cross-sector support, so that Series B rounds become repeatable milestones rather than exceptional outliers.

Sector and vertical breakdown

The sector data shows a funding market that is becoming broader, but not evenly distributed. In 2025, fintech became Morocco's leading venture sector, attracting $35.44 million across 9 rounds. This represented 32.68% of total capital and 18.75% of all transactions. The change from 2024 is significant. In 2024, fintech accounted for 27.50% of deals but only 11.60% of funding, meaning the sector was active but not dominant by capital raised. In 2025, fintech led on both dimensions.

The shift is important because fintech's 2025 performance was not only the result of one large transaction. The sector showed depth across stages and business models, including payments, embedded finance, lending, and digital banking. That makes fintech the clearest example of category maturity in the Moroccan ecosystem. It has enough founder activity, investor familiarity, customer demand, and capital availability to consistently produce fundable companies across the pipeline. In practical terms, fintech is no longer just a high-interest vertical. It is the ecosystem's most developed venture category.



Funding Share by Sector, 2025

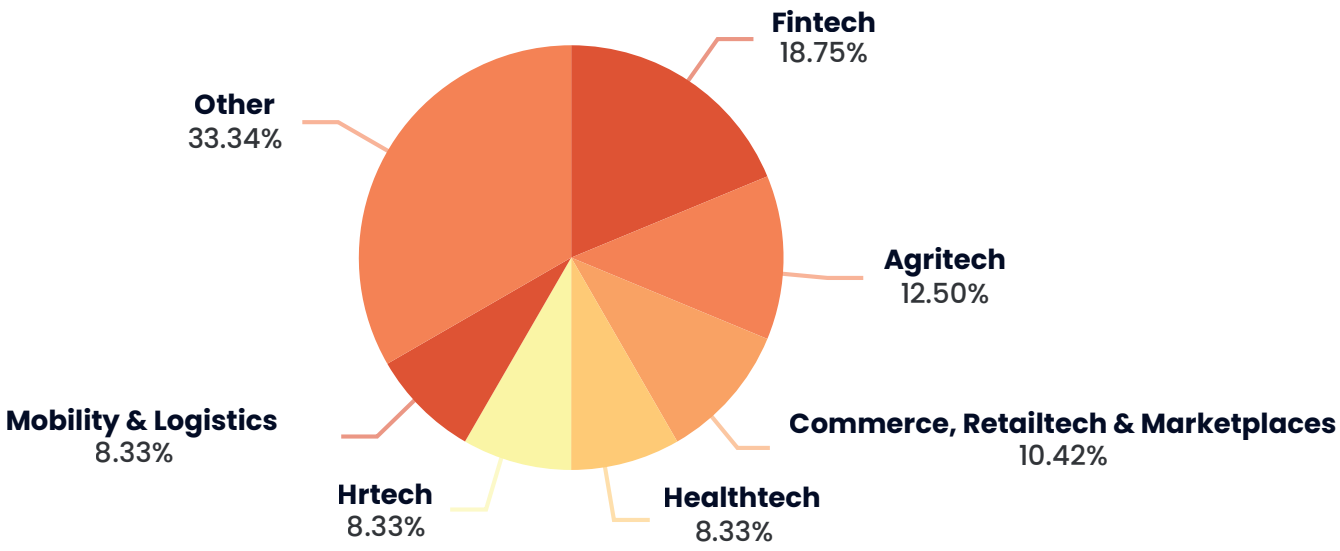
« At First Circle, we are excited about promising signs coming from Bank Al-Maghrib to create an innovation-friendly environment for fintech businesses to drive financial inclusion and improve services for Moroccan customers and SMEs. We have backed one of the fastest growing fintechs, WafR, very early and will look to make more investments in the future. »

Selma Ribica

Co-founder and Managing Partner at First Circle Capital

Proptech ranked second by capital, representing 13.83% of total funding. The sector's rise in 2025 should be read carefully. It does not yet prove that proptech has become a broad category in Morocco, however, it does show that investors are willing to underwrite larger tickets outside the traditional fintech and mobility clusters when a company reaches sufficient scale. That broadens the set of sectors capable of producing growth-stage outcomes.

Agritech ranked third, with $13.73 million across 6 rounds, equal to 12.66% of funding and 12.50% of deal count. Unlike proptech, agritech's position is supported by both value and volume. The sector's expansion over two consecutive years suggests that it is becoming one of Morocco's most credible non-fintech verticals. This is strategically important given Morocco's agricultural base, water stress, and the growing need for productivity-enhancing technologies. Agritech's funding activity shows that investor interest is moving beyond generic software into sectors tied to Morocco's real economic structure.



Deal Share by Sector, 2025

One of the most encouraging signals in the sector breakdown is the formation of several emerging categories such as cybersecurity, healthtech, and hrtech. These are not yet dominant sectors, but they are no longer isolated experiments. Each produced enough activity in 2025 to suggest early category formation.

This widening sector base matters for two reasons. First, it reduces the ecosystem's exposure to one or two sectors. A market overly dependent on fintech or mobility can appear active while still being structurally narrow. Second, it shows that Moroccan founders are building in more specialized verticals, including cybersecurity, AI and data, industrial technology, sustainability, and health. These sectors typically require deeper technical talent, more specialized go-to-market strategies, and stronger trust from customers. Their emergence suggests that the founder base is becoming more sophisticated.

The 2025 sector mix also shows how sensitive year-on-year comparisons can be in a relatively small market. Traveltech is the clearest example. In 2024, the sector accounted for 53.30% of total

funding, largely because of one large round. In 2025, it represented only 1.30% of capital. This does not necessarily indicate a deterioration in traveltech fundamentals. Rather, it shows that the 2024 sector ranking was heavily influenced by a single transaction, while the 2025 ranking reflects a broader distribution of capital across several sectors.

Mobility and logistics also recorded a lower share of activity in 2025, declining from 12.01% of funding and 17.50% of deals in 2024 to 4.64% of funding and 8.33% of deals in 2025. The decline may reflect timing effects, fewer companies raising during the year, a later-stage funding gap, or investor selectivity in operationally intensive models. What can be said with confidence is that mobility and logistics did not play the same balancing role in 2025 that they played in 2024.

Overall, the 2025 sector mix shows a more balanced ecosystem. Fintech remains the anchor, but agritech is becoming structurally relevant, proptech has shown growth-stage potential, and several specialized sectors are moving from isolated activity to early category formation. The market is still concentrated, but the concentration is less fragile than the previous year.

Stage analysis

The stage breakdown provides the clearest evidence that Morocco's startup financing market is maturing. The data shows a stronger early-stage base alongside a larger post-seed pipeline, with activity extending from pre-seed through Series A.

Series A activity remained central to Morocco's growth-stage funding in 2025, with 6 rounds totaling $51.41 million. The headline comparison with 2024, when Series A rounds totaled $62.50 million across 5 transactions, understates the strength of the 2025 cycle because the previous year's total was heavily concentrated in one large traveltech round. On a comparable basis, excluding that outlier, Series A capital increased from approximately $14.50 million across 4 rounds in 2024 to $51.41 million across 6 rounds in 2025. The key shift, therefore, is not simply the amount of capital raised, but the broadening of the Series A cohort across a larger number of companies and sectors.

« We are seeing a clear shift in the maturity of Moroccan startups, particularly at the Series A stage. Rounds that were almost nonexistent a few years ago are now becoming increasingly frequent. Companies like Yakeey, ORA, and Inyad have raised significant funding, marking an important step forward for the ecosystem. At the same time, interest from major international investors is strengthening. For instance, IFC's venture arm recently invested in a Moroccan tech company for the first time. Taken together, these developments point to a broader transformation: Moroccan startups are becoming more mature, expanding beyond their domestic market, and attracting the kind of institutional confidence that is reshaping global perceptions of the ecosystem. »

Nawfal Fassi Fihri
Deputy Director in charge of 212 Founders

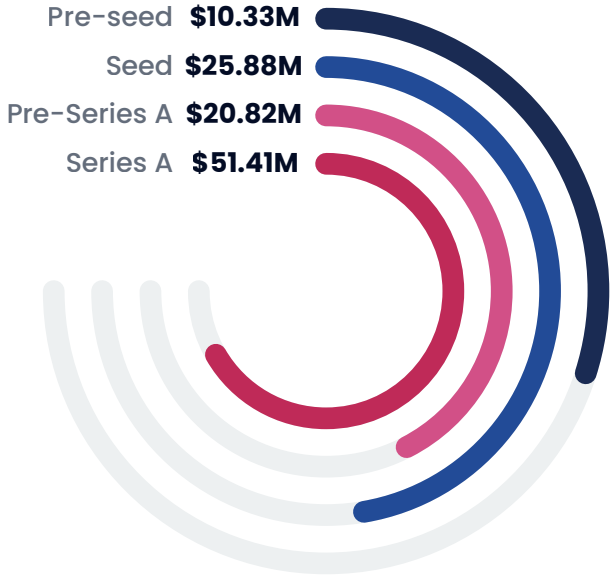
This is one of the most important findings in the section. Morocco did not simply produce another large Series A in 2025. It produced a larger Series A cohort. Six companies across five sectors reached that stage, which means the growth-stage pipeline is becoming broader. For investors, this signals that Morocco may finally be generating enough post-seed companies to justify more structured growth-stage capital. For policymakers and ecosystem builders, it shows that support efforts should increasingly focus not only on company creation, but also on scale-up readiness.

Pre-Series A activity also expanded sharply. Morocco recorded 7 pre-Series A rounds in 2025, compared with 2 in 2024, representing $20.82 million in capital. This is a major signal because pre-Series A is often the stage where young ecosystems either build continuity or lose companies. In markets with limited follow-on capital, startups that raise seed rounds often struggle to secure the next check before they are ready for a formal Series A. They may delay growth, move fundraising abroad, or restructure their companies to access foreign capital. The expansion of pre-Series A activity suggests that part of this gap is beginning to be served.

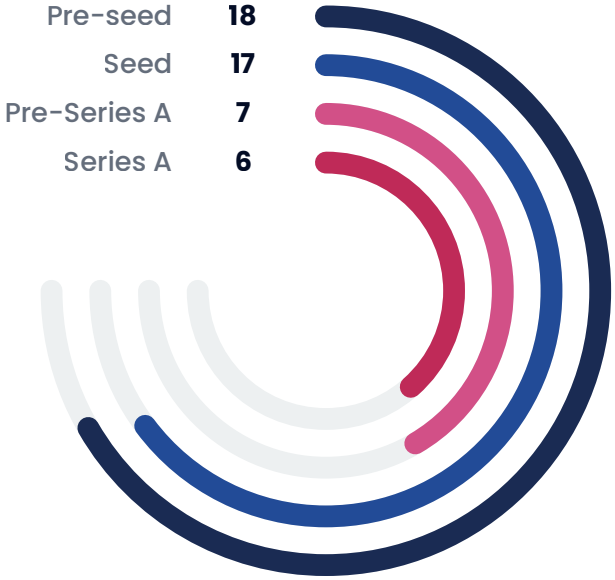
The size of pre-Series A rounds also shows that this part of the market is becoming more defined. With average pre-Series A tickets at $2.97 million and a median of $3.28 million, the segment now shows a clearer step-up from seed. However, it remains far below Series A levels, which means pre-Series A still functions as a transitional stage between early validation and larger institutional growth financing. It gives companies more runway to refine metrics, build teams, and prepare for Series A, but it may not be enough for startups with heavier capital requirements or regional expansion plans.

Pre-seed remained the most active stage by deal count, with 18 rounds, representing 37.50% of all 2025 transactions. Seed activity reached 17 deals and $25.88 million. Together, pre-seed and seed accounted for 35 of 48 rounds, confirming that early-stage activity remains the engine of Morocco's deal flow. This is expected in a young ecosystem, but the quality of this early-stage base matters. A high number of pre-seed rounds is only useful if enough companies can later convert into seed, pre-Series A, and Series A rounds. The 2025 data provides early evidence that this conversion is improving.

Median ticket sizes show a clearer funding staircase. The median pre-seed round stood at $0.53 million, seed at $1.10 million, pre-Series A at $3.28 million, and Series A at $7.50 million. This progression is important because it gives founders and investors a more realistic sense of market expectations. Morocco is beginning to show recognizable funding bands by stage, rather than a fragmented market where round labels are inconsistent and ticket sizes vary widely.



Funding by Stage, 2025



Number of Rounds by Stage, 2025

Median ticket size by stage

$0.53M	$1.10M	$3.28M	$7.50M
Pre-seed median	Seed median	Pre-Series A median	Series A median

The stage analysis also highlights what is still missing. Morocco's funding ladder is becoming stronger through Series A, but it has not yet demonstrated consistent Series B capacity. The gap is important because Series B is where companies typically require larger pools of capital for regional expansion, deeper product development, senior hiring, and market consolidation. Without a visible Series B path, the strongest Moroccan startups may still need to raise abroad, relocate holding structures, or pursue strategic alternatives earlier than they would in deeper venture markets.

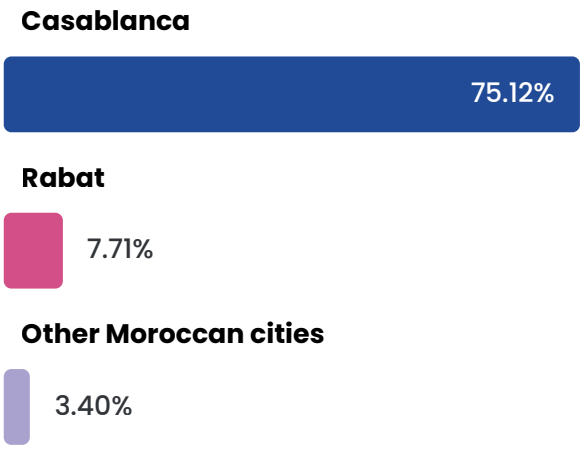
The 2025 stage data therefore points to a transition, not a completed maturity cycle. The ecosystem has moved beyond a purely early-stage profile, but it has not yet become a full-stack financing market. The key question for the next funding cycles is whether the larger pre-Series A and Series A cohorts can produce the next layer of growth rounds.

Geographic analysis

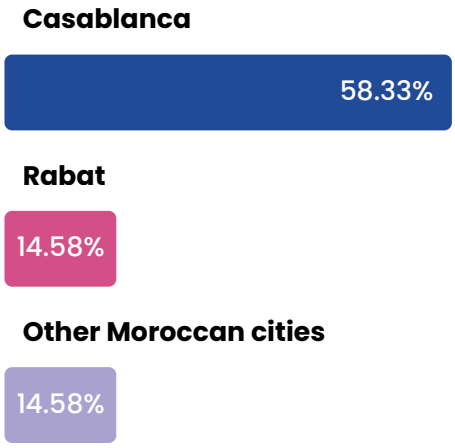
Morocco's startup funding remains heavily concentrated in Casablanca. In 2025, the city accounted for 28 of 48 disclosed rounds, representing 58.33% of total deal count and 75.12% of total capital raised. This concentration reflects Casablanca's advantages in access to financial institutions, corporate customers, talent, investors, and business networks. For startups, it is often the country's most efficient market, combining ecosystem infrastructure with customer proximity.

Rabat remained the second-largest hub, with 7 rounds totaling $8.36 million, equivalent to 14.58% of deal count and 7.71% of funding. The gap between its share of deals and capital suggests that Rabat is producing fundable startups, but fewer large-ticket rounds than Casablanca, consistent with its strengths in research, public institutions, and specialized talent. The concentration in both cities also partly reflects founders' place of residence.

Other Moroccan cities accounted for 7 rounds and $3.69 million, representing 14.58% of deal count and 3.40% of funding. This includes activity in Marrakech, Benguerir, Agadir, and other cities. While still fragmented, this activity shows that investable companies are emerging beyond the Casablanca-Rabat axis, often around sector-specific regional strengths.



Funding by City, 2025 *



Number of Rounds by City, 2025 **

« I expect to see greater fluidity across Morocco's regions. Today, much of the startup ecosystem remains concentrated in Casablanca. Yet active hubs exist across the country. In cities like Agadir, Essaouira, and other regions in both the south and north, there are promising startups that still lack the visibility that the ones in Casablanca have. Initiatives and institutions can play an important role in building the networks needed to give these startups broader exposure, and Technopark is a strong example. I believe this is a natural next step for Morocco's ecosystem, and one that will happen. As more startups emerge from across the country, Morocco's ecosystem as a whole will become stronger and more balanced. »

Niccolò Sapio
Principal at Plug and Play Ventures

However, geographic decentralization remains at an early stage. Casablanca's 75.12% share of capital remains far above its 58.33% share of rounds, confirming that larger checks are still concentrated in the country's main commercial hub. Rabat and other cities are increasingly visible, but have not yet shifted the ecosystem's center of gravity.

Scaling regional startup activity will therefore require more than incubation and founder training. Access to lead capital, investor networks, customers, and credibility remains critical to closing seed and Series A rounds. If founders outside Casablanca must build Casablanca-facing operations to raise capital, regional ecosystems will remain structurally dependent on the main hub.

** Percentages are calculated using total 2025 funding as the denominator. City information was not available for 6 rounds.*
*** Percentages are calculated using all 48 disclosed rounds as the denominator. City information was not available for 6 rounds.*

The 2025 data points to a dual reality: Morocco's startup footprint is widening, but capital formation remains centralized. The next phase will depend on whether regional hubs can turn occasional successes into repeatable local pipelines supported by investors willing to lead rounds outside Casablanca.

What to watch in the upcoming years

The next funding cycles will show whether 2025 marked a lasting shift in Morocco's venture market. Three indicators will be particularly important.

First, a Series B round above $20 million would demonstrate that Moroccan startups can progress beyond Series A and attract later-stage capital for regional scale.

Second, conversion of the 2025 pre-Series A cohort into Series A rounds at comparable or higher ticket sizes would validate the emergence of a more continuous funding ladder.

Third, secondary hubs need to generate multiple seed or post-seed rounds. Rabat, Marrakech, Benguerir, Agadir, and other cities do not need to rival Casablanca, but they do need repeatable funded activity if Morocco is to develop a genuinely national startup ecosystem.

« Morocco's startup ecosystem is entering a new phase of maturity. A first cohort of high-potential companies is successfully consolidating at the pre-Series A stage and progressing toward Series A, demonstrating the emergence of increasingly credible scale-up trajectories. At the same time, a growing network of accelerators and venture builders is nurturing a new generation of founders and expanding the pipeline of future seed-stage opportunities. While larger pools of capital are expected to materialize progressively toward 2027, this environment is already encouraging greater focus on resilience, execution, and sustainable growth. Looking ahead, a global-first mindset will be instrumental in strengthening Morocco's equity story, with the next generation of scale-ups poised to combine strong execution, compelling commercial narratives, and international growth ambitions. »

Hiba Mrani Alaoui
Managing Partner VC at AlphaVest Capital

« In 2025, Attijariwafa Ventures invested in technology startups in Morocco, Ghana, and Tunisia, contributing to broader efforts to expand access to financing for innovation. Beyond funding, Attijariwafa Ventures provides strategic capital by connecting its portfolio companies to the Attijariwafa bank Group's ecosystem, which spans 27 countries, including 15 across Africa. This approach gives startups access to industry expertise, business partnerships, and opportunities to scale their solutions across multiple markets, helping innovative businesses grow and create long-term economic value. »

Hamza Mikou
Chief Executive Officer at Attijariwafa Ventures

Methodology note

This section is based on 48 disclosed startup financing transactions recorded for Moroccan startups in 2025. For readability, the analysis uses "funding rounds" as shorthand for disclosed financing transactions, including formal rounds and other stage-classified funding events. Funding totals, averages, medians, sector shares, stage shares, and geographic shares are calculated from disclosed funding amounts in U.S. dollars. Sector and stage classifications follow the primary category assigned to each startup or transaction. Percentages are calculated using the full 2025 dataset unless otherwise stated. For geographic charts, rounds where city information was not available are not displayed as a separate category for readability, but they remain included in total funding and deal-count denominators. City information was not available for 6 of 48 disclosed rounds, representing $14.93 million in funding.

Liquidity Events in Morocco's Startup Ecosystem

Liquidity events are one of the clearest indicators of ecosystem maturity, because they show whether capital can not only enter startups, but also be returned or recycled. In Morocco, such outcomes have historically been limited, but 2025 offered more visible signs of progress through both strategic acquisitions and renewed activity in public markets. While the evidence still points to an ecosystem in transition rather than one that is fully mature, these developments suggest that liquidity pathways are beginning to take clearer shape.

Strategic Acquisitions and Ecosystem Consolidation

Within that broader picture, the acquisitions that did occur in 2025 were significant. At the regional level, exits are still widely recognized as the weakest link in venture capital, and Morocco has likewise continued to face a narrow exit base. In that context, these startup-led acquisitions are important not because they signal a fully developed M&A market, but because they show that more realistic paths to liquidity are beginning to emerge. In practical terms, 2025 suggested that Morocco's ecosystem is starting to move, cautiously, from a model centered almost entirely on fundraising toward one in which capital can also be deployed for consolidation and strategic control.

The acquisition of Cathedis by ORA Technologies is one of the clearest examples of this shift. The transaction gave ORA exclusive control over Cathedis, a last-mile logistics company specializing in retail parcel delivery, while ORA was already building a broader digital commerce ecosystem through products such as Kooul and ORA Cash. The deal stands out for its timing as much as for its strategic rationale. ORA had announced a $1.9 million pre-Series A round in March 2025, followed by a $7.5 million Series A in July 2025, before turning to acquisition. This sequence suggests that raised capital is beginning to be used in more strategic ways across the ecosystem. In ORA's case, it enabled the company to internalize a core operational layer that can strengthen execution, improve service reliability, and reinforce the coherence of its broader platform. ORA and Azur Innovation Fund described the transaction as the first startup-to-startup consolidation in Morocco financed exclusively by local capital, while Beltone Venture Capital later reported a 100% IRR on its exit from Cathedis. Taken together, these elements make the deal an early indication that local venture and growth capital may increasingly support consolidation alongside company creation and expansion.

« This is a landmark exit for Morocco! We've successfully sold our stake in a deal featuring two local firsts: a startup-to-startup acquisition by ORA Technologies and a fund-to-fund transfer to Azur Innovation Fund. This transaction sends a powerful signal of the ecosystem's growing maturity and directly answers the risk of 'exit lock-in' for regional investors. »

Ghita Khaoulani
Investment Director at BMCE Capital

« The ORA–Cathedis transaction was a defining milestone for us. Through this 100% acquisition, we were able to achieve several objectives simultaneously. First, we proved that build-up strategies can be successfully executed in venture capital, not only in private equity. Second, we facilitated the exit of a foreign investor who, notably, was the first to recover its funds seamlessly. Third, we unlocked tangible synergies between ORA and Cathedis, two distinct but highly complementary businesses spanning technology production, field operations, and support functions. »

Adnane Filali
Managing Partner at Azur Innovation Management

The Logidoo-Kamtar transaction reflects the same broader shift, but with a stronger regional dimension. Moroccan-Senegalese Logidoo presented the acquisition as part of its strategy to simplify intra-African trade and build an integrated logistics network for African businesses. Beyond the strategic narrative, the deal was reported to add meaningful operating scale, bringing in a business with more than 40 corporate clients and cumulative turnover of over €17 million (≈ $19.8 million) across the industrial, construction, agri-food, and logistics sectors. It also reinforced Logidoo's presence on key corridors such as Dakar-Abidjan, Casablanca-Dakar, and Tunis-Dakar. Rather than a symbolic transaction, the acquisition expanded freight density, improved corridor execution, and strengthened regional operating capacity in markets where fragmentation remains a structural constraint. For Morocco's ecosystem, its importance lies in what it signals: a Morocco-linked platform positioning itself as a regional consolidator in Francophone Africa rather than remaining focused only on domestic expansion.

A separate confidential fintech-to-fintech transaction reviewed for this report points in the same direction. While the deal terms were not publicly disclosed, its strategic significance remains clear. One Moroccan fintech acquiring another suggests that consolidation is beginning to take shape within the ecosystem itself, with founders using M&A to expand capabilities and reinforce their market position rather than relying solely on organic growth. In a still-young market, that is a meaningful sign of growing maturity.

Taken together, these deals suggest that the next stage of Moroccan startup growth may increasingly be shaped by integration and consolidation. ORA is reinforcing its domestic platform by bringing together payments, commerce, and last-mile delivery, while Logidoo is expanding regional reach by strengthening strategic transport corridors across North and West Africa. In both cases, acquisition is being used to secure capabilities that would take considerable time and effort to build internally. The right interpretation, however, is disciplined optimism. These transactions do not mean Morocco has solved its exit gap, and they do not yet amount to a broad, liquid M&A market. What they do show is that startup-led acquisitions are becoming a credible mechanism for value creation and liquidity, especially when the acquired asset provides operational depth that would be costly or slow to build internally.

IPO Momentum and Market Confidence

If strategic acquisitions showed one emerging route to liquidity, developments in public markets offered a broader signal that Morocco's overall liquidity environment was improving. Reuters reported that average daily trading volume on the Casablanca Stock Exchange rose by nearly 70% in 2024, while total market capitalization rose about 20%, and the exchange moved forward with a derivatives market centered on the MASI 20 to improve liquidity and broaden participation. At the same time, Reuters also noted that local population participation in the market remained below 1%. That contrast is important. It means the 2025 sequence of equity transactions did not emerge from a fully mature retail market, but from a market that was being actively modernized and was beginning to regain momentum.

One of the strongest signals of confidence in 2025 was the breadth of retail participation across multiple transactions. Vicenne's IPO, the first of the year, drew 37,674 subscribers and generated roughly MAD 32.1 billion (≈ $3.51 billion) in demand for a MAD 500 million (≈ $54.7 million) offering. TGCC's capital increase then attracted 82,080 subscribers and about MAD 92 billion (≈ $10.2 billion) in demand, equivalent to roughly 42 times the amount sought. Cash Plus followed with 80,759 subscribers and nearly MAD 48.8 billion (≈ $5.26 billion) subscribed, while SGTM mobilized 171,377 subscribers and more than MAD 171 billion (≈ $18.44 billion) in demand, setting a new participation record on the market. The analytical point is not simply that these transactions were oversubscribed. It is that investor appetite was broad-based across sectors such as healthcare, fintech, and construction, and across both IPOs and follow-on equity issuance. This reinforces the idea that Morocco's 2025 equity story was not a single-company anomaly, but a wider reopening of the public-equity window.

Cash Plus stands out as the most relevant transaction from a startup-ecosystem perspective. Official documents and market reporting show that the IPO combined 2 million newly issued shares with a secondary sale by an existing shareholder, with the main offer priced at MAD 200 (≈ $21.57) per share and a discounted employee and eligible management tranche at MAD 160 (≈ $17.25), bringing the total deal size to MAD 750 million (≈ $80.9 million). That structure is important because it created two forms of liquidity at once: MAD 400 million (≈ $43.1 million) in fresh capital for the company and MAD 350 million (≈ $37.7 million) in secondary liquidity for an existing shareholder. Mediterrania Capital Partners later explicitly described the offering as a partial exit. The transaction carries even greater symbolic weight because Cash Plus was Morocco's first fintech IPO, making it a category-level milestone rather than just a company event. More broadly, it suggests that a tech-enabled financial services platform with nationwide reach, regulatory legitimacy,

and sufficient operational maturity can now satisfy the requirements of public market investors. The market's response reinforced that signal, with the stock closing its first trading week at MAD 321.9 (≈ $35.05), about 61% above the IPO price. For Morocco's startup and scale-up landscape, the message is meaningful but should not be overstated: public markets are becoming a more plausible route for mature, tech-enabled financial services businesses, but the threshold remains high and still favors companies with established scale, operating history, and strong market presence.

The rest of the 2025 market calendar strengthens that interpretation. Vicenne's offering was a pure primary issue of 2,118,644 new shares at MAD 236 (≈ $25.84), showing that investors were willing to fund growth capital in a healthcare platform well before Cash Plus came to market. TGCC was not an IPO, but its MAD 2.2 billion (≈ $243.9 million) capital increase was highly relevant because it demonstrated that the market could also absorb a very large follow-on equity transaction. Official documentation shows that the company intended to use the proceeds primarily to fully repay debt raised for the acquisition of 60% of STAM, while also increasing its free float from 33.2% to 39.0%. SGTM then extended the momentum through an all-secondary share sale, with the AMMC-approved prospectus describing an offer of up to MAD 5.04 billion (≈ $543.5 million) through the sale of 12 million shares, representing 20% of capital, at MAD 420 per share (≈ $45.29), and subsequent market reporting describing SGTM as the 80th listed company on the exchange.

What does this mean for startups? First, the public-market signal is real. Morocco demonstrated in 2025 that domestic equity capital can be mobilized at scale and across sectors, and that retail participation can become a powerful force when confidence is high. Second, the bar is still demanding. The companies that succeeded in public markets were not early-stage ventures, but larger, more mature businesses with clear operating footprints and governance structures that public investors could underwrite. For startups, this suggests that IPOs are becoming more conceivable as a long-term pathway, but not yet broadly accessible as a near-term outcome. The more immediate significance is indirect but still important: stronger public markets improve the overall liquidity environment, make partial exits more imaginable for growth investors, and help establish reference cases that may gradually expand the universe of businesses considered listable.

Overall, the combined message of 2025 is that Morocco is beginning to build clearer liquidity pathways through both strategic acquisitions and public markets, but it remains an ecosystem in transition rather than one that is already fully mature. On the private side, acquisitions are still limited in number and concentrated in highly strategic situations. On the public side, investor appetite is clearly present, but the market continues to favor larger and more established companies. The next true inflection point will come when the ecosystem produces a significant startup exit that delivers strong and visible returns for investors. Such an outcome would do more than mark an individual success, it would help validate venture capital as a credible asset class in Morocco, encourage new capital inflows, attract more private investors, and strengthen the incentive for ambitious founders and experienced professionals to build companies locally. In that sense, supporting startups that can reach meaningful scale and attract strategic acquirers or public-market interest is not only important for company growth, but for the broader maturation of the ecosystem itself.

« A key inflection point for Morocco's startup ecosystem will occur when the first significant liquidity event materializes. A successful exit demonstrating strong returns for investors would validate venture capital as a viable asset class in the country. Such outcomes tend to catalyze new capital inflows, attract private investors, and encourage talented professionals to pursue entrepreneurship. Supporting startups capable of reaching meaningful scale and attracting strategic acquirers is therefore essential to accelerating the ecosystem's maturation. »

Omar Lemrabet
General Partner at Wita Ventures

Interview with

Nabil Amar

Chairman, Cash Plus

Could you begin by introducing your background and explain how that journey led you to Cash Plus and shaped its evolution over the past decade?

Nabil Amar: My background spans distribution, technology, and business transformation. After completing my studies in France, I returned to Morocco and began working in telecom distribution at a time when mobile telephony was rapidly reshaping the market. That experience showed me very clearly how technology can change customer behavior and transform entire business models.

I later founded a startup focused on ERP deployment, fleet management, and practical digitalization solutions for companies. That experience led me to collaborate with Cash Plus before formally joining the company. At the time, Cash Plus needed stronger internal systems to support its operations and structure its growth more effectively. We developed a platform to help manage and consolidate transaction flows across the business, and that work gradually evolved into a broader transformation effort.

In 2015, I joined Cash Plus as part of a wider phase of institutionalization, with stronger governance, more structured management, and a clearer foundation for scaling.

Since then, the company has gone through a much broader transformation. It has expanded well beyond its original remittance activity, significantly broadened its product offering, modernized its network model, and invested in technology, marketing, and operational excellence. What has remained constant is its proximity-based model and its focus on serving customers across Morocco, especially segments that have historically been underserved by traditional financial services. Today, the next phase is centered on efficiency, digitalization, and reinforcing trust in financial services.

Cash Plus recently became the first Moroccan fintech to go public. What was the strategic logic behind that decision?

Nabil Amar: For us, going public was part of a longer trajectory rather than a standalone event. Cash Plus had already gone through several phases of institutional development and capital operations over the years, so the IPO was a natural next step in that evolution.

The rationale was very clear. First, we wanted

additional financial resources to accelerate digitalization, both internally and externally. Second, we wanted to continue expanding the network across the local market. Third, we wanted more flexibility to pursue selective external growth through acquisitions where there is real strategic fit and synergy.

We also set aside a smaller allocation for venture investments, which reflects a broader ambition to build around innovation and support companies that can create strategic value alongside our core business.

What led you to establish Cash Plus Ventures, and how do you view the different ways corporates and startups can create strategic value together?

Nabil Amar: Cash Plus Ventures came from a simple observation. For several years, startups had already been approaching us because they wanted access to our network, our customer base, or a partner that could help them scale. In some cases, the fit was very clear. Their technology could address a real need for Cash Plus, and our infrastructure could help them grow faster. We wanted to formalize that type of relationship.

Our approach is not purely financial. Early-stage companies need more than capital. They need close follow-up, regular dialogue, and real operational support. That is how we want to position Cash Plus Ventures. We do not just want to write checks. We want to stay engaged with founders through regular interaction and business reviews, and help them reach real milestones.

More broadly, I do not think there is only one valid model for corporate-startup collaboration. In practice, we have worked through several models: minority investment, incubation, and in some cases, full acquisition. What matters is not the label, but whether there is real strategic logic and real room for synergy on both sides.

Based on your experience as both an operator and an investor, what makes a strong founder in Morocco today?

Nabil Amar: There is no perfect founder profile and no universal formula. But some qualities matter consistently. The first is depth of experience. The strongest founders are often those who know their sector very well because they have spent years working in it and understand its realities firsthand.

That matters because execution does not happen in the abstract. It comes from knowing the field, understanding how the market works, and building around problems you have actually experienced. Founders who operate in areas they know well usually start from a stronger position than those approaching a sector from a distance.

The second quality is maturity. A strong founder needs to stay grounded, understand how value is really created, and have enough financial and legal awareness to navigate the company's development responsibly. Capital matters, but founder quality remains decisive.

Looking more broadly at the Moroccan startup ecosystem, what do you think it needs most over the next few years?

Nabil Amar: In my view, the ecosystem needs to invest more in the depth and quality of entrepreneurship. Morocco needs more founders with real professional experience, stronger sector knowledge, and a better understanding of how businesses actually operate.

But it also means giving founders more than funding. Capital is important, but it is not enough. Founders need close support, regular follow-up, and a more disciplined approach to building companies over time. That includes stronger guidance on execution, governance, and financial and legal fundamentals.

More broadly, I think the ecosystem needs to take a clearer look at what has and has not worked over the past decade. We need a more honest state of play, and we need to learn more systematically from strong Moroccan founders, including those building abroad. Morocco does have talented founders. The challenge now is to create the conditions for many more of them to emerge and scale.

Interview with

Ismael Belkhayat

Founder & CEO, Chari

Could you begin by introducing your background and providing an overview of Chari as it stands today?

Ismael Belkhayat: I am a Moroccan entrepreneur, born and raised in Rabat. After high school, I pursued undergraduate studies in Europe and completed graduate studies in the United States. I began my career in consulting in Paris before returning to Morocco. About twelve years ago, I transitioned into entrepreneurship and have since launched a few ventures, including Chari.

Chari is, at its core, a Banking-as-a-Service platform. As a licensed financial institution, we provide the infrastructure, payment rails, technology stack, and regulatory authorization that enable local companies to develop and offer embedded finance products. In practice, this operates as a white-label model, with partners integrating into our platform to launch financial services.

Chari also serves small merchants directly. Leveraging our Banking-as-a-Service capabilities, we support the digitization of shopkeepers by providing access to a bank account, a POS terminal, a payment gateway, a debit card, and a retail management system. We also enable value-added services, including mobile top-ups and bill payments. The objective is to build a comprehensive digital ecosystem for local merchants.

In 2025, Chari announced a major funding round. What is that capital for, and what are the key priorities going forward?

Ismael Belkhayat: Our priorities are very clear. First, we want to keep strengthening and scaling our Banking-as-a-Service business by deepening the product, the infrastructure, and the offering for our clients.

Second, we want to expand the tools we provide to digitize small shops. The ambition is to take a neighborhood store and help transform it into a local banking point where people can access everyday financial services.

We also expect to raise a future Series B to support the next phase of growth. Competing with banks requires sustained investment in product, infrastructure, and growth, and that is the purpose of the next financing cycle.

Your strategy appears strongly rooted in Morocco. Do you also see international expansion as part of Chari's next phase of growth?

Ismael Belkhayat: Yes, absolutely. We have already taken a first step internationally through the acquisition of Karny, a bookkeeping app that now serves six Francophone markets: Morocco, Tunisia, Senegal, Côte d'Ivoire, Cameroon, and the Democratic Republic of Congo. We focused on these markets because they share similar linguistic and market characteristics, which allows our Morocco-based team to support them efficiently.

Looking ahead, West Africa is an important market for us. We have already applied for a license in Côte d'Ivoire, and because the country is part of the BCEAO zone, that could help us extend our Banking-as-a-Service model beyond Morocco and into other Francophone markets in the region.

Based on your experience, how would you describe the licensing journey with Bank Al-Maghrib, and how has the process evolved for fintechs since then?

Ismael Belkhayat: When we started, the licensing process was highly complex and lengthy. In many ways, we helped pave the way. Today, the situation is much improved. Bank Al-Maghrib has adopted a more structured approach to fintech, with clearer processes and guidance for startups seeking licenses. Founders now have better visibility on the steps, requirements, and expectations involved, which makes the regulatory path more accessible than it was in the early days.

If Morocco aims to catch up with the continent's leading ecosystems, what are your recommendations for the ecosystem overall, including investors, regulators, and founders?

Ismael Belkhayat: Morocco's startup ecosystem moved relatively slowly between 2010 and 2025, but over the last two years it has started to accelerate. My conviction is that in the next three years, Morocco could make as much progress as it did in the previous fifteen.

To sustain that momentum, the ecosystem needs more institutions that actively support entrepreneurship, more VC funds, more capital deployed consistently into startups, and, most importantly, a few strong exits. Visible success stories create role models, recycle capital, and give both founders and investors more confidence in the market.

For founders, my advice is to look seriously at fintech. While this perspective is naturally influenced by my own experience as a fintech founder, I believe the sector remains one of the most compelling areas of opportunity within Morocco's startup ecosystem. A wide range of use cases is still underserved, and many of the models emerging in Europe and the United States could be adapted to the local market. Just as importantly, the enabling infrastructure is becoming more mature. With several Banking-as-a-Service players now active in Morocco, founders have more of the building blocks needed to launch efficiently, making this a particularly timely moment to build in the sector.

To conclude, do you have any final thoughts you would like to share about Morocco's startup ecosystem?

Ismael Belkhayat: I'm genuinely very optimistic about Morocco's startup ecosystem. Of course, today we are still behind markets like Egypt, Kenya, and Nigeria, but Morocco is catching up and moving in the right direction. I believe the coming years can be transformative for the ecosystem, and that Morocco has the potential to produce major success stories of its own.

Interview with

Omar Alami

Founder & CEO, ORA Technologies

Could you provide an overview of ORA, including the problem you are addressing and the solutions you have built to date?

Omar Alami: I founded ORA in January 2023 with a simple mission: "e-Morocco for everyone." Any Moroccan, whether in the city, countryside, or mountains, regardless of gender or social category, deserves access to e-commerce and digital payment.

We're building an ecosystem of day-to-day apps. At the core is ORA Cash, a universal mobile wallet: free instant transfers, QR merchant payments, and an IBAN in about 20 seconds. Fintech is the backbone because it secures cash collection. In Morocco, e-commerce is basically 100% cash-on-delivery, and food delivery is still mostly cash, so if you don't digitize the cash collection, you don't scale.

On top of that, we run Kooul (food delivery) and Cathedis (last-mile e-commerce). Kooul is live in six cities and we price for the real market: low commissions for restaurants, riders keep the delivery fee, and affordable menus so delivery is not just for social category A. Cathedis lets over 3,500 daily merchants and social sellers deliver nationwide in 24 hours.

Today, ORA has about 250 employees, 1,200 riders, around 250,000 parcels per month, and 30,000 monthly food orders. We raised $12M in three years, 100% Moroccan-funded. Most of our talent studied in Morocco. No complex: the ambition is to keep this journey Moroccan, especially because we're touching sensitive transactions and data.

2025 marked a significant acceleration for ORA, including a pre-Series A, a Series A, and the acquisition of Cathedis. What were the key drivers and decision points behind these milestones?

Omar Alami: 2025 was full of excitement. We launched Kooul in October 2024, then completed a pre-Series A to finance the relaunch. We saw hypergrowth, 20% to 30% month-over-month. Then the opportunity to acquire Cathedis came up, so we raised a $7.5M Series A at the ORA level rapidly. Cathedis is profitable, it de-risks the whole project, and investors were very keen to support.

But hypergrowth also means hyperchallenges, hiring, operations, customer management. Today we're proud to have three pillars, and we're preparing the fourth in the coming months.

Why did you choose an integrated model across fintech and delivery operations, and how do you ensure operational coherence across these business lines?

Omar Alami: Because use cases come first. Mobile wallets don't work when the only use case is cash-out: you digitize and you come back to cash. If you want digital payments to spread, you build the daily habits: food and e-commerce. Then you can ask people to change how they pay.

We even tried a "superapp" at the beginning, and we failed. A superapp is very hard to get adoption for in Morocco. You need day-to-day use apps, or you're dead. In Morocco, you either build something concrete for inclusion or you just pretend.

Operationally, each pillar is independent with one accountable leader. We don't have a pyramid; we run our company with responsibilities. That's how we decide fast. Sometimes we're wrong, sometimes we're right, but we never stay stuck.

What are ORA's strategic priorities for the next 12 to 24 months, particularly regarding geographic expansion and product development?

Omar Alami: In Morocco, Kooul needs to go from six cities to twelve. We're launching a brand-new version of the app soon with major UX and ops improvements. We also plan to raise $5M–$10M for Kooul's Series A, build a strong franchise, and scale internationally.

Internationally, we aim our first expansion to Europe. There are about six million Moroccans in Italy, Spain, France, Belgium, and the Netherlands, so we believe in a community-based approach: Moroccan supply, Moroccan users, Moroccan operations.

On Cathedis, we're at approximately 250,000 orders per month and aim for 350,000 to 400,000 by the end of the year, with a longer-term target of 1 million.

More broadly, e-commerce penetration in Morocco is still around 2.5%. We prepare ourselves for e-commerce transactions to increase fivefold by 2030. And on ORA Cash, the target is to digitize Cathedis' cash collection. I'll be honest: we haven't yet been able to find the right product to bank the underbanked and unbanked easily and cheaply. We're working on a new product that should get launched soon.

You have emphasized digital sovereignty as a guiding principle. How do you define it operationally, and what capabilities does Morocco still need to strengthen to achieve it?

Omar Alami: Digital sovereignty is your cloud, your data centers, your tech talent, your fundraising, but most importantly, your own data collection tools. My journey is also about securing user data collection: what you eat, what you spend, what you buy. It has to be Moroccan. Even if your servers are local, if a foreign actor collects much more data than you, your digital sovereignty is still missing.

Digital sovereignty is a matter of decision and leadership. The institutional support is there. Ministries, regulators, financial institutions, everyone is pushing for the Moroccan Digital 2030 transformation. The last mile is us, founders, and private investors. We need to build the use cases as part of sovereign infrastructure and sovereign tools for data collection.

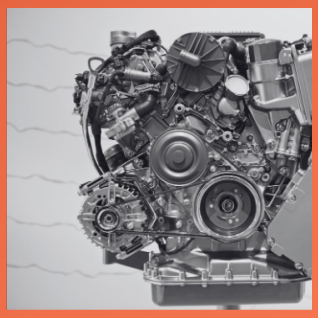
When Morocco decides something, we do it. We decided to have a high-speed train, we had it. Stadiums for the Africa Cup of Nations before the World Cup—done. Highways, industrialization, aeronautics—done. Digital sovereignty will also be achieved.

From your experience, what have been the primary challenges in building and scaling ORA in Morocco?

Omar Alami: Challenges? There are no challenges. I'm a bit contrarian. For tech, we're in the right place, at the right moment, with the right people. Morocco is moving faster than anyone else, including us. Morocco has the advantage of a developed country when it comes to political and macroeconomic stability, and the growth potential of an emerging country. When you see an emerging country that is this stable, it's a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity. I'm sorry; I could not be more positive about Morocco.

What guidance would you offer to founders building in Morocco, based on your experience scaling ORA?

Omar Alami: The ecosystem is boiling, yes. But it has to be impactful: address concrete needs in the deep market. And build for the majority, not just the privileged Morocco. That's my last word.



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Founder Demographics and Inclusion

Founder profiles and leadership insights

Understanding who founds the Moroccan startups that successfully attract capital is a prerequisite to understanding how the ecosystem is structured and where its next generation of funded operators is likely to come from. Drawing on a sample of 98 founders behind the 47 Moroccan startups that raised funding in 2025, this subsection profiles the demographic, educational, and professional characteristics of the individuals behind the cohort of companies currently attracting investor capital. The picture that emerges is of a mid-career, experience-heavy, and increasingly repeat-founder population, with profiles that challenge the prevailing narrative of a young, undergraduate-driven ecosystem.

At a glance

91%
Aged 30 to 50

85%
Hold a graduate degree

44%
CS/Data/AI or Engineering trained

49%
Currently serve as CEO

80%
5+ years pre-founding experience

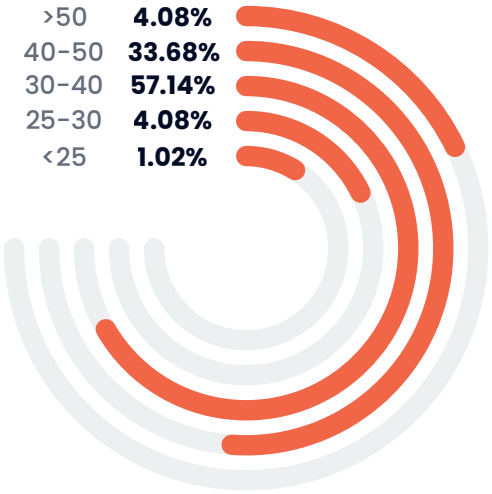
52%
Founded from senior leadership roles

55%
Serial founders

45%
Two-co-founder teams

Age and career stage

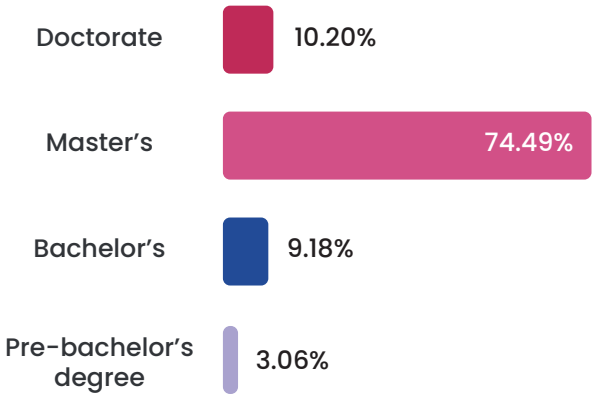
Founders of Moroccan startups are firmly positioned in mid-career. Among the profiled sample, 90.82% fall between the ages of 30 and 50, with 57.14% in the 30-to-40 bracket and 33.68% between 40 and 50. Founders under 30 account for only 5.10% of the sample, while those above 50 represent an additional 4.08%. The distribution points to a launch window that typically opens after roughly a decade of professional experience rather than directly out of university, a pattern that has implications for the type of ventures that emerge and for the infrastructure required to support them.



Age Distribution of Moroccan Startup Founders

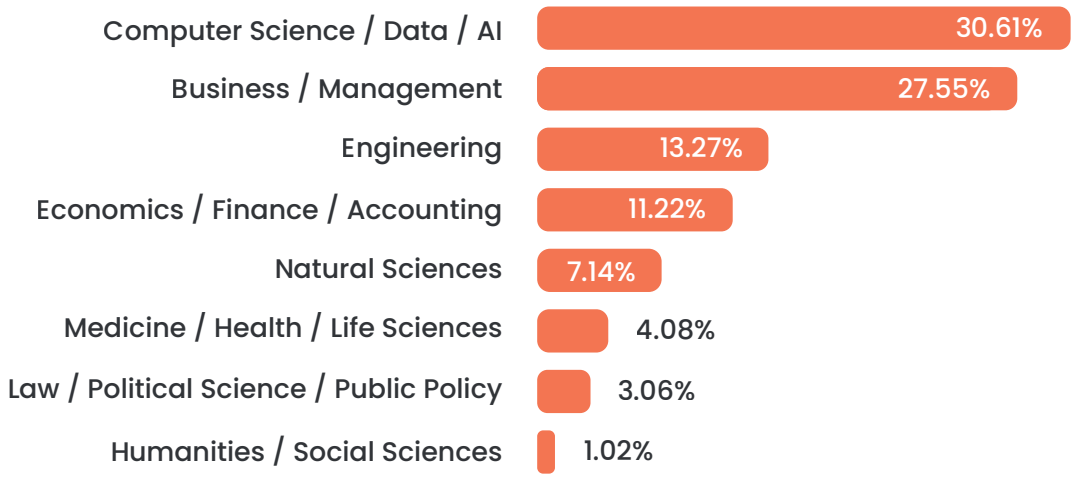
Educational foundation

Founders of Moroccan startups that raised funding in 2025 are academically credentialed. Nearly three quarters of the sample hold a Master's degree as their highest qualification, with an additional 10.20% holding a doctorate. Only 9.18% have stopped at a bachelor's, and 3.06% at a pre-bachelor level. Taken together, 84.69% of profiled founders carry a graduate-level degree, a proportion well above the national average and consistent with the strong association between formal education and entry into venture creation observed in the Moroccan context.



Highest Academic Degree

The distribution by field of study reinforces the technical and business orientation of the ecosystem. Computer Science, data, and AI is the single largest field at 30.61%, followed closely by Business and Management at 27.55%. Engineering accounts for 13.27%, and Economics, Finance, or Accounting for 11.22%. Combined, Computer Science, data, AI, and Engineering represent 43.88% of the sample, while business-adjacent disciplines represent a further 38.78%. Natural sciences, medicine and life sciences, law and public policy, and humanities and social sciences collectively account for 15.31%, signaling limited representation of founders trained in regulated or research-driven disciplines.



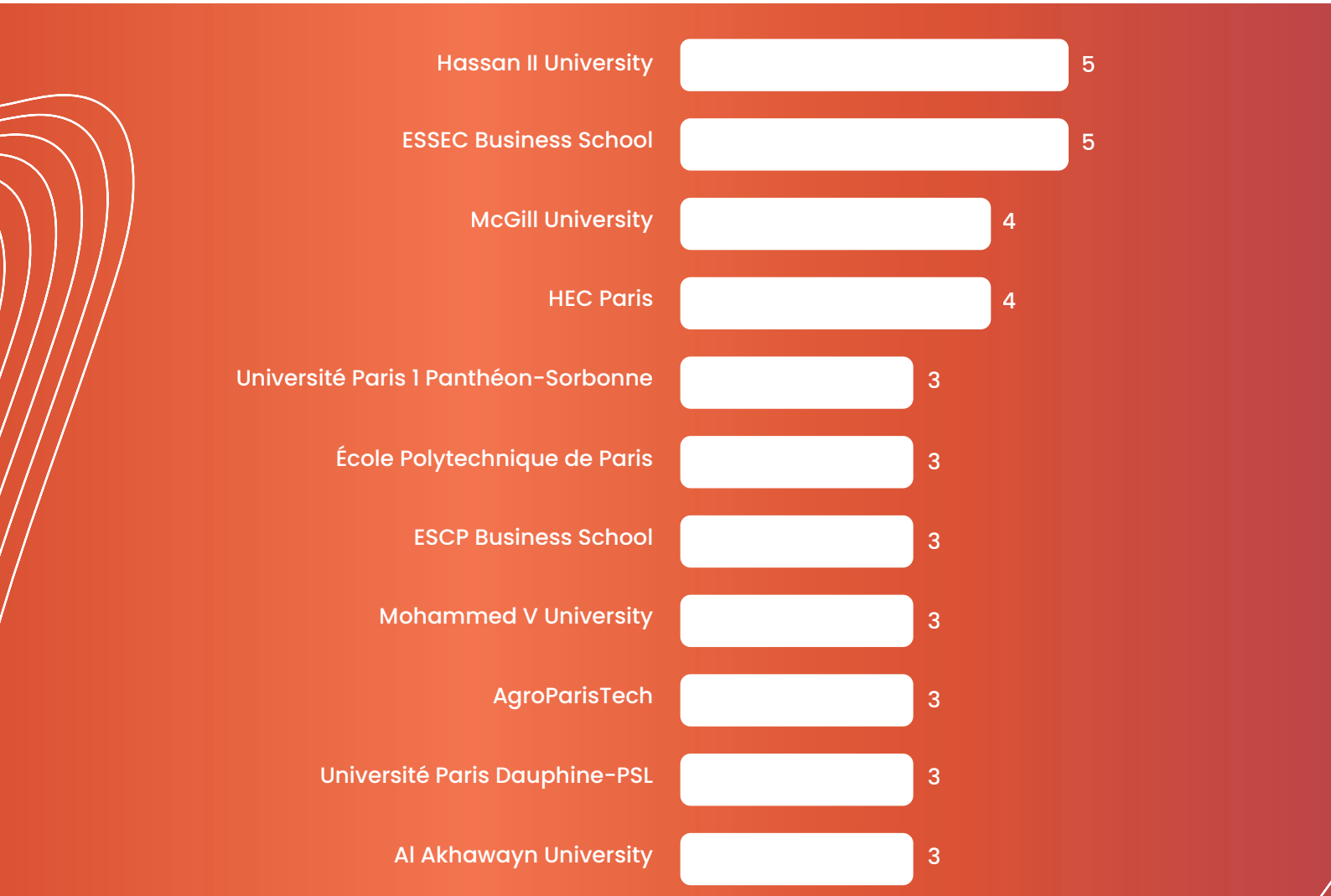
Primary Field of Study

Academic origins: top feeder institutions

Beyond degree level and field of study, the specific institutions that train founders offer a useful secondary lens on the ecosystem's talent pipeline. Across the sample, 167 distinct institution affiliations were recorded against 122 unique institutions, with most founders reporting more than one (a common sequence is a first degree from one institution followed by a graduate degree from another).

Hassan II University in Casablanca and ESSEC Business School are tied as the most frequent affiliations, with five mentions each. McGill University in Montreal and HEC Paris each appear in four founder profiles, and a further seven institutions (Université Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne, École Polytechnique de Paris, ESCP Business School, Mohammed V University, AgroParisTech, Al Akhawayn University, and Université Paris Dauphine-PSL) each record three. These eleven institutions together account for 23.35% of all recorded affiliations, representing the core cluster from which a disproportionate share of Moroccan venture talent has emerged.

Below this cluster, the feeder landscape is highly fragmented. A further 17 institutions appear in exactly two founder profiles, and the remaining 94 appear only once. In aggregate, roughly 77.05% of institutions mentioned have produced a single founder in the sample, which points to a feeder ecosystem that is concentrated at the very top but otherwise dispersed across a long tail of academic backgrounds. The geographic dimension of these institutional origins, including the split between domestic and foreign schooling and the role of diaspora networks in founder education, is developed in the diaspora section of this report.

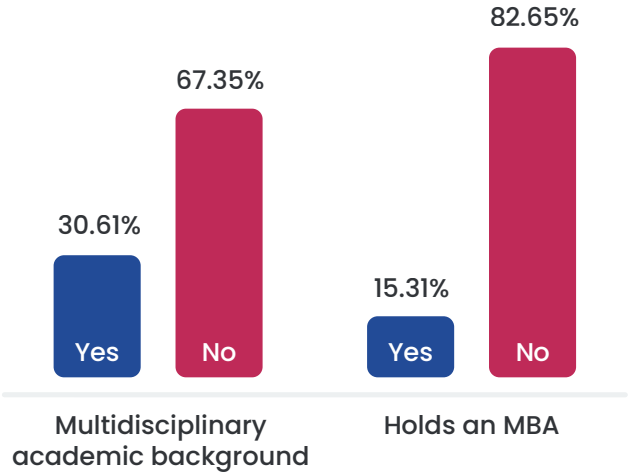


Top Feeder Institutions

Credential breadth: multidisciplinarity and the MBA

Despite the high academic credentials, founders of Moroccan startups tend to specialize rather than diversify their training. Only 30.61% of the sample report a multidisciplinary academic background, meaning a formal combination of fields such as engineering and management, or science and policy. The remaining 67.35% have progressed through a single academic track. MBA penetration is similarly modest: only 15.31% of founders hold an MBA.

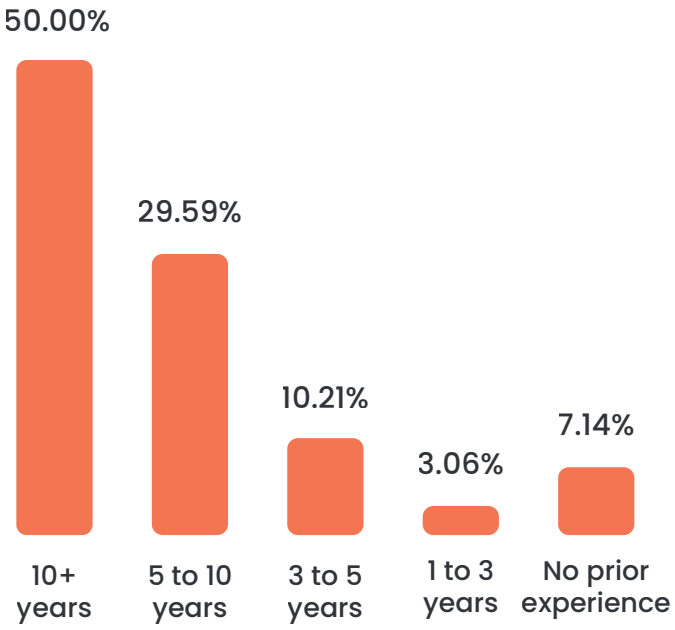
The implication is twofold. First, the Moroccan ecosystem produces founders with deep rather than broad formal training, which may compress time-to-competence in a technical or functional domain but can limit early-stage capacity in adjacent disciplines such as finance, operations, or governance. Second, the MBA does not operate as a standard on-ramp into entrepreneurship in Morocco, in contrast to advanced markets where formal management education is a recognized founder pathway.



Credential Breadth: Multidisciplinarity and MBA Prevalence

Pre-founding professional experience

The experience profile of founders backed in 2025 is pronounced. 79.59% of the sample entered entrepreneurship with five or more years of prior full-time work experience, and 50% had accumulated at least a decade before founding. Only 13.27% founded within the first five years of their career, and a further 7.14% are recorded as having no prior full-time employment. The funded cohort is therefore not primarily populated by founders who stepped into venture creation at the start of their working lives.

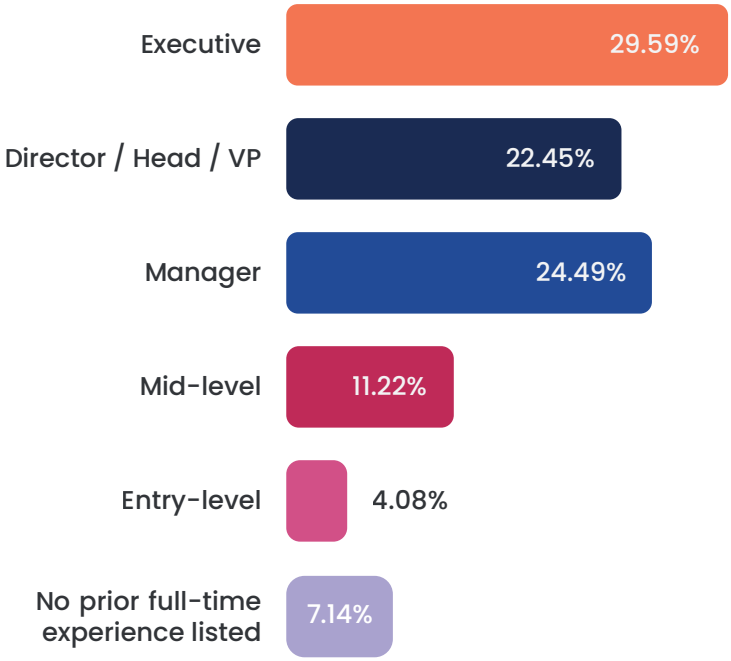


Years of Pre-founding Work Experience

« What is especially striking today is the evolution in the profile of Moroccan founders and venture teams. We are seeing more complementary teams, stronger sector expertise, and more people making a deliberate decision to leave comfortable corporate careers to build startups. That is a major shift from a decade ago, when the ecosystem was still dominated by young graduates tackling small local problems or service companies trying to pivot into product. This change is directly improving the quality of deal flow and is one of the clearest signals that the Moroccan ecosystem is maturing. »

Sidi Mohammed Zakraoui
Partner at EmergingTech Ventures

Seniority reinforces the same signal. At the time of founding, 29.59% of profiled founders had reached executive roles within their prior organization, and a further 22.45% held director, head-of-function, or vice-president positions. Combined, 52.04% of founders in the sample transitioned into venture creation from a senior leadership seat. An additional 24.49% moved from manager-level roles, and only 15.31% founded from mid-level or entry-level positions. The decision to found is, in aggregate, made after reaching substantive organizational responsibility, not before it.



Seniority Level Reached Before Founding

Functional background

The functional origins of founders are relatively balanced, with a slight tilt toward technical and operational disciplines. Engineering and technology represents the single largest feeder function at 20.41%, followed by Operations at 19.39% and Sales or Business Development at 17.35%. Strategy or Consulting and Marketing or Growth each account for 10.20% of the sample, and Finance or Investment for 8.16%. Product, legal, and research backgrounds collectively represent 7.14%.

The composition is consistent with a Moroccan ecosystem whose venture activity is concentrated in software, fintech, e-commerce, and logistics, which typically draw founders from technology, operations, and commercial backgrounds. The limited representation of product and research functions is notable and likely reflects both a thin domestic talent pipeline for product management and the still-early stage of deep-tech and research-driven venture activity in the country.

Primary Functional Background Before Founding

Serial versus first-time founders

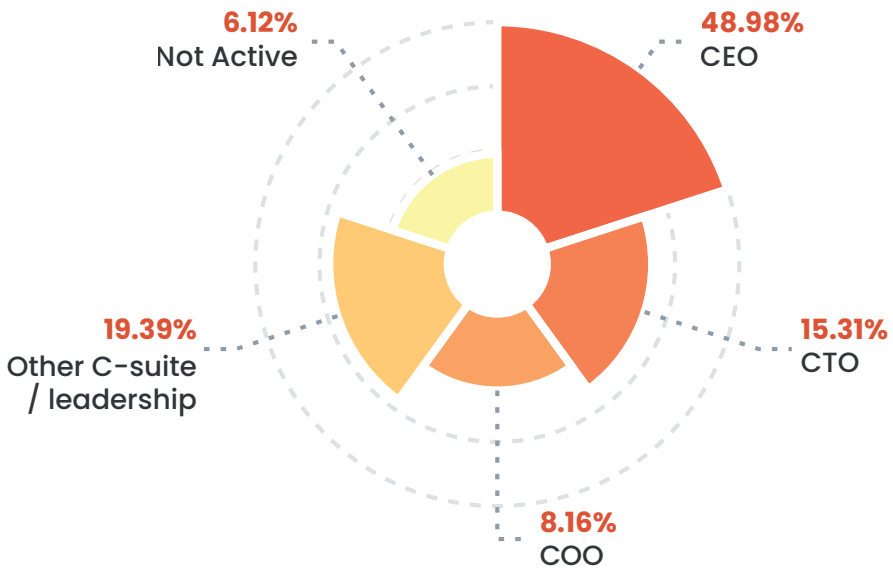
55.10% of profiled founders had prior founder experience at the time of launching their current venture, meaning a majority of the 2025-funded founder population is building from a second or later attempt. First-time founders represent the remaining 44.90%. The serial share is meaningful, and arguably underappreciated as an ecosystem signal. It suggests that investors in Morocco are backing founders who have cycled through at least one earlier company, that a growing body of founder experience is being recycled into the ecosystem rather than lost after an initial venture winds down, and that the first-time founder pathway to institutional capital remains the harder one to travel.

For investors, the implication is a larger pool of founders with hands-on operating history. For policymakers and program designers, the signal is that founder support should be calibrated to experience level, with differentiated programming for first-time founders building from zero and for repeat founders scaling a second or third venture.

Prior Founder Experience: Serial vs First-time Founders

Current leadership role within the venture

Almost half of the profiled founders hold the CEO title in their current venture. A further 15.31% serve as CTO and 8.16% as COO, with an additional 19.39% occupying other C-suite or senior leadership roles, including CPO, CFO, CRO, and equivalent positions. 6.12% of founders are recorded as no longer active in the venture they co-founded. Taken together, 91.84% of profiled founders remain in an executive leadership seat within the company they founded. This is typical of early- to growth-stage companies but may evolve as ventures scale and professional management layers are introduced.



Current Leadership Role Within the Venture

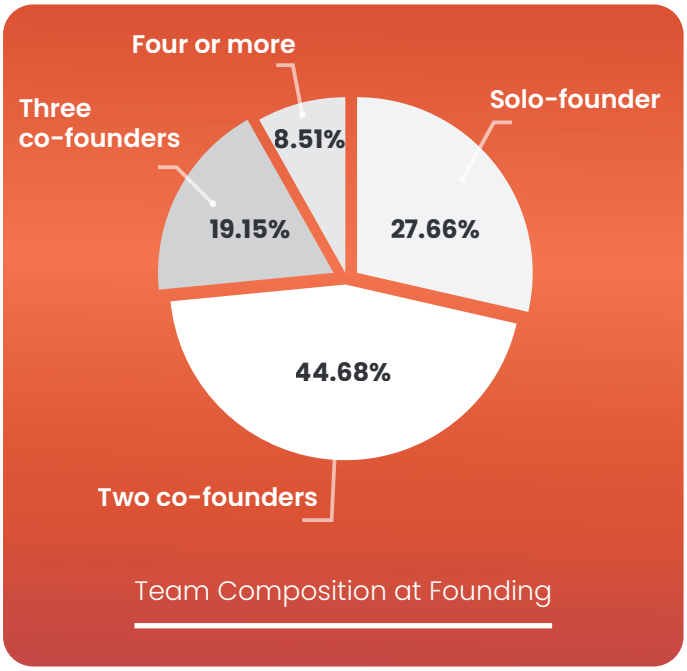
Team composition at founding

The 98 profiled founders represent the full set of 47 Moroccan startups that raised funding in 2025, for an average of 2.09 founders per company. The modal configuration is the two-founder team, which accounts for 44.68% of startups in the sample (21 ventures). Solo founders represent 27.66% (13 ventures), three-founder teams 19.15% (9 ventures), and teams of four or more 8.51% (4 ventures). Viewed from the other direction, 86.73% of profiled founders build alongside at least one co-founder, and 42.86% do so specifically in a two-founder partnership.

The distribution sits close to international benchmarks, where the two-founder team is consistently the most common configuration among venture-backed companies. The relatively high share of solo founders in the Moroccan sample is worth flagging. Solo founding carries a well-documented structural disadvantage in early-stage funding and is often associated with thinner operational capacity during the pre-product-market-fit phase. The pattern may reflect the still-limited density of the domestic operator network, which constrains the pool of complementary co-founders available to any given founder at launch. It may also reflect a tendency, specific to the region, for first-generation entrepreneurs to launch on their own before bringing complementary talent into the cap table at a later stage.

« The team is everything. Anyone can have a bright idea, but not everyone can bring it to life. So a smart but resilient team with, if possible, a good academic and professional background, can make the difference. Most of the startups, at some point, will have to pivot and adapt to the rapidly evolving technologies. And that is why, the team is everything. »

Driss Laraki
Founder and Managing Partner at U-Investors



Team Composition at Founding

Composite portrait

Synthesizing across the dimensions above, the typical founder behind a Moroccan startup that raised funding in 2025 is a professional aged 30 to 50, holding a Master's degree in a technical or business discipline, with five or more years of pre-founding experience most often at senior or director level, a single rather than multidisciplinary academic background, no MBA, and a better-than-even chance of having founded before. The venture is most commonly launched alongside one co-founder, and current responsibilities cluster in the CEO or CTO seat.

This composite carries concrete implications for how the ecosystem should be supported. The investors active in Morocco in 2025 have clearly gravitated toward experienced operators rather than first-jobs-out-of-university talent, which means capital, advisory programs, and infrastructure designed for that profile will find a receptive audience, while programming aimed at earlier-stage or less experienced founders will need to work harder to bridge the gap to institutional capital. Founder development work should focus less on basic entrepreneurship literacy and more on the areas where the funded Moroccan cohort is structurally thinner, namely cross-disciplinary management exposure, product and research functions, access to complementary co-founder talent, and the governance capabilities associated with scaling beyond founder-led leadership. The concentrated but fragmented institutional feeder landscape also suggests a strategic opening for domestic universities and business schools willing to build a dedicated founder-producing track.

Diversity metrics across gender

Gender representation shapes both the pipeline of founders entering the Moroccan ecosystem and the profile of the ventures that get funded. This subsection profiles the gender composition of the same sample of 98 founders described in the Founder profiles and leadership insights subsection, and examines how male and female founders compare across the same dimensions of age, education, pre-founding experience, and current leadership role. Because the sample is drawn from the set of startups that successfully attracted investor capital in 2025, the findings below describe not only who founds in Morocco but, more specifically, who gets funded. Given the small absolute number of female founders in the sample, cross-cuts are presented as indicative shares within each gender group rather than as statistically definitive comparisons.

At a glance

15%
Of profiled founders are women

26%
Of startups have at least one female founder

74%
Of startups are all-male teams

47%
Of female founders hold the CEO title

27%
Of female founders serve as COO

13%
Of female founders trained in CS/Data/AI

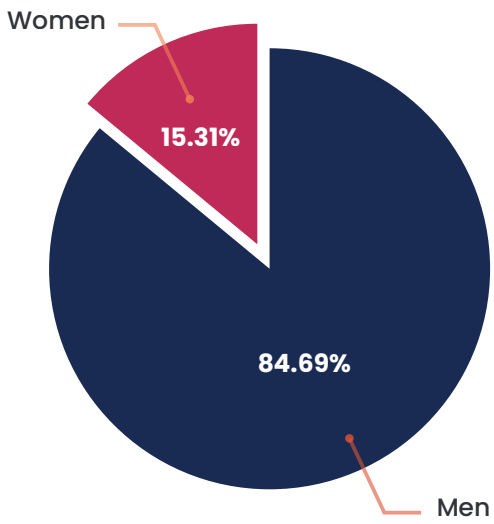
40%
Of female founders reached senior leadership

67%
Of female founders are first-time founders

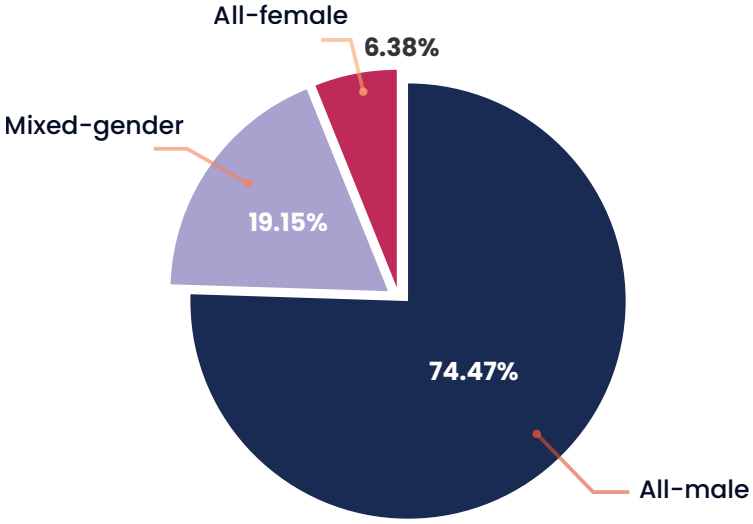
Aggregate gender distribution

At the founder level, 15 of 98 profiled founders are women, representing 15.31% of the 2025 funding cohort, with men accounting for the remaining 84.69%. At the startup level, 12 of 47 profiled startups include at least one female founder. Of these, 9 are mixed-gender teams and 3 are all-female teams. The remaining 35 startups were founded exclusively by men.

The gap between the founder-level and startup-level figures is worth noting. Women are concentrated in a smaller number of ventures, with the 15 female founders spread across 12 startups for an average of 1.25 women per startup. Men are distributed across the 44 startups that include at least one male founder, for an average of 1.89 men per such startup. The structural implication is that women are more likely to be in smaller founding teams, often paired with a single male co-founder in the mixed-gender configuration.



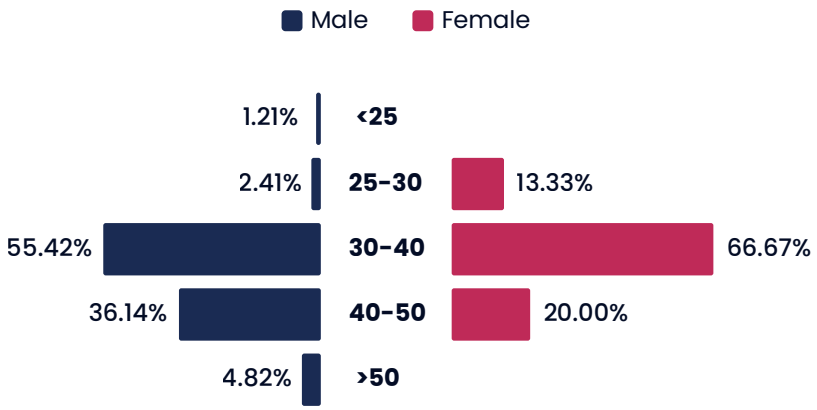
Founder-level Composition



Startup-level Team Composition

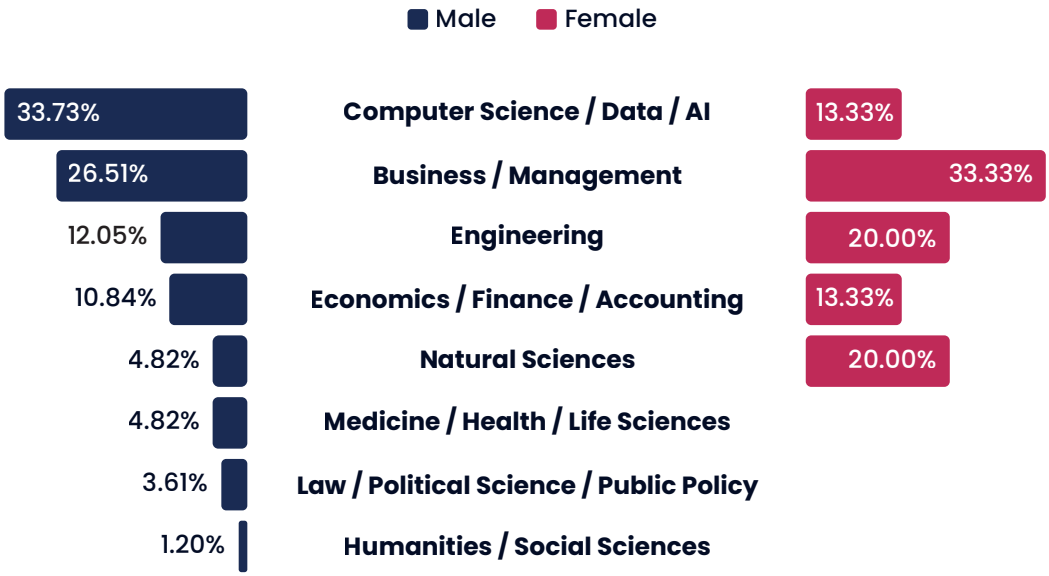
Age and educational profile

Female founders skew younger than their male counterparts. Two thirds of women in the sample are in the 30-to-40 age bracket, compared with 55.42% of men. A further 13.33% of women are in the 25-to-30 bracket, against only 2.41% of men. At the upper end, 20% of women fall in the 40-to-50 bracket versus 36.14% of men, and no women in the sample are above 50, against 4.82% of men. The younger age profile is consistent with the experience and seniority patterns discussed below.



Age Distribution by Gender

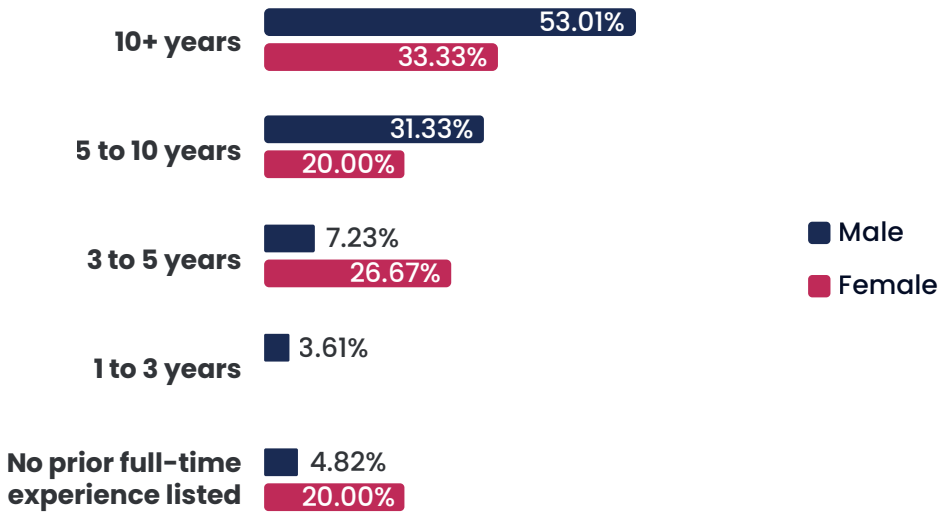
Educational attainment is broadly comparable across the two groups. Master's degrees are the most common qualification for both, held by 74.70% of men and 73.33% of women, while doctorate holders account for 9.64% of men and 13.33% of women. The more consequential divergence appears in the field of study. Computer Science, data, and AI, which is the single largest field among men at 33.73%, accounts for only 13.33% of female founders. Business and Management is slightly more prevalent among women, at 33.33% versus 26.51% for men. Natural Sciences is also markedly more prevalent among women, at 20.00% versus 4.82% for men, as is Engineering, at 20.00% versus 12.05%. The combined representation across CS/Data/AI, Engineering, and Natural Sciences is therefore broadly comparable across genders, but the composition differs substantially, with men concentrated in Computer Science and AI and women distributed more across engineering and natural sciences.



Primary Field of Study by Gender

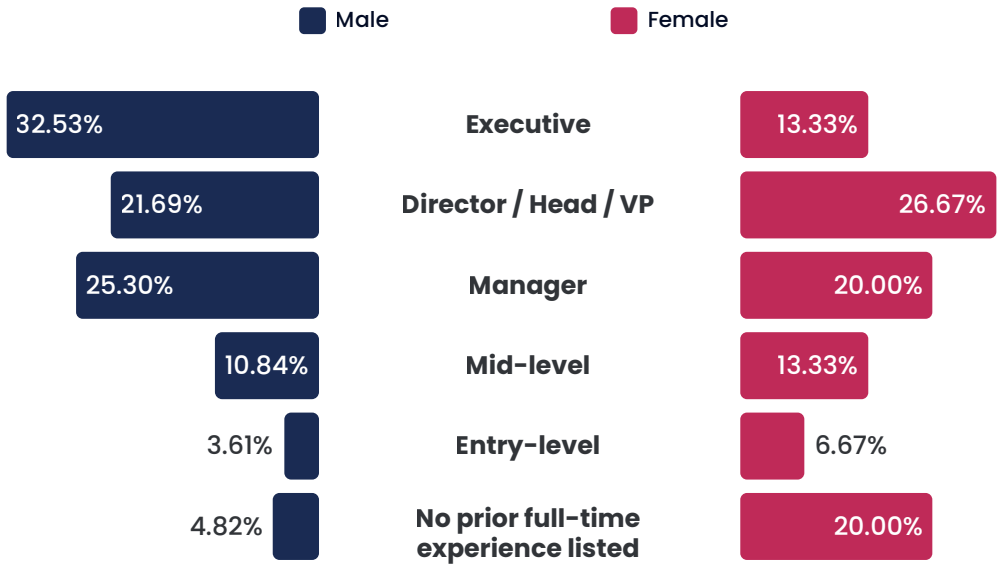
Pre-founding experience and seniority

Consistent with the younger age profile, women in the sample enter founding with less pre-founding professional experience on average. One third of female founders (33.33%) have 10 or more years of prior work experience, compared with 53.01% of male founders. At the other end of the distribution, 20% of female founders are recorded as having no prior full-time employment, against 4.82% of men.



Years of Pre-founding Work Experience by Gender

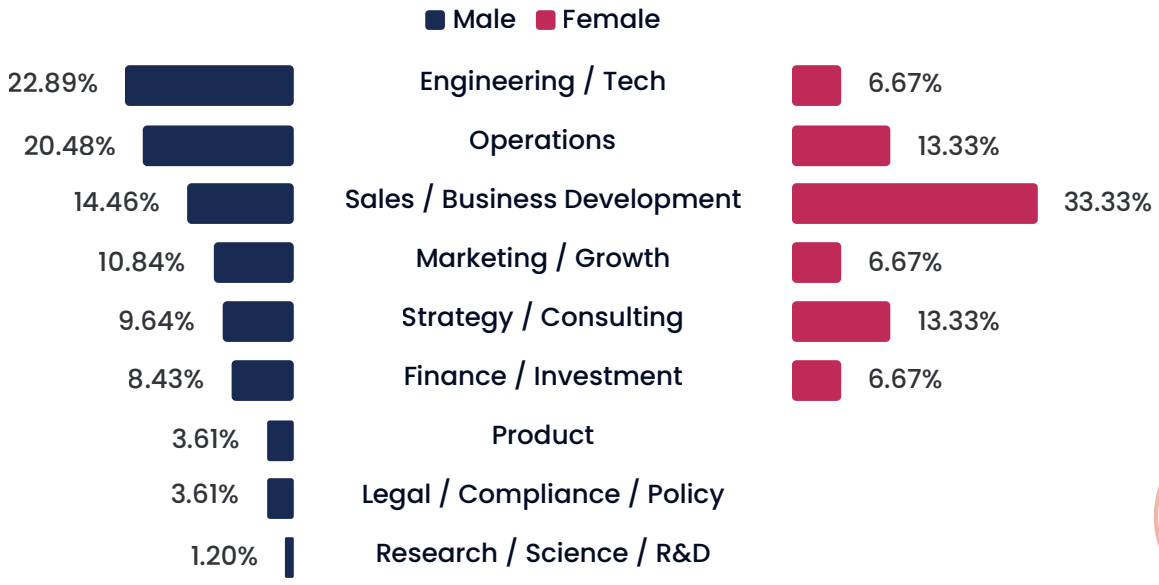
Seniority reached before founding reflects the same pattern. Only 13.33% of female founders reached an executive-level role before launching their venture, compared with 32.53% of men. The director, head-of-function, or vice-president tier is more balanced, with 26.67% of women and 21.69% of men reaching that level. Combined, 40% of female founders transitioned into venture creation from a senior leadership seat, against 54.22% of men. The gap is meaningful but narrower than the executive-level figure alone would suggest.



Seniority Reached Before Founding by Gender

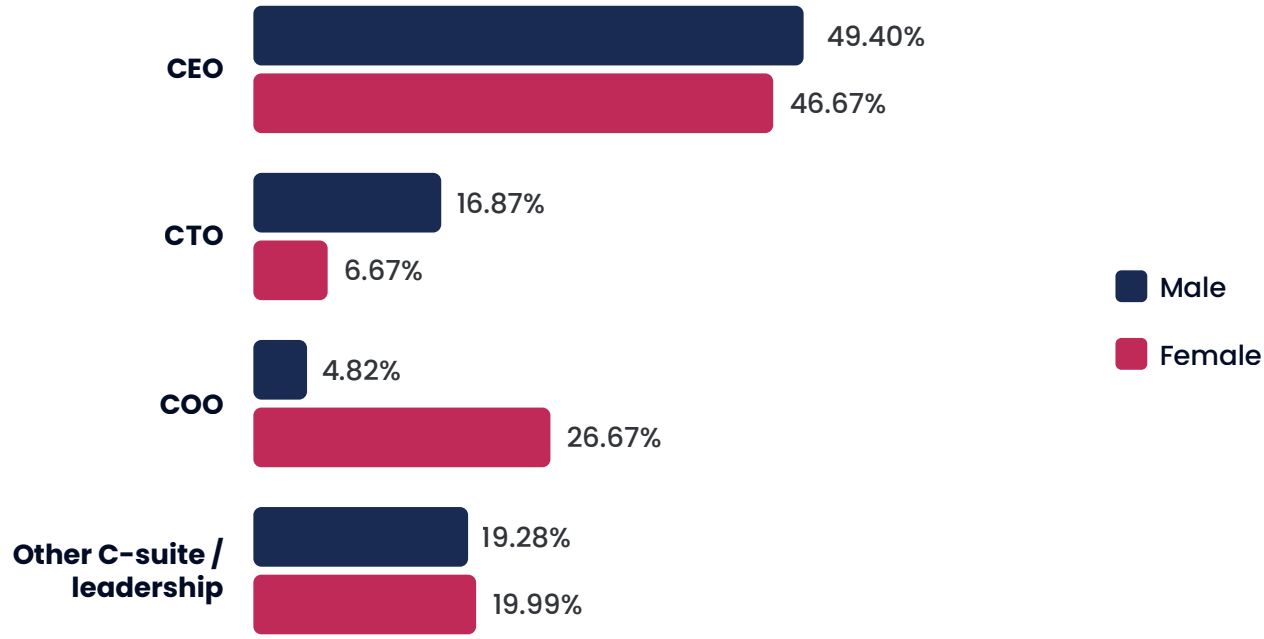
Functional background and current leadership role

Pre-founding functional backgrounds differ significantly by gender. Sales or Business Development is the most common functional background for women, accounting for 33.33% of female founders compared with 14.46% of men. Engineering and technology, the leading function for men at 22.89%, accounts for only 6.67% of female founders. Operations is the second most common function for both groups (20.48% of men, 13.33% of women), and Strategy or Consulting is represented at broadly similar rates (9.64% of men, 13.33% of women).



Pre-founding Functional Background by Gender

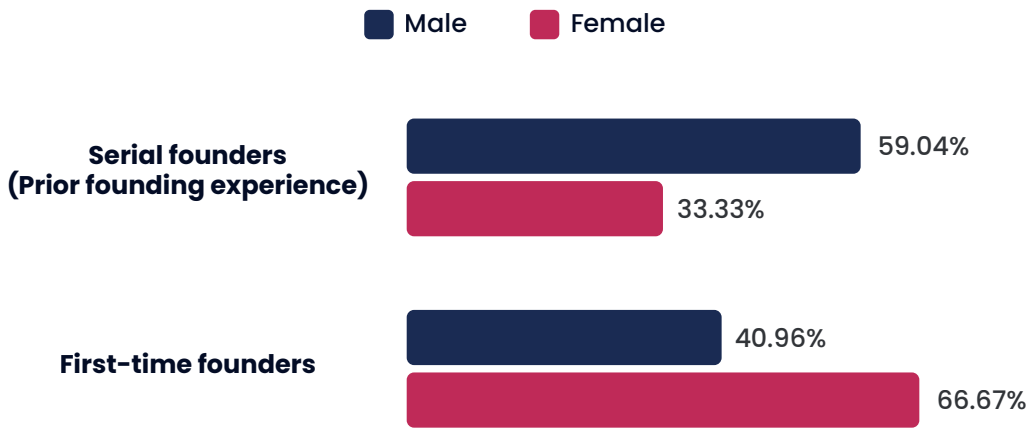
Parity appears most visibly in the current leadership role distribution. Half of male founders and 46.67% of female founders currently serve as CEO of the venture they founded. The clearest divergence is in the COO seat, which is held by 26.67% of female founders but only 4.82% of male founders, a marked overrepresentation of women in the operating-leadership role. Conversely, 16.87% of male founders serve as CTO against only 6.67% of female founders, consistent with the Computer Science and AI field-of-study gap noted earlier. Other C-suite and senior leadership roles, a catch-all covering CPO, CFO, CRO, and similar titles, are held at near-equal rates across genders (19.28% of men, 19.99% of women).



Current Leadership Role by Gender

Prior founder experience

Two thirds of female founders in the sample are first-time founders, compared with 40.96% of male founders. Put differently, only one third of women have prior founder experience, against 59.04% of men. The ecosystem's female founder population is therefore predominantly first-generation, which has practical implications for access to founder networks, investor relationships, and the accumulated playbooks that serial founders carry from earlier attempts.



Prior Founder Experience by Gender

Synthesis

Taken together, the data tells a layered story. The Moroccan startups that raised funding in 2025 were founded by a heavily male population, with women representing 15.31% of profiled founders and nearly three quarters of funded startups founded exclusively by men. Because the sample reflects funding outcomes rather than the full universe of Moroccan entrepreneurial activity, these aggregate figures describe the composition of capital-backed ventures specifically, and should be read as a signal about who is reaching investors rather than about who is starting companies more broadly. Where women do secure funding, however, they achieve parity on the most visible leadership metric, with CEO titles held at essentially equal rates across genders.

Within the funded cohort, the differences between male and female founders appear most clearly in age, years of pre-founding experience, seniority reached, and functional background, all of which describe founder profiles before or at the point of company formation rather than funding outcomes alone. Female founders in the 2025 cohort skew younger, are earlier in career, and are concentrated in commercial rather than technical functional tracks. The serial founder gap is the most pronounced of these differences: 66.67% of female founders in the cohort are launching for the first time, compared with 40.96% of male founders. Because this analysis is limited to founders who successfully raised funding in 2025, it cannot speak to the dynamics that shape who reaches that stage in the first place, nor to the question of whether and how these gaps close over time. What the data does show is a clear difference in profile composition between male and female founders within the funded cohort, which is itself a useful baseline against which future cohorts can be measured.

Methodology note

Sample. *Founder profiles were compiled from public professional profiles, company disclosures, and primary outreach. The sample covers the 98 individual founders behind the 47 Moroccan startups that closed a funding round in 2025. It therefore represents the subset of the Moroccan ecosystem currently attracting investor capital rather than the full universe of active Moroccan startups, and findings should be read with this scope in mind.*

Data coverage. *Coverage across the attributes reported ranges between 96.94% and 100%. For readability, charts do not display "Not Available" categories. These observations remain included in the overall sample totals and percentage denominators. As a result, some charts may not visually sum to 100%. Where a category is marked "Not applicable," this reflects cases where the attribute does not apply, most often founders with no prior full-time employment history, rather than missing data. Institution-level statistics are expressed as shares of the 167 recorded institution mentions.*

Gender coding. *Gender was coded as male or female using publicly available information, including names, photographs, and pronouns on professional profiles. Coverage on gender is 100%. Given the small absolute female sample of 15 founders, gender cross-cut percentages are indicative rather than statistically robust, and findings should be read as patterns to monitor rather than conclusions to generalize.*

Attribution. *Attributes are self-reported through public sources. All figures in this section draw on the same underlying dataset, and percentages across the founder profile and gender analysis are directly comparable.*

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The Moroccan Diaspora as a Catalyst for Startup Development

Understanding the international footprint of founders of Moroccan startups matters because the country's venture activity has long been shaped by the movement of talent between Morocco and abroad. This section examines the same sample of 98 founders behind the 47 Moroccan startups that raised funding in 2025, focusing specifically on their academic and professional exposure outside Morocco. A direct census of diaspora-linked founders is not possible using public data. Nationality, residency, and identity-based ties to Morocco or its diaspora cannot be determined reliably from professional profiles, and any attempt to assign founders to a "diaspora" or "non-diaspora" category would rest on assumptions that the underlying data does not support. This section therefore takes an indirect approach. It uses two observable signals, where a founder studied and where a founder worked before launching their current venture, as proxies for the kind of international academic and professional exposure typically associated with diaspora experience. The analysis describes patterns of exposure rather than identities, and should be read as a structural lens on how founders move through foreign academic and professional systems, not as a claim about who is or is not part of a diaspora.

At a glance

78%
Studied outside Morocco at some stage

69%
Worked outside Morocco before founding

66%
Have both foreign studies and work experience

18%
Purely domestic academic and professional profile

63%
Studied exclusively in international institutions

55%
Of foreign-study mentions are in France

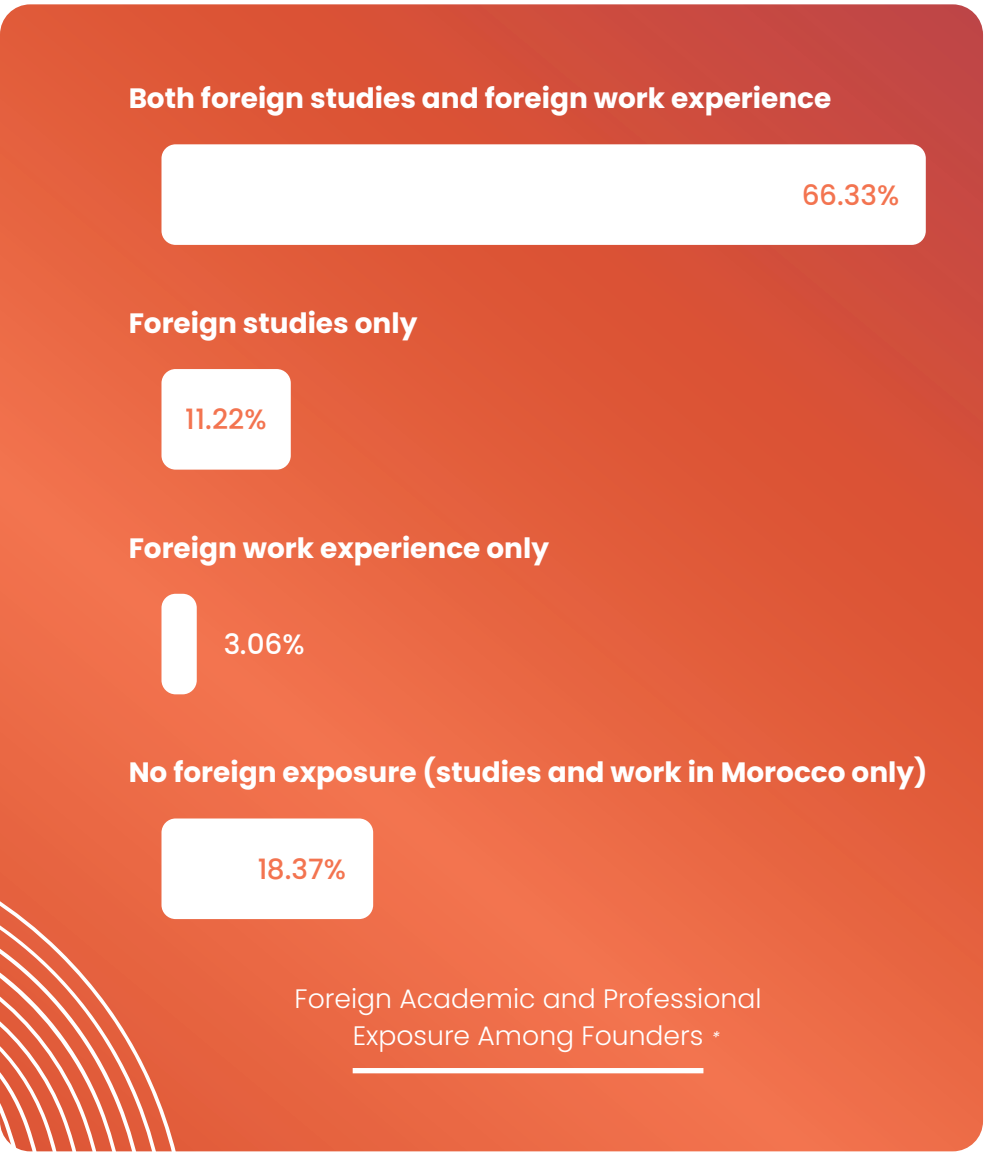
41%
Of foreign-work mentions are in France

70%
Of foreign geographies mentioned are European

The scale of foreign academic and professional exposure

Foreign exposure is the norm rather than the exception among founders who raised funding in 2025. 66.33% of profiled founders have both studied and worked outside Morocco at some point before launching their current venture. An additional 11.22% have studied abroad without having worked abroad, while 3.06% have confirmed foreign work experience without confirmed foreign academic exposure. Taken together, 80.61% of the sample have some observed form of foreign academic or professional exposure, and only 18.37% have a purely domestic profile with both studies and pre-founding work experience confined to Morocco.

The implications are meaningful. Founders backed in 2025 overwhelmingly arrive at founding with international credentials, international professional networks, or both. This pattern likely reflects two converging dynamics. The first is the long-standing pipeline of Moroccan students moving through foreign universities, particularly French Grandes Écoles, a pattern already visible in the top feeder institutions discussed in the previous section. The second is the return, either permanent or circular, of Moroccan professionals who built early-career experience in foreign markets before launching ventures at home. Whether these founders are best described as "returning diaspora," "cross-border operators," or simply "internationally trained Moroccans" is a question this data cannot answer, but the scale of foreign exposure itself is unambiguous.



Foreign Academic and Professional Exposure Among Founders *

« Morocco has the talent, a powerful diaspora, and the ability to build locally while selling globally. After several years of active investing, the shift is clear: founders now come with products, early customers, and real traction. At that stage, capital alone is not differentiating. What matters is experience, strategic guidance, and access to networks to accelerate decisions and avoid costly mistakes. Startups must move fast, think global from day one, and structure to meet international investment standards. The fundamentals are here. The mindset is changing. The time is now. »

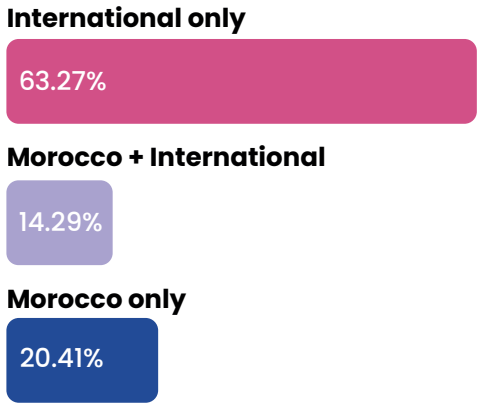
Ilan Benhaim
Co-founder and President at MFOUNDERS

** Unavailable observations remain included in the denominator but are not displayed.*

Education and work geography profiles

Breaking the exposure pattern into its two component dimensions brings the scale into sharper relief. On the education side, 63.27% of founders received their academic training exclusively in international institutions, 14.29% were trained in a combination of Moroccan and international institutions, and 20.41% were educated exclusively in Morocco. Put differently, 77.55% of profiled founders have some international academic exposure, and the modal profile is an education track located entirely outside the country.

On the professional side, 69.39% of founders accumulated work experience outside Morocco before launching their current venture, while 30.61% built their pre-founding career entirely within the country. The roughly eight-point gap between the foreign-study share and the foreign-work share is worth noting. It suggests that international exposure is acquired more frequently through higher education than through subsequent professional mobility, and that a non-trivial number of founders who studied abroad chose to build their professional careers in Morocco.

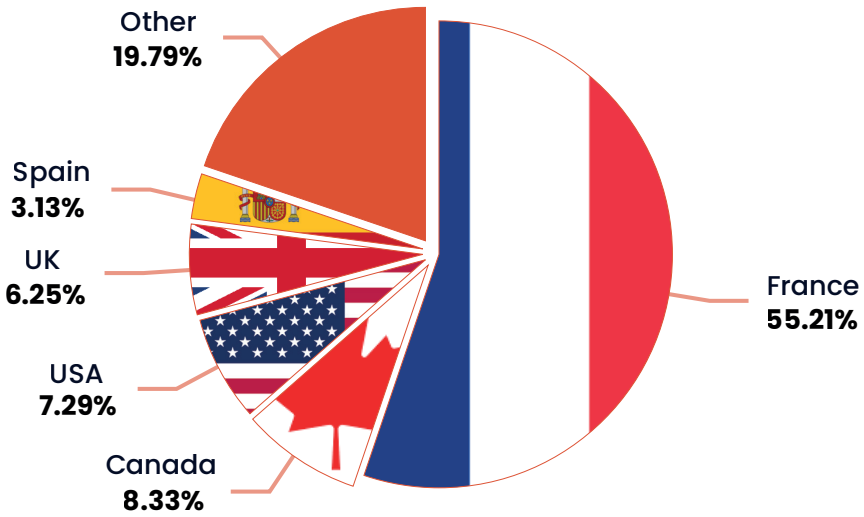


Education Geography Profile *

Pre-founding Work Experience Location *

Geographic destinations

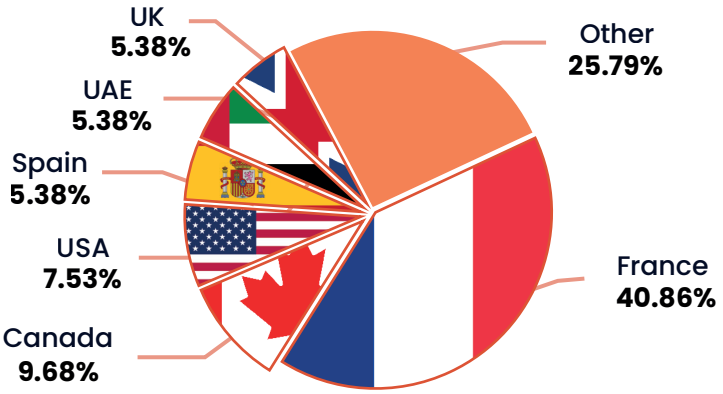
The geography of foreign exposure is heavily concentrated on a small number of countries. Among the 76 founders with foreign academic exposure, 96 foreign-study country mentions were recorded. France is by a wide margin the most frequent destination with 53 founder mentions, accounting for 55.21% of all foreign-study mentions recorded in the sample. Canada follows with 8 mentions (8.33%), the United States with 7 mentions (7.29%), the United Kingdom with 6 mentions (6.25%), and Spain with 3 mentions (3.13%).



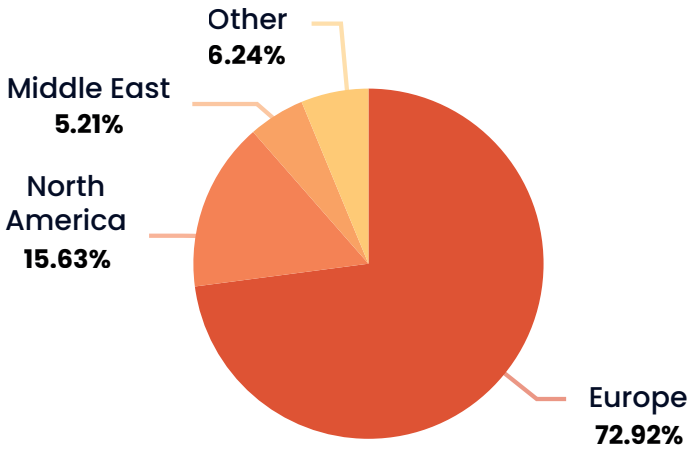
Top Foreign Destinations for Studies

** Unavailable observations remain included in the denominator but are not displayed.*

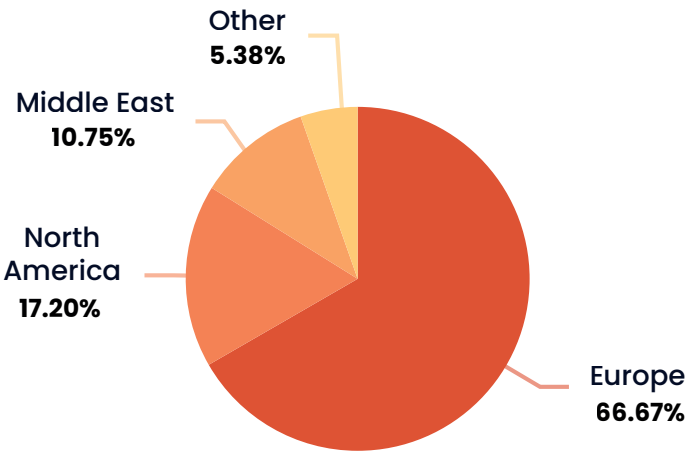
The foreign-work distribution follows a broadly similar pattern, though with meaningfully greater geographic diversity. The cleaned country-level field records 93 foreign-work country mentions. France again leads with 38 mentions (40.86% of foreign-work mentions), but the gap to the next tier is smaller than on the education side. Canada follows with 9 mentions (9.68%), the United States with 7 mentions (7.53%), the UAE, the United Kingdom, and Spain each record 5 mentions (5.38%). The broader distribution on the work side likely reflects the range of international job markets accessible to Moroccan professionals after graduation, and the growing role of the Gulf region as a professional destination for Moroccan talent.



Top Foreign Destinations for Pre-founding Work Experience



Regional Distribution of Foreign Study Destinations



Regional Distribution of Foreign Work Experience

Regional concentration

Aggregating to the regional level confirms that Europe is the dominant destination for both academic and professional exposure. European countries account for 72.92% of all foreign-study mentions and 66.67% of all foreign-work mentions. North America, driven by the United States and Canada, represents 15.63% of foreign-study mentions and 17.20% of foreign-work mentions. The clearest regional divergence between the two dimensions appears in the Middle East, which accounts for 5.21% of foreign-study mentions but 10.75% of foreign-work mentions, reflecting the role of the Gulf region as a work destination more than as a study destination. Other destinations combined account for less than 7% of foreign mentions on either dimension.

The regional concentration in Europe, and more specifically in France, is the single most consistent structural feature of the international profile of founders. It has implications for how the ecosystem connects to foreign capital, to foreign talent markets, and to foreign regulatory and commercial environments. Investors, accelerators, and public institutions designing programs to engage internationally-exposed founders should assume a primarily Franco-European operating context, while recognizing that North America and the Gulf also represent meaningful secondary professional corridors.

« The diaspora does not need to return physically to create value for Morocco. A Moroccan founder can build from London or Dubai and still make Morocco part of the company's trajectory. But if Morocco wants more of those founders to build locally, it has to offer a real reason to do so: access to financing, a market that allows startups to grow, and a regulatory framework that makes international fundraising and flipping easier, without founders being taxed in Morocco until they sell their shares. »

Karim Amor
President of the Moroccan Talents and Entrepreneurs' diaspora region at CGEM

Synthesis

The data paints a consistent picture: founders who raised capital in 2025 are, in large majority, products of cross-border academic and professional journeys, with Europe and particularly France as the dominant reference market. 80.61% of profiled founders have some foreign exposure, 66.33% have both studied and worked abroad, and only 18.37% built their profile entirely within Morocco. These are proxies for international exposure, not markers of diaspora identity, and should be interpreted accordingly. What the data does support is a structural observation. The funded founder population is internationally oriented by construction, not by exception. Most founders engaging with institutional capital arrive at founding with some form of European academic or professional grounding, comfort operating across French-speaking and English-speaking business environments, and existing connections to at least one foreign market. Conversely, the 18.37% of founders with purely domestic profiles represent a distinct and structurally underrepresented segment in the funded cohort, one whose participation in future funding rounds may depend on the extent to which domestic feeder institutions and operator networks can close the gap with internationally-exposed peers.

Methodology note

This section uses two observable attributes, the geographic location of each founder's academic institutions and pre-founding employers, as indirect proxies for international exposure. The data does not capture nationality, residency, citizenship, heritage, or identity-based ties to Morocco or any diaspora community, and no inference about those dimensions should be drawn from the findings reported here. Country-level counts reflect founder mentions rather than founder counts, meaning a single founder with studies or work experience in multiple countries is reflected in multiple country totals. Regional percentages are computed as shares of foreign-only mentions within each axis (studies or work), excluding Moroccan mentions. Coverage on the two geographic attributes used in this section is 98% on the education geography variable and 99% on the work geography variable. All other methodological notes from the previous section apply.

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Investor Activity

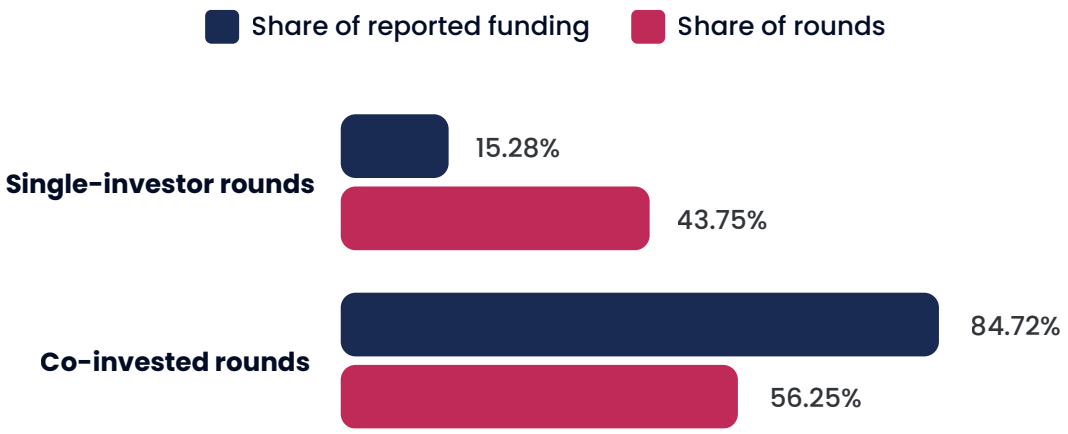
Investor participation and co-investment patterns in 2025 rounds

48	140	$91.87M	56%
2025 rounds	Investor participations	Funding in co-invested rounds	Co-invested rounds

Investor participation in 2025 points to a market that is becoming more networked and more dependent on syndicate formation. Across 48 funding rounds, the dataset captures at least 140 investor participations on a conservative count. Even at this floor, co-investment emerges as the main capital formation mechanism behind the largest rounds.

Single-investor rounds accounted for $16.57 million, or 15.28% of reported funding, across 21 transactions, or 43.75% of 2025 activity. Rounds involving at least two investors absorbed $91.87 million, equal to 84.72% of reported funding, across 27 transactions, or 56.25% of activity.

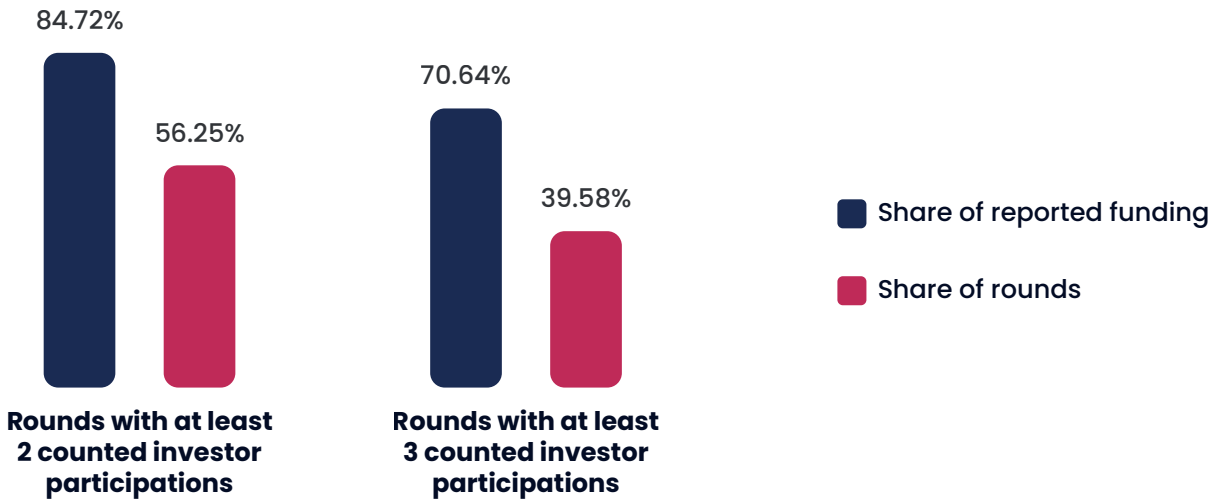
The market still has a broad base of smaller rounds backed by a limited investor group, while larger financings increasingly rely on several capital providers. For a market still building fund depth, this pattern is healthy. It allows investors to share risk and gives startups access to a wider support base, especially when financing needs move beyond early validation capital.



Round and Funding Distribution by Investor Participation

The role of larger syndicates becomes clearer when investor participation is grouped by depth. Rounds with at least two counted investor participations accounted for $91.87 million, or 84.72% of reported funding, across 27 transactions, or 56.25% of the year's round count. Within that group, rounds with at least three counted investor participations accounted for $76.60 million, or 70.64% of reported funding, across 19 transactions, or 39.58% of the year's round count.

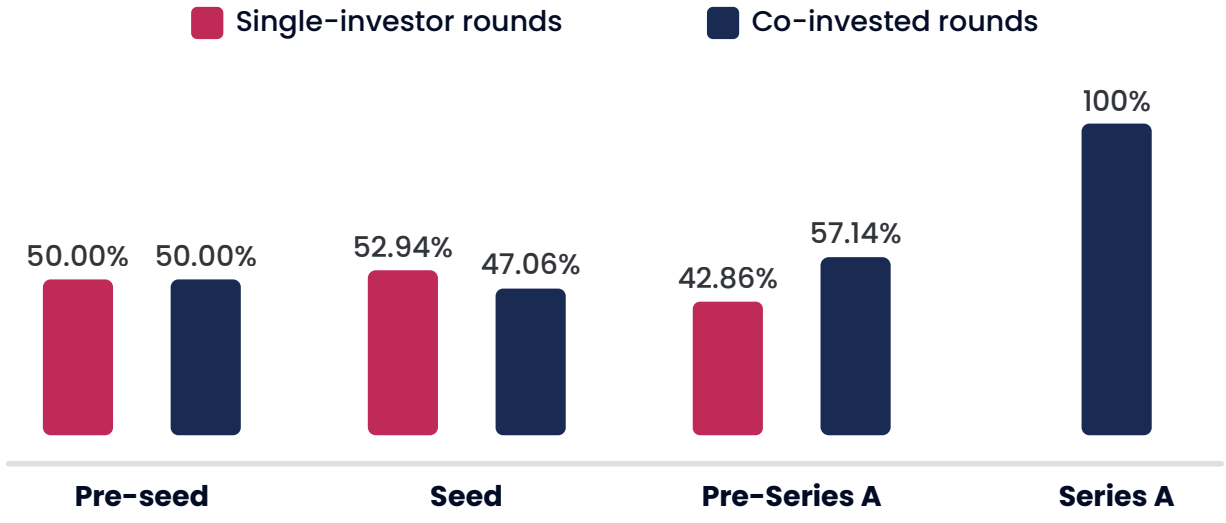
This has implications beyond the amount raised. Co-investment can combine local market access, regional expansion support, sector knowledge, strategic relationships, and follow-on funding capacity. For Moroccan startups raising larger rounds, the composition of the investor group is becoming part of the financing value proposition.



Co-Investment Depth by Minimum Investor Participation

Stage-level patterns reinforce the same conclusion. Series A rounds were fully syndicated, with all 6 involving at least two investors, and 5 involving at least three. Seed rounds remained relatively balanced by count, with 8 of 17 involving multiple investors and 7 involving at least three. Pre-seed activity was also evenly split by count, with 9 of 18 rounds involving multiple investors and 5 involving at least three.

This progression is consistent with a maturing early-stage market. Individual conviction remains important at the earliest layer, especially when companies are still validating their product, team, or first customer base. As rounds move toward pre-Series A and Series A, financing needs become larger and syndicates become more important. The 2025 data still shows this progression, even though seed activity remains more balanced between single-investor and co-invested rounds.



Investor Participation by Stage

« Most Moroccan funds reached the end of their investment period in 2025, slowing the pace of traditional financing — but making room for new models to emerge: venture builders and startup studios stepped in to fill the gap, offering a more operational approach to value creation. On the corporate side, the acceleration of AI and agentic technologies was a real wake-up call: many corporates, shaken in their own business models, became far more receptive to collaborating with startups. In female entrepreneurship, role models continue to inspire a new generation of women founders across increasingly diverse sectors — from agriculture to FMCG to telecom — with names like Z.Systems, ShareID, Paylik, SandToGreen, MLNetworks, Chari Pay and Hypeo leading the way. Finally, one exit reminded the Moroccan ecosystem, and beyond, of its real capacity to generate liquidity. We now look to the rest of 2026 for the closing of several funds, giving startups room to breathe and execute on their plans, for these new models to prove their ability to build ventures more efficiently, and for large corporates — some of which are already structuring their CVC arms, startup investment strategies, and fast-track collaboration mechanisms — to turn this momentum into concrete results. »

Ghita Zniber
Co-founding Partner at Kalys Ventures

Synthesis

The broader implication is that Morocco's investor base is becoming more connected. Larger funding outcomes increasingly depend on investor groups rather than isolated checks, giving the ecosystem a more institutional financing pattern. For a market where the number of active investors is growing but individual balance-sheet depth remains uneven, this marks a useful step.

The pattern also exposes a remaining constraint. Heavy reliance on multi-investor structures means the market still needs more investors with the capacity and conviction to lead sizeable financings independently. Morocco is developing a more reliable co-investment market, and the next phase will depend on whether these syndicates become more repeatable, more intentional, and better connected to post-Series A capital.

Methodology note

Investor counts use the at least methodology. Rounds with no investor names are counted as at least one investor, and wording that indicates multiple investors is counted at the lowest defensible number. Funding shares are calculated using rounds with reported amounts. Investor-count categories are based on conservative lower-bound counts and should be read as minimum counted investor participations, not exact investor headcounts. For investor-origin analysis, one round where investor origin could not be classified remains included in the denominator but is not displayed in charts for readability. As a result, investor-origin charts may not visually sum to 100%.

212 Founders

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2019	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$1,000,000**

Target Stages

Pre-Series A
Series A

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Nawfal Fassi Fihri

Amine Boukouss

Mehdi Dahoune

Imane Bennis

Startups Invested In	Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies
28	Inyad, Nucleon Security, Yakeey
Number of Exits	
3	

Afrimobility

Corporate Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2019	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$200,000 - $500,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed
Seed
Pre-Series A
Series A

Target Sectors

Agritech
Cleantech & Energy
Deeptech
Fintech
Foodtech
Healthtech
Mobility & Logistics

Leadership Team

Moulay Hafid Amrani

Youssef Loudyi

Startups Invested In	Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies
27	Chari, CloudFret, VelyVelo
Number of Exits	
3	

Al Mada Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2022	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$500,000 - $10,000,000**

Target Stages

Seed
Pre-Series A
Series A
Series B

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Startups Invested In	Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies
13	DeepEcho, SOWIT, Userguest

Alphavest Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2024	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$500,000 - $10,000,000**

Target Stages

Seed
Series A
Series B
Series C

Target Sectors

Agritech
Artificial Intelligence
Cybersecurity & Privacy
Fintech
Healthtech
Industry 4.0

Leadership Team

Hiba Mrani Alaoui

Isabelle Amiel

Attijariwafa Ventures

Corporate Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2023	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$200,000 - $3,000,000**

Target Stages

Pre-Series A · Series A · Series B · Series C

Target Sectors

Tech for Finance

Leadership Team

Hamza Mikou

Meryam Khir

Daouda Coulibaly

Ahmed Mansour

Mohamed Chami

Mehdi Lengliz

Startups Invested In: **5**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

AgenZ · WafR

Azur Innovation Management

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2019	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$500,000 - $2,500,000**

Target Stages

Seed · Pre-Series A · Series A

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Adnane Filali

Tarik Haddi

Khalil Azzouzi

Zineb Slaoui

Startups Invested In: **22**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

ORA Technologies · Weego

BMCE Capital Investments (FCV)

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2022	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$100,000 - $800,000**

Target Stages

Seed · Pre-Series A · Series A

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Zineb Megzari

Ghita Khaoulani

Startups Invested In: **2**

Number of Exits: **1**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Cathedis · PTS

Cash Plus Ventures

Corporate Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2023	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$100,000 - $1,000,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed · Seed

Target Sectors

Fintech · Mobility & Logistics

Leadership Team

Nabil Amar

Startups Invested In: **3**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Weego · ZSystems

Domseeds

Corporate Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2023	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$50,000 - $1,000,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed, Seed, Pre-Series A, Series A

Target Sectors

Agritech

Leadership Team

Maryam Guessous

Startups Invested In: **5**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Agridata, DAUMTech, SOWIT

EmergingTech Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2018	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$500,000 - $3,000,000**

Target Stages

Seed, Pre-Series A, Series A

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Meriem Zairi Tlemçani

Sidi Mohammed Zakraoui

Abdelouahid Benlamlih

Startups Invested In: **9**

Number of Exits: **2**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

SOWIT, Docline, Mazma

First Circle Capital

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2021	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$250,000 - $1,000,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed, Seed

Target Sectors

Fintech

Leadership Team

Agnes Aistleitner

Selma Ribica

Ming S. Kwan

Startups Invested In: **16**

Number of Exits: **3**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

WafR

Kalys Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2021	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$50,000 - $200,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed, Seed, Pre-Series A

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Ghita Zniber

Salma Benaddou Idrissi

Startups Invested In: **7**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Logidoo, Weego, ZSystems

MNF Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2010	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$100,000 - $1,000,000**

Target Stages

Seed
Pre-Series A
Series A

Target Sectors

Artificial Intelligence
Cybersecurity & Privacy
Edtech
Enterprise Software
Fintech
Mobility & Logistics
Proptech
Retailtech

Leadership Team

Dounia Boumehdi

Omar El Hyani

Startups Invested In
29

Number of Exits
4

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

AgenZ
Logidoo

Outlierz Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2019	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets:
- Fund I: **$150,000**
- Fund II: **$250,000 - $750,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed
Seed
Pre-Series A

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Kenza Lahlou

Startups Invested In
19

Number of Exits
1

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Paytic
Freterium

Seedbox

Corporate Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2025	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$100,000 - $5,000,000**

Target Stages

Stage Agnostic

Target Sectors

Advanced Materials
Autonomous Systems
Biotech
Specialty Products
Sustainable Chemistry
Watertech

Leadership Team

Reda Tamsamani

Jihad Maleh

Startups Invested In
5

U-Investors

Corporate Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2024	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$200,000 - $300,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed
Seed
Pre-Series A
Series A

Target Sectors

Cybersecurity & Privacy
Deeptech
Fintech
Healthtech
Insurtech

Leadership Team

Driss Laraki

Startups Invested In
5

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

ShareID

UM6P Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2021	Benguerir	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$100,000 - $700,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed
Seed
Pre-Series A

Target Sectors

Agritech
Cleantech & Energy
Digital & AI
Deeptech
Enterprise Software
Fintech
Foodtech
Healthtech
Insurtech

Leadership Team

Yassine Laghzioui

Lamiaa El Amrani

Sofia Zine-Eddine

Ikram Labtaini

Irfan Vissandjee

Hamza Eddahmani

Startups Invested In: **32**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Chari
DeepEcho
Weego

Wita Ventures

Venture Capital

Established in	Location	Employees
2020	Casablanca	2-10

Investment Tickets: **$200,000 - $500,000**

Target Stages

Pre-seed
Seed

Target Sectors

Sector Agnostic

Leadership Team

Omar Lemrabet

Startups Invested In: **12**

Number of Exits: **1**

Notable Moroccan Portfolio Companies

Data Pathology
Talaty
ZSystems

« The year 2025 marks a turning point for venture capital in Morocco. With the launch of new funds backed by the Mohammed VI Investment Fund, the ecosystem is entering a period of unprecedented acceleration, supported by greater access to capital, deeper expertise, and a shared ambition: to foster a new generation of Moroccan champions with regional and international reach.

Against this backdrop, MNF Ventures chose, during this period, to prioritize long-term value creation across its portfolio rather than increase the number of investments. We therefore focused our efforts on supporting our portfolio companies in their growth, strengthening their governance, and preparing them for their next funding rounds. Several companies are now well positioned for new rounds of investment, while MNF II's first exits are beginning to take shape and exits from MNF, our first fund, are continuing.

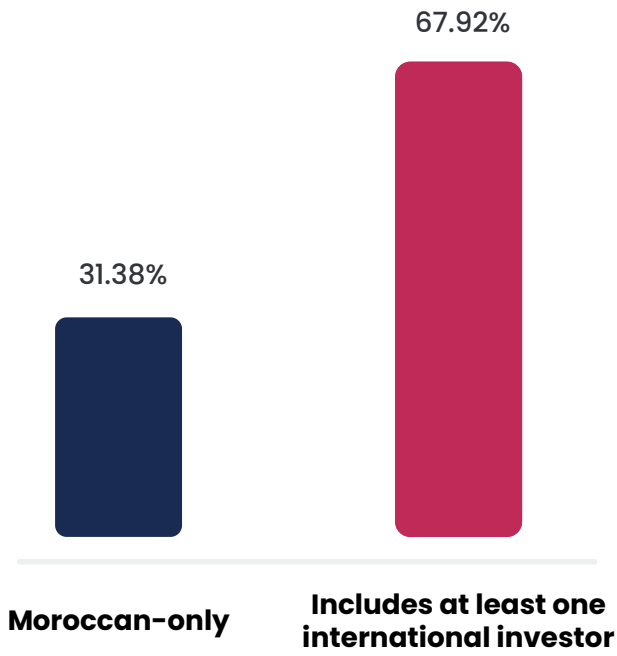
As this new momentum takes hold, MNF Ventures intends to contribute actively to the development and structuring of the market by providing high-quality deal flow to new investors entering the ecosystem, developing syndicated investment opportunities, and building bridges between the ecosystem's various stakeholders. »

Dounia Boumehdi
Managing Director at MNF Ventures

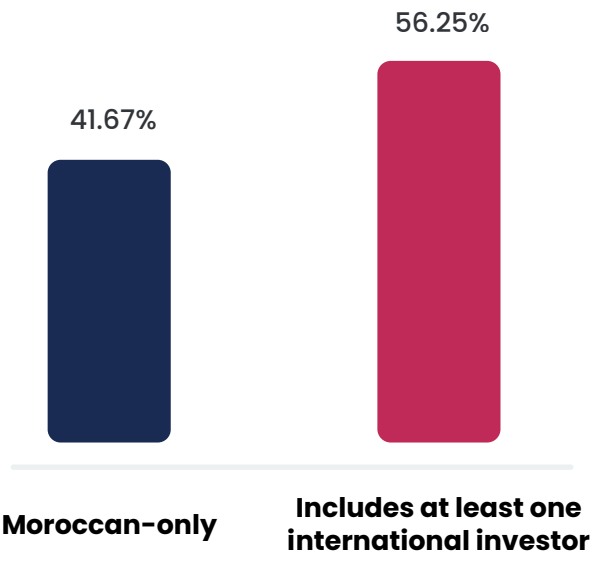
International Investor Participation and Local Market Presence

International investors are already a material part of Morocco's startup ecosystem. In capital terms, rounds that included at least one international investor accounted for $73.66 million, or 67.92% of reported funding. By deal count, 27 funding rounds included at least one international investor, equivalent to 56.25%.

The pattern points to a market where international capital is no longer limited to occasional participations. Foreign investors appeared across the funding pipeline, but their impact was most visible in rounds where larger ticket sizes, cross-border scaling needs, and follow-on financing requirements made international networks more valuable.



Disclosed Funding by Investor Origin, 2025 *



Funding Rounds by Investor Origin, 2025 *

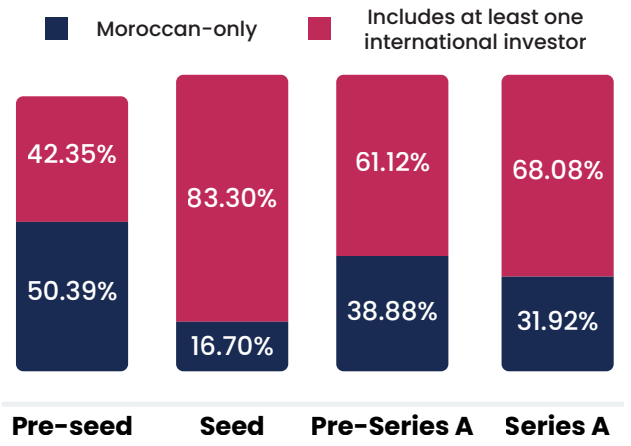
This capital mix does not suggest that Moroccan investors were displaced. It shows a funding market where local investors continued to anchor a large share of activity, while international investors increasingly appeared in rounds with higher disclosed values. The most relevant distinction is therefore not whether a round was purely foreign or purely local, but whether international capital was present at all.

That distinction is especially important for Morocco because international participation often brings more than capital. It can improve access to regional customers, international networks, technical expertise, and later-stage capital pools that remain comparatively limited in the domestic market.

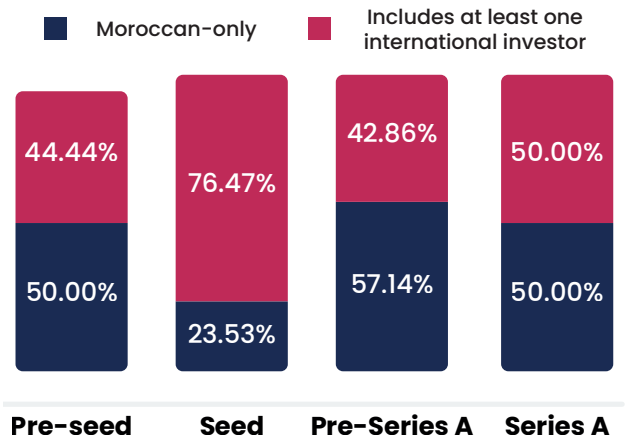
** One round where investor origin could not be classified remains included in the denominator but is not displayed.*

International participation by stage

By stage, international investors were present from pre-seed through Series A, but their role strengthened as rounds became larger. Pre-seed remained more locally anchored, with Moroccan-only rounds representing 9 of the 18 pre-seed rounds. Seed moved in the opposite direction, with 13 of 17 seed rounds including at least one international investor. Pre-Series A was more balanced by count, with 3 of 7 rounds including at least one international investor, but those rounds still represented 61.12% of pre-Series A funding. Series A was evenly split by deal count, but the funding value was not: Series A rounds involving international investors captured $35 million of disclosed funding, compared with $16.41 million for Moroccan-only Series A rounds.



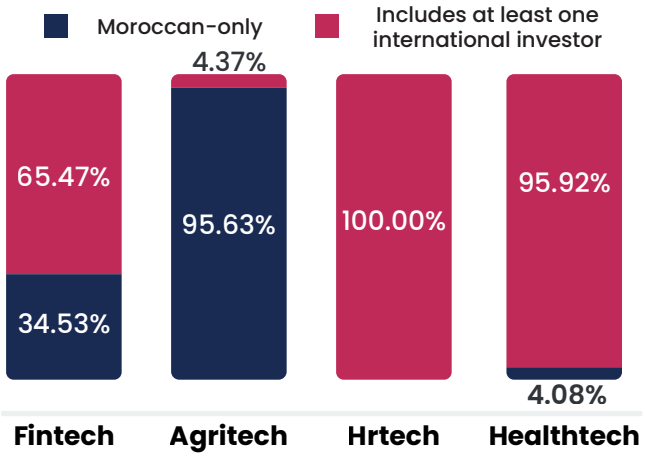
Investor Origin by Funding Stage, 2025 (Disclosed Funding) *



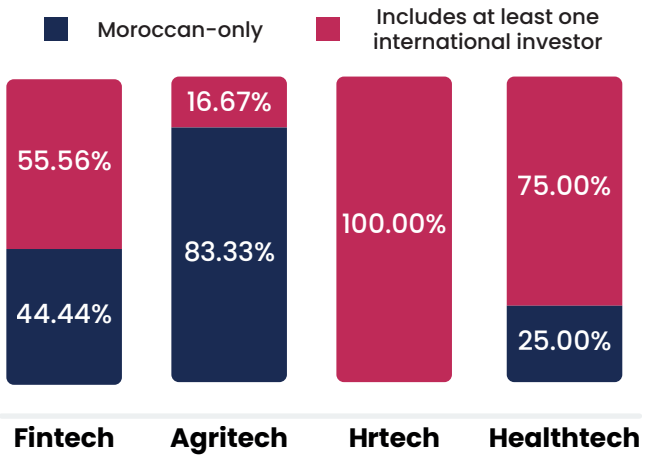
Investor Origin by Funding Stage, 2025 (Round Count) *

Sector concentration of international capital

International-linked funding did not mirror the overall sector ranking. Fintech led with five internationally backed rounds and $23.20 million in disclosed funding, while proptech ranked second by value because of Yakeey's $15.00 million Series A. Healthtech and hrtech also showed strong foreign-linked participation across the selected sector view. Agritech moved differently: despite being one of the year's most important sectors overall, most of its rounds and disclosed funding were concentrated around Moroccan-only investors. The pattern suggests that international capital was more visible in sectors where investors had clearer reference points for assessing business models, market potential, and follow-on financing needs, while local investors remained central in sectors where opportunities were more closely tied to Morocco's domestic market priorities.



Investor Origin by Selected Sector, 2025 (Disclosed Funding)



Investor Origin by Selected Sector, 2025 (Round Count)

** Pre-seed includes one round where investor origin could not be classified. It remains included in the denominator but is not displayed in the chart.*

From cross-border participation to local market presence

The second shift is qualitative. Morocco is not only attracting international investors into individual funding rounds; it is also starting to attract international platforms, accelerators, and fund managers into the local market. This matters because a local footprint changes the nature of investor engagement. It gives foreign actors repeated exposure to founder pipelines, institutional partners, public programs, talent networks, and co-investment opportunities, instead of limiting their role to one-off deal participation.

Plug and Play illustrates the accelerator and innovation-platform side of this shift. Through the Morocco Accelerator, developed with Technopark and backed by the Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform, the organization is helping connect Moroccan startups to mentors, corporate partners, investors, and its global innovation network.

Renew Capital shows a more direct presence model. In December 2025, the firm launched its North and West Africa headquarters in Morocco through a partnership with Technopark Casablanca. The positioning is important: Morocco is being used not only as a domestic market, but as a base for linking Moroccan and North African entrepreneurs with sub-Saharan and East African opportunities.

Public venture-building and fund-of-funds initiatives are reinforcing the same direction. The Startup Venture Building initiative brought international partners such as Flat6Labs, Open Startup International, Renew Capital, and 500 Global into Morocco's startup support architecture. Separately, the Mohammed VI Investment Fund preselected several international and mixed fund managers under Digital Morocco 2030, including 500 Global, Middle East Venture Partners, Plug and Play Investment Group, Ring Capital, Sawari Ventures, and Sienna Venture Capital in partnership with AlphaVest Capital.

The combined effect is still early, but strategically important. Morocco's international investor story is moving beyond capital inflows alone. The market is beginning to build the connective tissue that can make foreign participation more repeatable. For founders, this can gradually improve access to networks and follow-on capital. For the ecosystem, it signals a transition from episodic foreign participation toward a more structured cross-border capital market.

« Morocco's startup ecosystem is reaching an inflection point, driven by the FM6I Fund of Funds, accelerating capital inflows, and strengthening deal flow supported by MTNRA-backed programs. Combined with World Cup-driven investment momentum and a stable macro and geopolitical environment, Morocco is emerging as a key hub for both investors investing on the continent and founders scaling regionally. »

Kenza Lahlou
Managing Partner at Outlierz Ventures

« At 500 Global, we have a long history of entering emerging tech ecosystems that we believe are approaching an inflection point. We apply a framework to assess market readiness across six criteria: government policy, startup pipeline, technology adoption, talent pool, venture capital availability, and the startup support ecosystem. When we mapped that framework across Africa, Morocco stood out clearly as a high-potential opportunity.

Morocco combines strong macro momentum, a sizable population, a growing pool of tech talent, and supportive government initiatives. At the same time, digital adoption across sectors is catching up, creating an exciting opportunity for founders to build market-fit tech solutions that have the potential to capture new adopters and scale regionally and globally. »

Demola Adegbite
Partner, Africa at 500 Global

64

Founder Challenges and Structural Bottlenecks

61
Founder respondents

80%
Pre-seed or seed

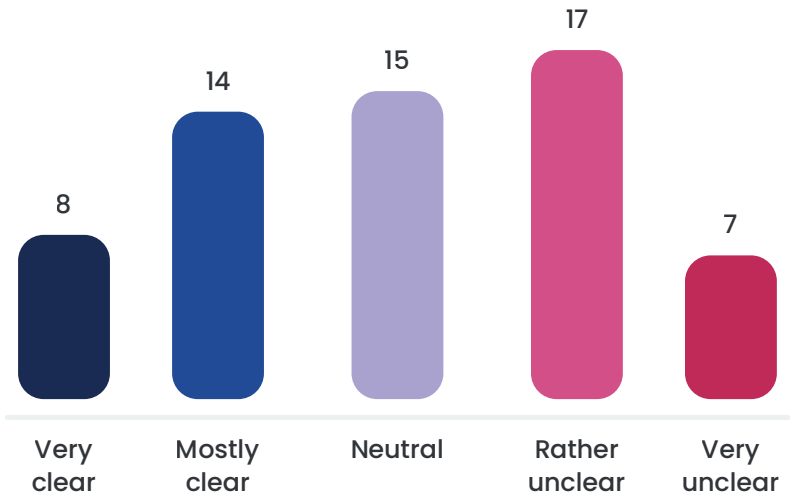
75%
Founded since 2023

59%
Based in Casablanca

The findings presented in this section are drawn from a structured survey conducted with startup founders across Morocco as part of the research underpinning this report. A total of 61 founders responded, representing companies at different stages of development, from idea and pre-seed (39.34%) to seed (40.98%), early growth (13.11%), and scale-up (6.56%). Combining quantitative responses with open-ended input, the survey offers a ground-level view of the structural frictions that continue to shape the founder experience. While Morocco has made visible progress in strengthening its entrepreneurial infrastructure over the past decade, the results point to a persistent gap between ecosystem ambition and the day-to-day operational realities facing startups.

Regulatory Complexity and Administrative Burden

Regulatory friction remains one of the most consistently cited pressure points for Moroccan founders. When asked to assess the clarity of the regulatory framework governing their activity, only 36.07% of respondents described it as «mostly clear» or «very clear,» while 39.34% rated it as «rather unclear» or «very unclear.» The remaining 24.59% characterized it as «neutral,» suggesting that the issue is not always outright opacity, but a level of ambiguity that creates recurring friction for early-stage startups with limited legal and administrative capacity. Rather than acting as a single visible barrier, this lack of clarity often translates into a cumulative operational burden that slows decision-making, increases compliance effort, and makes it harder for founders to navigate growth with confidence.

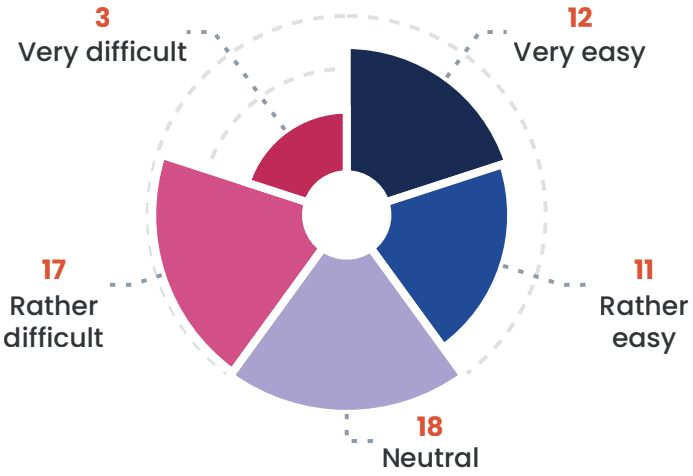


Perceived Clarity of the Regulatory Framework *(n=61)*

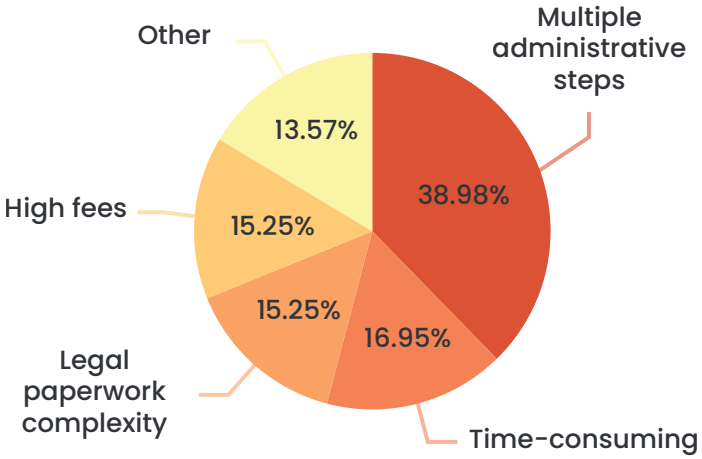
In terms of specific regulatory challenges, sector-specific regulation was the most frequently cited obstacle, selected by 36.21% of respondents. It was followed by taxation and compliance, identified by 24.14%, then company registration and legal procedures at 17.24%, and administrative delays at 15.52%. Overall, the pattern suggests that regulatory friction is driven less by a single systemic bottleneck than by the combined weight of sector-level complexity, compliance requirements, procedural hurdles, and slow administrative processes, all of which place a disproportionate burden on early-stage startups with limited internal capacity.

Main Regulatory Challenges *(n=58)*

Founders were also asked to evaluate the difficulty of the company incorporation process itself. The results were relatively mixed: 37.70% described it as «very easy» or «rather easy,» 29.51% said it was «neutral,» and 32.79% rated it as «rather difficult» or «very difficult.» Among those who encountered friction, the most commonly cited challenge was the number of administrative steps involved, mentioned by 38.98% of respondents. Time-consuming procedures (16.95%), high fees (15.25%), and legal paperwork complexity (15.25%) were also frequently noted.

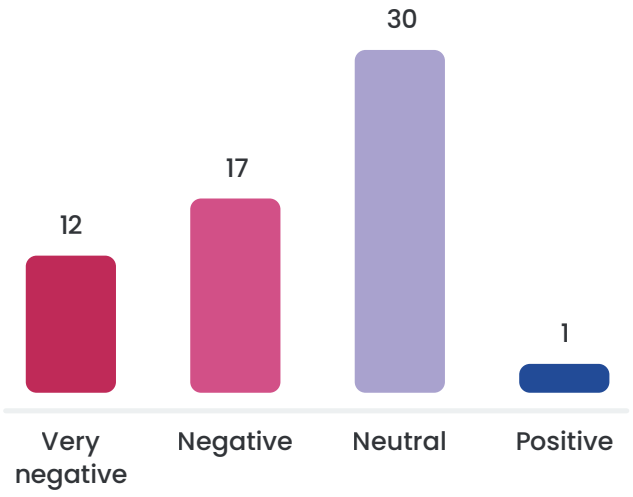


Incorporation Difficulty *(n=61)*



Main Incorporation Challenges *(n=59)*

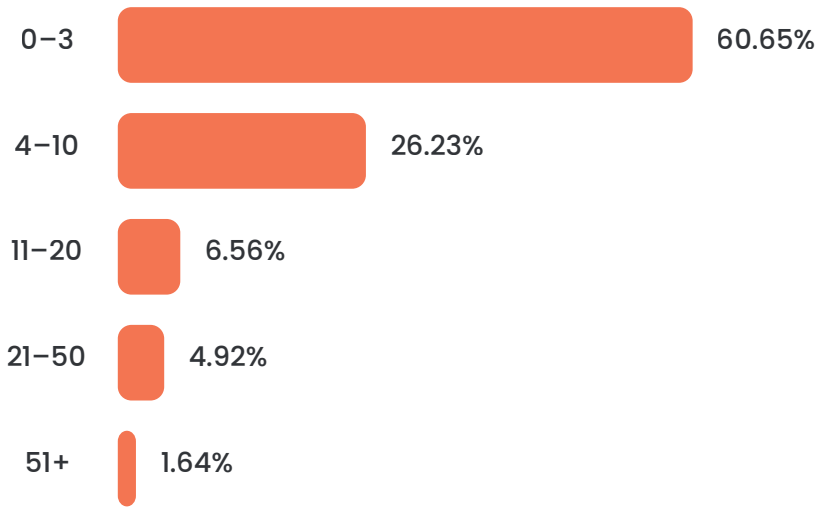
On the question of taxation, the picture is more clearly negative. Nearly half of respondents (48.33%) rated the impact of taxation on their startup as «negative» or «very negative,» while 50% described it as «neutral.» Only one respondent in the sample assessed the tax environment as «positive.» While the absence of a startup-specific fiscal framework is a structural factor, the open-ended responses suggest the issue is less about tax rates per se and more about the absence of incentives calibrated to early-stage ventures.



Impact of Taxation on Startups *(n=60)*

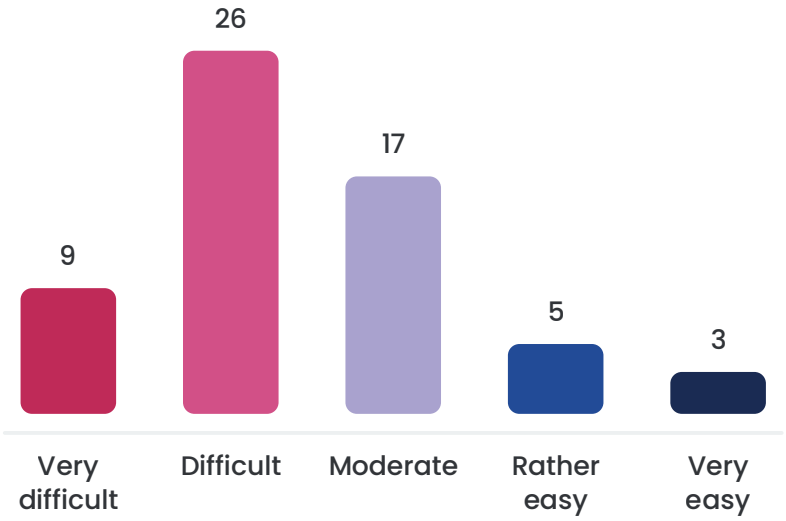
Human Capital

The survey sample is overwhelmingly composed of lean teams. Overall, 60.65% of respondents reported having between zero and three full-time employees, and another 26.23% had between four and ten. Only 13.11% employed more than ten people, with just one respondent reporting a team of more than 50. Although this distribution aligns with an ecosystem still dominated by pre-seed and seed-stage ventures, it also reflects a deeper constraint on company building. In practice, hiring remains difficult as limited funding, challenges in attracting and retaining qualified talent, and the operational demands of scaling early-stage companies continue to constrain headcount growth.



Current Number of Full-Time Employees *(n=61)*

Talent acquisition itself is a significant concern across the sample. A combined 58.33% of respondents described the difficulty of recruiting qualified talent as «difficult» or «very difficult,» while 28.33% rated it as «moderate.» Only 13.33% characterized recruitment as «rather easy» or «very easy.» The challenge is most pronounced among fintech and deeptech startups, where specialized engineering, data science, and product roles are difficult to fill against competition from larger corporates and remote employers offering European-level salaries.

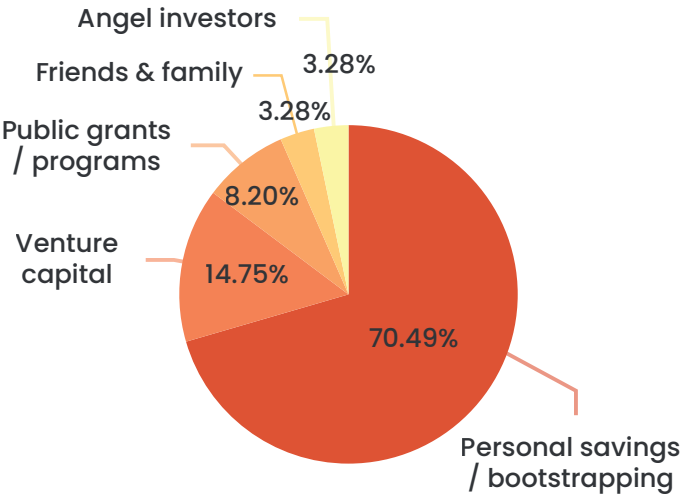


Difficulty of Recruiting Qualified Talent *(n=60)*

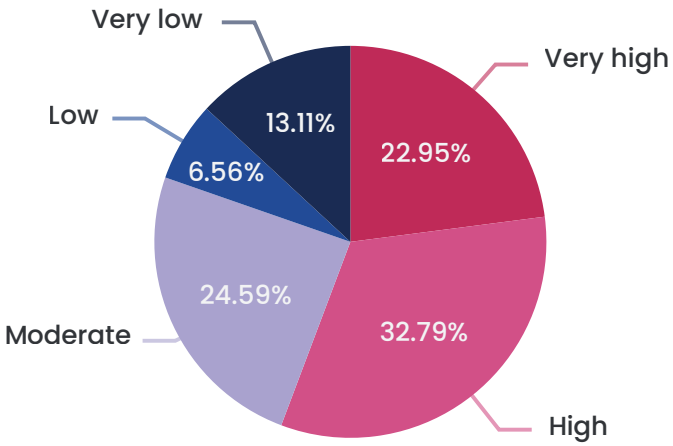
The open-ended responses on HR challenges, provided by 34 of the 61 respondents, reveal a set of recurring themes that cut across sectors and stages. The most frequently cited issue is the difficulty of attracting technical talent, particularly experienced developers, AI engineers, and SaaS specialists, at salary levels that early-stage companies can afford. This challenge extends to technical leadership, with founders also reporting difficulty finding CTOs who combine strong technical expertise, startup experience, and a willingness to join an early-stage venture. Several founders described a direct tension between the compensation expectations set by large corporates or remote European employers and the cash constraints of a pre-revenue startup. A second pattern concerns commitment and reliability: founders reported high turnover, a lack of long-term orientation among candidates, and a mismatch between available applicants and actual role requirements. A third theme involves the legal and structural barriers to talent retention, including the difficulty of implementing stock option or vesting mechanisms under Moroccan corporate law, which limits founders' ability to offer equity-based compensation as an alternative to high salaries.

Funding and Financial Sustainability

The survey reveals an ecosystem still heavily reliant on personal capital. Fully 70.49% of respondents reported that personal savings or bootstrapping had been their main source of funding to date. Venture capital was cited by 14.75%, public grants and programs by 8.20%, and angel investors and friends-and-family rounds by 3.28% each. This distribution indicates that most founders are still building primarily with their own resources, while external sources of capital remain limited across the sample. This dynamic is reflected in how respondents assess current fundraising conditions. A combined 55.74% rated the difficulty of accessing funding at their stage as high or very high, while 24.59% described it as moderate. Only 19.67% rated access to funding as low or very low.

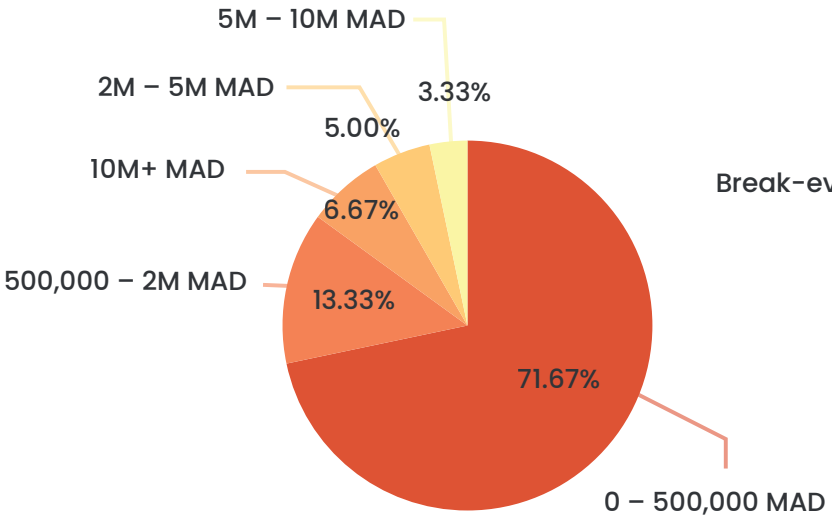


Main Sources of Funding *(n=61)*

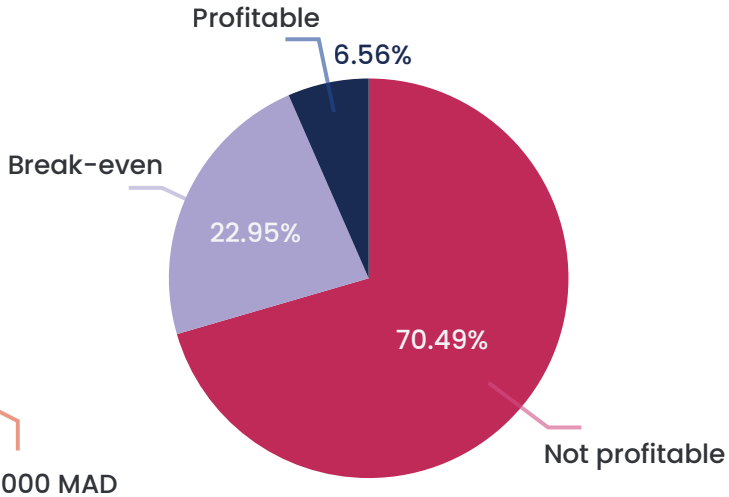


Difficulty of Accessing Funding *(n=61)*

The revenue and profitability data further highlight how early most surveyed companies remain in their commercial development. Fully 71.67% of respondents reported annual revenues below 500,000 MAD, and 70.49% of the full sample said they were not yet profitable at the time of response. Only 6.56% reported being profitable, while 22.95% had reached break-even. At the upper end, 6.67% reported revenues exceeding 10 million MAD, reflecting a small number of more advanced companies within the sample. While this distribution is broadly consistent with a sample dominated by pre-seed and seed-stage ventures, it also shows that most respondents are still in the early phases of building sustainable revenue and reaching financial stability.

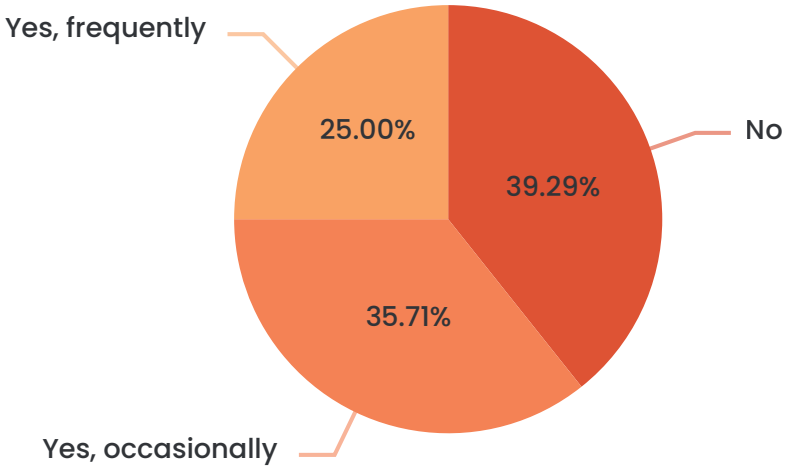


Estimated Annual Revenue *(n=60)*

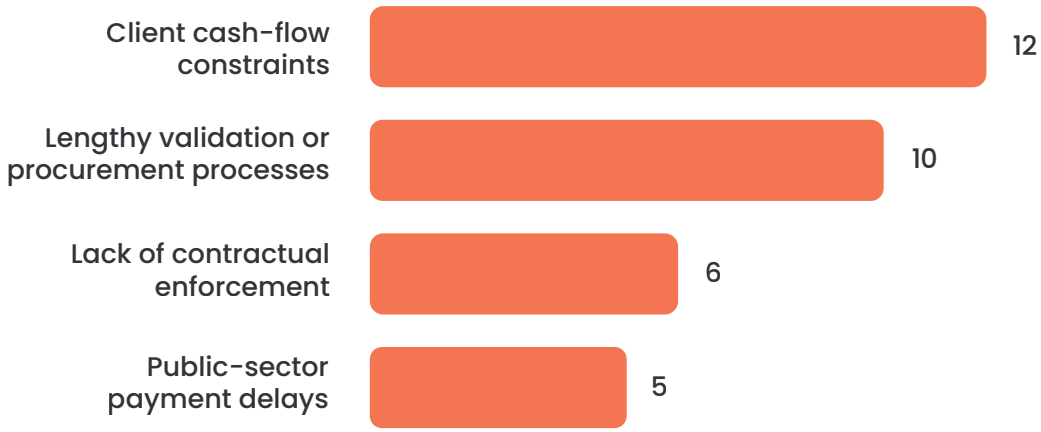


Profitability Status *(n=61)*

Payment delays from clients and partners compound the financial pressure. Among the 56 respondents who answered this question, 35.71% reported experiencing delays occasionally and 25% reported experiencing them frequently, for a combined rate of 60.71%. Among founders who experienced payment delays and provided a valid reason, the most commonly cited causes were client cash-flow constraints (36.36%), lengthy validation or procurement processes (30.30%), lack of contractual enforcement (18.18%), and public-sector payment delays (15.15%). For startups already operating on thin margins and limited runway, these delays translate directly into cash-flow crises that can stall hiring, product development, and growth.



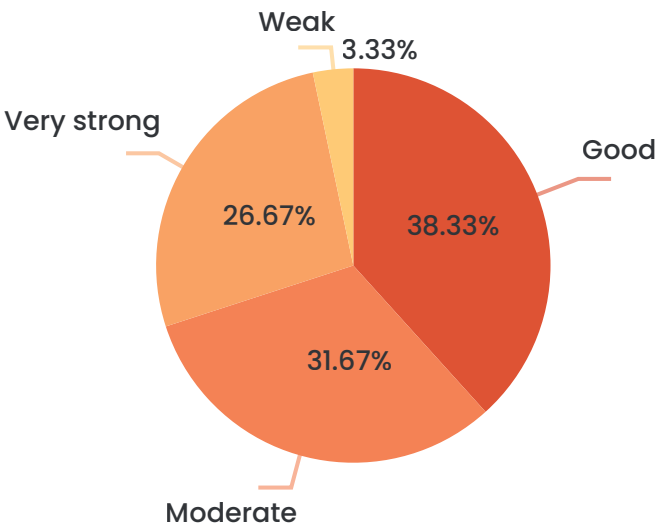
Experienced Payment Delays *(n=56)*



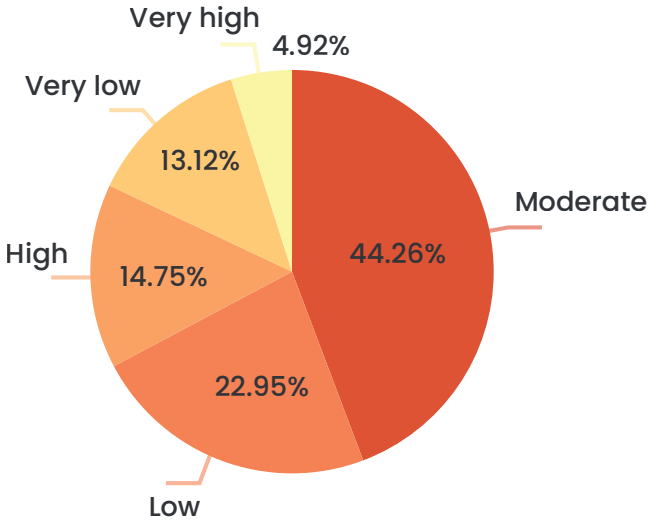
Main Reasons for Payment Delays *(n=33)*

Go-to-Market and Customer Adoption

Market reception emerges as one of the more encouraging findings in the survey, even as founders continue to face structural barriers in customer acquisition and market access. A combined 65% of respondents rated market acceptance of their product or service as «good» or «very strong,» while 31.67% described it as «moderate.» Only 3.33% rated it as «weak.» Competition intensity was perceived as moderate by 44.26% of respondents, with 22.95% rating it as low and 19.67% as high or very high.

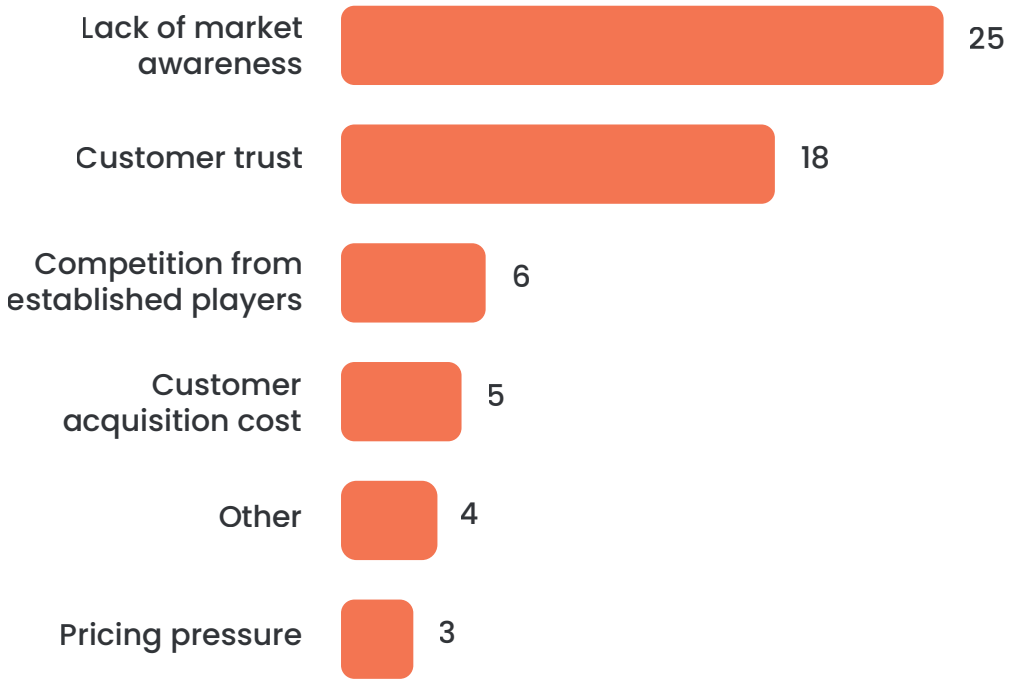


Market Acceptance *(n=60)*



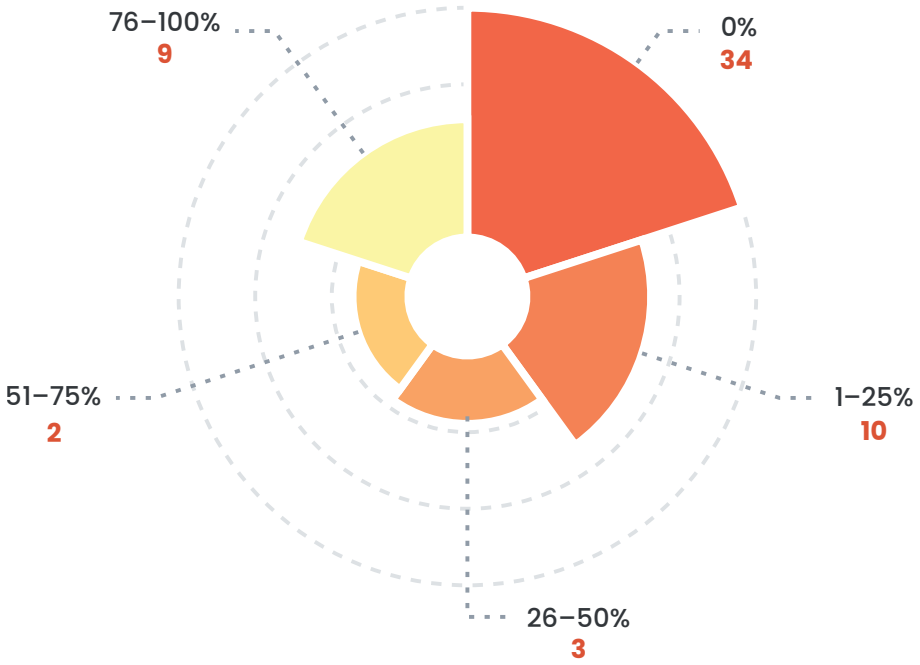
Competition Intensity *(n=61)*

The principal go-to-market challenges, however, are structural rather than competitive. Lack of market awareness was the single most cited barrier, selected by 40.98% of respondents. Customer trust was the second most common, cited by 29.51%, reflecting a broader pattern in emerging ecosystems where buyers remain skeptical of early-stage providers. Competition from established players was selected by 9.84%, while customer acquisition cost and pricing pressure were cited by 8.20% and 4.92% respectively.

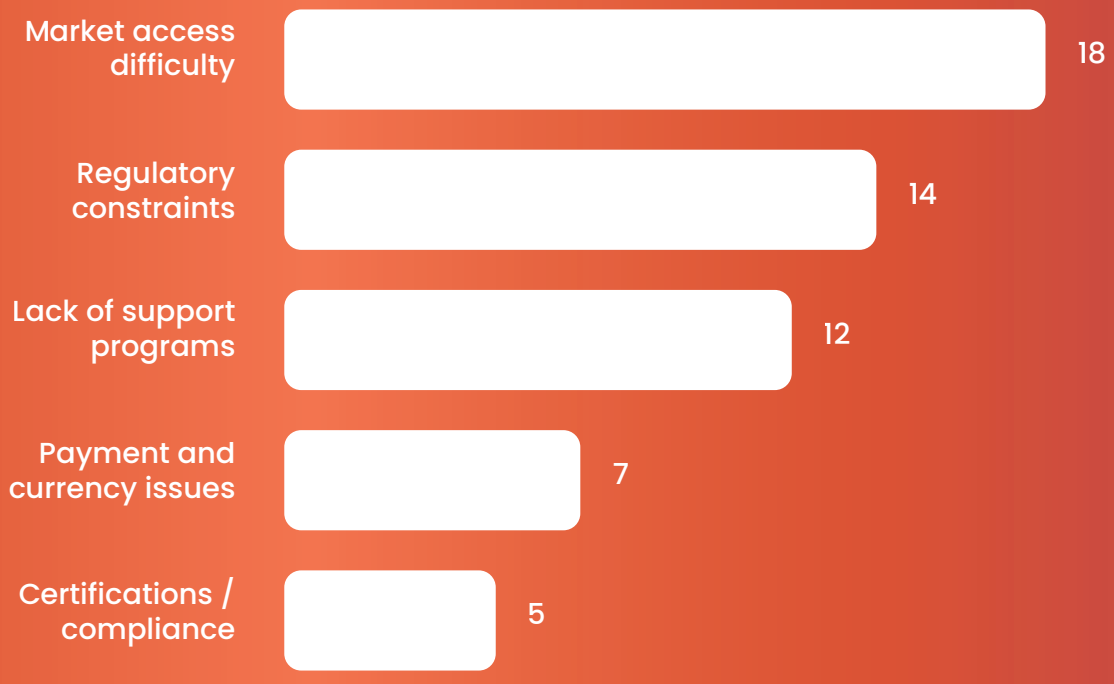


Main Challenges Related to Market Entry or Growth *(n=61)*

International expansion is still at an early stage for most respondents. Fully 58.62% reported that none of their revenue comes from outside Morocco, while 17.24% derive between 1% and 25% from international markets. At the other end, 15.52% reported that 76% to 100% of their revenue is international, reflecting a small subset of more export-oriented companies across multiple sectors. The main barriers to international expansion include market access difficulty (32.14%), regulatory constraints (25%), lack of support programs (21.43%), payment and currency issues (12.50%), and certifications or compliance requirements (8.93%).



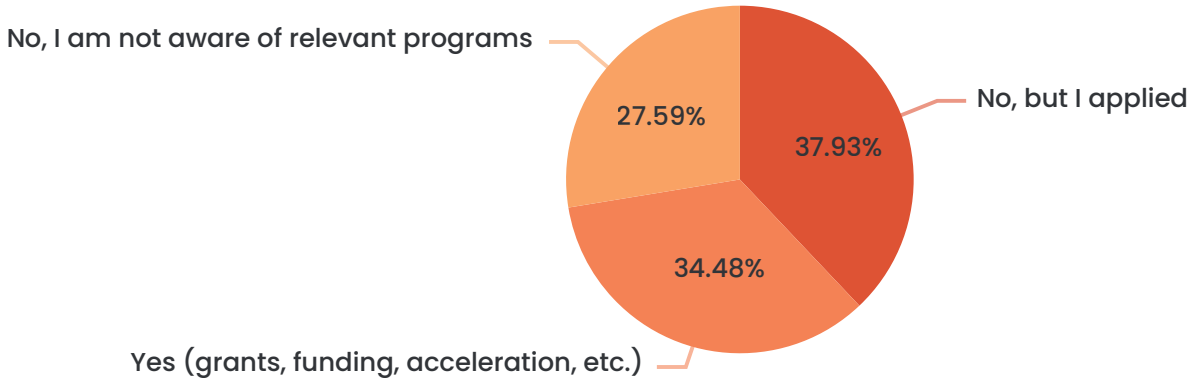
Revenue from Outside Morocco *(n=58)*



Main Barriers to International Expansion *(n=56)*

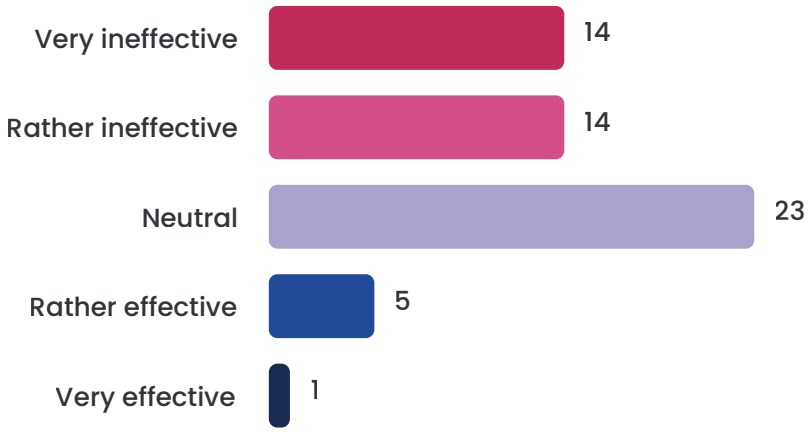
Public Support and Institutional Environment

Founders' experiences with public support programs are sharply divided. Among the 58 respondents who answered this question, 34.48% reported having benefited from government support (grants, funding, or acceleration programs), while 37.93% said they had applied but not benefited. Another 27.59% were not even aware of relevant programs. The split between applicants who were accepted and those who were not suggests that program capacity or selection criteria are filtering out a substantial share of potentially eligible founders.



Access to Government or Public Support Programs *(n=58)*

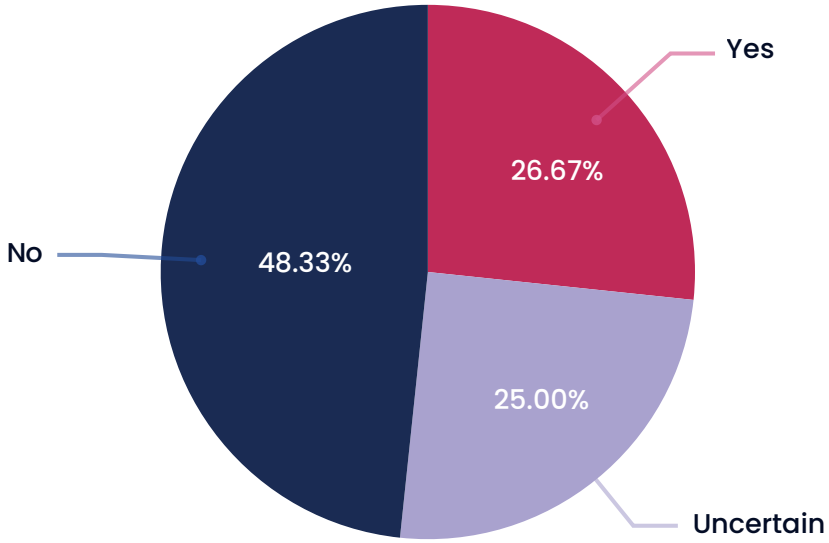
Assessments of the overall effectiveness of public support were predominantly negative or neutral. Among those who responded, 40.35% rated support as «neutral,» while 24.56% selected «very ineffective» and 24.56% chose «rather ineffective.» Only 10.53% rated it as «rather effective» or «very effective.» The qualitative responses reveal frustration not only with the scarcity of support, but also with how that support is structured. Founders consistently called for faster disbursement of funds, fewer administrative hurdles, and programs designed around business outcomes rather than participation metrics.



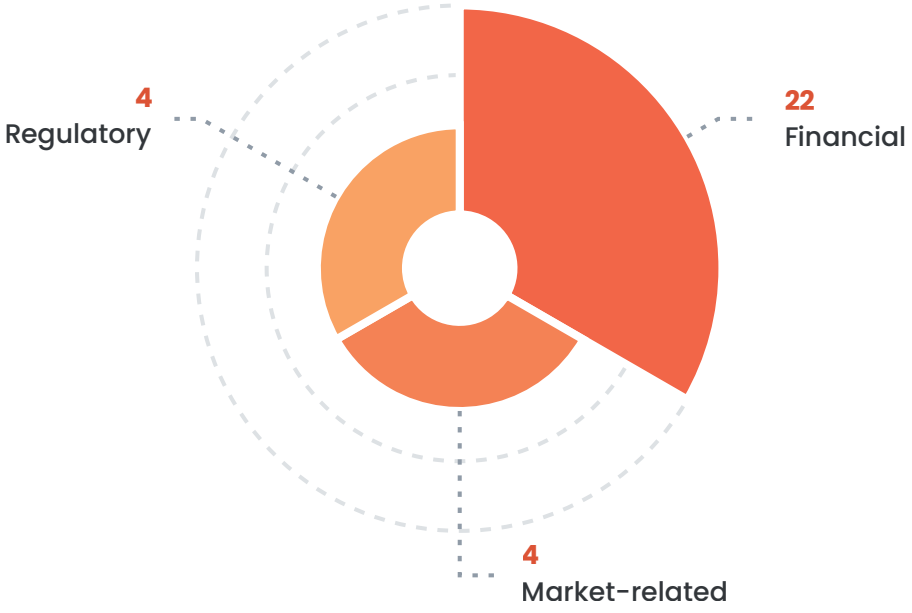
Overall Effectiveness of Public Support *(n=57)*

Survival Outlook

The final question in the survey asked founders whether they believe their startup is at risk of shutting down within the next 12 to 18 months. Nearly half the sample, 48.33%, answered «no,» while 26.67% said «yes» and 25% described themselves as «uncertain». Among founders who indicated risk or uncertainty and provided a valid risk-factor response, financial pressure was the predominant concern, cited by 73.33% of respondents. Regulatory and market-related risks followed, each cited by 13.33%.



Risk of Shutting Down Within 12–18 Months *(n=60)*



Primary Risk Factor *(n=30)*

These figures do not, on their own, suggest an ecosystem in crisis, but they do highlight the extent to which financial fragility shapes the operating environment for many early-stage startups in Morocco. The combination of limited funding options, slow revenue growth, delayed payments, and limited public support can create compounding pressure that many founders must navigate with little margin for error. The challenge ahead is not simply to increase the volume of available capital, but to build a more integrated support architecture in which regulatory clarity, fiscal incentives, programmatic support, and market access reinforce one another rather than operating in parallel.

Policy and Regulatory Developments

75

Laying the Foundations

2000

FEBRUARY 2000

Establishment of the Moroccan Office of Industrial and Commercial Property

Law No. 13-99 created the Moroccan Office of Industrial and Commercial Property (OMPIC) as a public institution with legal personality and financial autonomy, establishing Morocco's dedicated institutional framework for industrial and commercial property.

JUNE 2000

Creation of the National Agency for Employment Promotion and Skills

Law No. 51-99 established ANAPEC as a public institution under state supervision, creating Morocco's national employment promotion and intermediation agency with mandates including job matching, employer support, and guidance for young entrepreneurs.

OCTOBER 2000

Inauguration of Technopark Casablanca

His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist him, inaugurated Technopark Casablanca as a flagship technology hub designed to support ICT development, innovation, and the emergence of Moroccan startups and tech companies.

Three institutions in eight months. Morocco established its intellectual property office, created its national employment intermediation agency, and inaugurated its first flagship technology hub within a short span early in the reign of His Majesty King Mohammed VI, setting a pace that signaled how seriously the country would approach economic modernization in the years ahead. Technopark Casablanca, in particular, was an ambitious institutional bet. Morocco inaugurated it in 2000, opened it in 2001 through a public-private partnership model, and would not inaugurate a second Technopark, in Rabat, until 2012. That long gap is itself telling: the model mattered, but replicating it required time, coordination, and institutional learning.

2001

APRIL 2001

Presentation of the First National e-Maroc Strategy

At the National e-Maroc Symposium held in Rabat, Morocco presented the first national Strategy e-Maroc, formalizing an early national roadmap around five action lines covering skills and education, online administration and local services, enterprise digitization and SME support, e-commerce enablement, and narrowing the digital divide through access, awareness, and local-language public content.

April 2001 was a counterintuitive moment to present a national digital strategy. The dot-com bubble had already burst, and tech markets had been hit hard. Morocco went ahead anyway. The e-Maroc symposium in Rabat framed digital not as a market play but as a development lever: skills, e-government, SME digitization, e-commerce, and digital access. That framing made the strategy less dependent on the boom-and-bust cycle of internet markets because it was never only about riding a wave. It was about building infrastructure. That same logic would resurface later, as digital tools were treated not as a standalone trend but as part of a broader modernization agenda.

AUGUST 2001

Transformation of the National Research Coordination Body into the CNRST

Law No. 80-00 redesignated the Centre national de coordination et de planification de la recherche scientifique et technique (CNCPRST), originally established in 1976, as the Centre National pour la Recherche Scientifique et Technique (CNRST), consolidating its status as a public institution for scientific and technical research.

2002

JANUARY 2002

Creation of the Regional Investment Centers

In the Royal Letter of 9 January 2002 on the deconcentrated management of investment, His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist him, decided that Regional Investment Centers be created under the authority of the Walis as regional one-stop shops for business creation and investor support.

NOVEMBER 2002

Institutionalization of National SME Support through ANPME

Morocco created the National Agency for the Promotion of Small and Medium Enterprises (ANPME), under Law No. 53-00 forming the SME Charter, as a public agency tasked with SME promotion and upgrading, replacing the former Industrial Development Office (ODI).

2003

SEPTEMBER 2003

Promulgation of Morocco's Labor Code

Law No. 65-99 relating to the Labor Code was promulgated by Dahir No. 1-03-194 on September 11, 2003, establishing a modern unified framework for labor relations, employment conditions, collective bargaining, and labor dispute resolution in Morocco.

2005

JANUARY 2005

Launch of the e-Maroc 2010 National Digital Strategy

Morocco launched e-Maroc 2010 as a national roadmap for the development of the information society and knowledge economy, with priorities centered on reducing the digital divide and strengthening the country's positioning in ICT.

By 2007, two years into the e-Maroc 2010 strategy, the numbers told a clear story. Administrative e-services had jumped from 5 in 2002 to 190. Mobile phone ownership reached about 64% of Moroccan households, up from 41.5% in 2004. International bandwidth had risen to 11.2 Gbps, among the highest in Africa at that time. The strategy also helped institutionalize first-generation e-government tools, including the IDARATI program and portals such as service-public.ma, while .ma domain registrations rose to nearly 22,000 by late 2006. What makes these numbers worth noting is that they were achieved under the first generation of digital policy, before Morocco had a dedicated digital agency, a startup label, or most of the ecosystem infrastructure that exists today.

2006

FEBRUARY 2006

Introduction of Morocco's Dedicated Venture Capital Legal Framework

Law No. 41-05 established Morocco's first dedicated legal regime for venture capital activity through OPCR structures, creating a formal framework for risk-capital investment in SMEs via specialized vehicles and management companies.

Morocco did not stop at recognizing venture capital activity in principle. Law No. 41-05 embedded discipline into the regime itself, requiring OPCR vehicles to keep at least 50% of their net assets in qualifying SME equity-linked instruments, with a three-year ramp-up to reach that threshold. This was a forcing mechanism: it prevented fund managers from claiming the venture-capital regime while keeping too much capital in safer assets. Later reforms did not simply preserve that original rigidity. Law No. 18-14 in 2015 and Law No. 58-22 in 2023 kept the dedicated legal architecture for private capital while making it broader, more flexible, and more attractive to investors.

2007

JANUARY 2007

Introduction of the General Tax Code

Morocco introduced the Code Général des Impôts as a unified tax code, instituted by Article 5 of Finance Law No. 43-06 promulgated on December 31, 2006, with core provisions applicable from January 1, 2007, consolidating the main tax rules into a single reference framework.

NOVEMBER 2007

Enactment of the Legal Framework for Electronic Exchange of Legal Data

Law No. 53-05, promulgated by Dahir No. 1-07-129 on November 30, 2007 and published in Official Bulletin No. 5584 on December 6, 2007, established Morocco's legal regime for electronic legal data, recognized the evidentiary equivalence of electronic and paper documents, and framed electronic signatures, electronic contracts, and electronic certification services.

2008

SEPTEMBER 2008

Operationalization of the Innovation TIC Fund

The Innovation TIC fund was operationally launched as a MAD 100 million mechanism, managed by the Caisse Centrale de Garantie, to support ICT innovation through direct co-financing and guarantees for venture-capital participation.

2009

FEBRUARY 2009

Enactment of Morocco's Personal Data Protection Framework

Law No. 09-08 established Morocco's core legal framework for the protection of personal data, regulating the processing of personal data and creating the CNDP as the supervisory authority.

JUNE 2009

Launch of the Maroc Innovation Initiative

Launched during the First National Innovation Summit, Maroc Innovation introduced a national framework to strengthen innovation governance, infrastructure, financing, and talent mobilization, targeting 100 innovative startups and 1,000 Moroccan patents annually from 2014 onward.

Late 2008 and 2009 exposed both the ambition and the limits of Morocco's first innovation-policy wave. Innovation TIC gave the state a concrete instrument for co-financing technology projects and supporting venture-capital participation, yet available program data points to only five projects treated and five retained under the mechanism despite its MAD 100 million envelope. Maroc Innovation then raised the level of ambition further, setting targets of 1,000 Moroccan patents a year and 100 innovative startups a year from 2014 onward, while building a more structured support architecture around the Centre Marocain de l'Innovation and instruments such as INTILAK, TATWIR, and PTR, backed by a MAD 380 million framework for 2011-2014. Those ambitions were high, and the results fell short. The deeper lesson was structural: innovation finance required more than capital alone. It needed a stronger pipeline of investable projects, better founder readiness, and institutions capable of turning technical ideas into fundable companies.

OCTOBER 2009

Presentation of the Maroc Numeric 2013 National Strategy

Presented before His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist him, Maroc Numeric 2013 set out Morocco's national strategy for the information society and digital economy, with a MAD 5.2 billion program focused on broadband access, user-oriented e-government, SME digitalization, and development of the local IT sector.

DECEMBER 2009

Creation of the National Business Environment Committee

Morocco created the CNEA as a high-level public-private coordination body attached to the Head of Government to strengthen interministerial coordination and public-private dialogue on business climate reform.

Morocco's digital strategies have often advanced through recalibration rather than rupture. Maroc Numeric 2013 did not present digital policy as a fresh start, but as a more operational second phase of an agenda already underway, translating national ambition into a MAD 5.2 billion program structured around four strategic priorities. That iterative logic would continue later with Maroc Digital 2020 and Digital Morocco 2030, suggesting a policy tradition in which each cycle refines the instruments of the last rather than starting from scratch. Maroc Numeric 2013 was especially notable for the concreteness of its targets: raising household internet access from about 10% to one third, equipping 100% of public schools, and expanding access points and online public services across the country.

Structuring the Entrepreneurial Base

2010

JULY 2010

Introduction of the Damane Capital Risque Guarantee Mechanism

Damane Capital Risque was introduced through the Caisse Centrale de Garantie (CCG) to guarantee equity and quasi-equity investments made by venture capital firms in Moroccan SMEs, helping address SME undercapitalization.

SEPTEMBER 2010

Launch of Maroc Numeric Fund

Maroc Numeric Fund was launched as a dedicated public-private venture capital vehicle for Moroccan technology startups under the Maroc Numeric 2013 strategy, with backing from public and private institutional investors.

NOVEMBER 2010

Creation of Maroc Numeric Cluster

Maroc Numeric Cluster was created as a public-private cluster to promote Morocco's digital economy and support collaborative and innovative ICT projects.

DECEMBER 2010

Establishment of the Casablanca Finance City Legal Framework

Law No. 44-10 established the Casablanca Finance City (CFC) status, creating the legal basis for a Casablanca-based regional financial hub open to qualifying financial and non-financial companies operating at a regional or international level, with a dedicated incentive framework to attract investment into Africa.

Damane Capital Risque and MNF addressed the same financing gap through different mechanisms. The guarantee mechanism reduced downside risk for venture capital firms investing in SMEs, making equity and quasi-equity deployment easier in a market where bank financing was poorly suited to innovative firms. MNF, by contrast, created a dedicated pool of institutional capital specifically mandated to invest in Moroccan technology startups. One instrument de-risked investment, the other organized it. By deploying both within two months, Morocco began to build the outlines of a financing system rather than relying on a single tool. MNF I went on to make 17 investments by the end of 2016. Its successor, MNF II, was later launched under the Innov Invest initiative and broadened that logic with tickets ranging from MAD 1 million to MAD 10 million across seed to Series A, while eventually extending its scope to startups founded by members of the Moroccan diaspora.

2011

FEBRUARY 2011

Enactment of Morocco's Consumer Protection Framework

Law No. 31-08 established Morocco's modern consumer protection regime, strengthening rights related to information, abusive clauses, withdrawal, and representation, while also regulating distance selling, which became a core legal pillar for consumer protection in e-commerce.

SEPTEMBER 2011

Establishment of the General Directorate for Information Systems Security

Morocco established the DGSSI within the national defense administration as the central authority responsible for information systems security, giving it a national mandate to coordinate cybersecurity policy, protect sensitive and critical systems, and oversee related vigilance and response functions.

The creation of DGSSI within the national defense administration in September 2011 reflected a specific choice about where cybersecurity authority should sit. Rather than placing it under a civilian technology ministry, Morocco anchored it in the defense establishment, giving it responsibility for coordinating cybersecurity strategy, preparing regulatory texts, issuing technical referentials, conducting audits of public-sector systems, and operating national monitoring and incident-response capabilities. This institutional positioning shaped the way cybersecurity matured over the following decade, primarily as a matter of national resilience and protection of sensitive systems. When the cybersecurity law arrived in 2020, it reinforced and widened that architecture, extending the framework to critical infrastructure and a broader set of operators, including telecom and digital service providers.

2012

JULY 2012

Opening of Technopark Rabat

Technopark Rabat opened as the second site in the Technopark network, extending the model beyond Casablanca to support startups, SMEs, and the regional digital entrepreneurship ecosystem in the capital.

2013

DECEMBER 2013

Launch of the OCP Entrepreneurship Network

The OCP Foundation launched the OCP Entrepreneurship Network (OCPEN) to strengthen Morocco's entrepreneurial ecosystem and foster sustainable job and value creation. Working through local, national, and international partners, the program supported project holders and growing businesses with training, technical and financial assistance, access to networks and markets, and dedicated support for innovation, women's entrepreneurship, and social entrepreneurship.

2014

DECEMBER 2014

Enactment of Law No. 103-12 on Credit Institutions and Similar Bodies

Law No. 103-12 modernized Morocco's banking legal framework and created the status of payment institution, broadening the regulated payments ecosystem beyond traditional banks.

Institutionalizing the Startup Ecosystem

2015

FEBRUARY 2015

Modernization of Morocco's Venture Capital and Private Equity Legal Framework

Law No. 18-14 modernized Morocco's legal regime for venture capital and private equity by replacing the earlier OPCR logic with the OPCC framework and formalizing collective investment vehicles for capital investment.

FEBRUARY 2015

Introduction of Telemedicine into Morocco's Medical Practice Framework

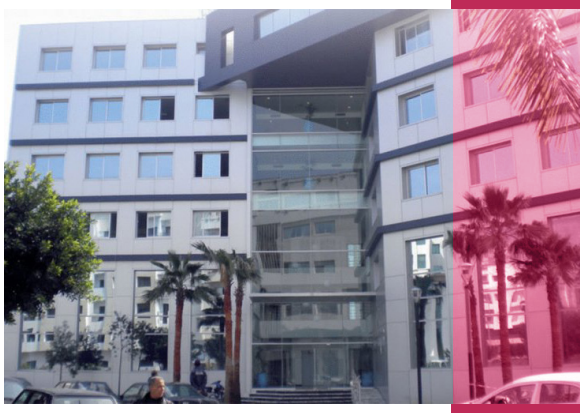
Law No. 131-13 legally recognized telemedicine as part of the practice of medicine and set the foundation for its later regulatory operationalization.

Law No. 103-12 is the clearest example of a reform that mattered most for what it enabled rather than what it explicitly set out to do. Its primary purpose was to modernize the banking framework, but by introducing the payment institution status, it cracked open a door that the fintech sector would later walk through. Non-bank companies could now legally provide payment services, a change that helped make the mobile payment, digital wallet, and payment aggregation models of the late 2010s possible. The telemedicine provision in Law No. 131-13, enacted the same day as the VC modernization, drew little attention in 2015. Five years later, when COVID-19 forced Morocco into lockdown, it became part of the legal basis that later made remote care operational, once the implementing framework was put in place. Not every law is written for the use cases that eventually define its importance, but having the legal scaffolding in place early gave Morocco a head start when those use cases began to emerge.

JULY 2015

Repositioning of ANPME as Maroc PME

ANPME adopted the Maroc PME identity as part of a broader repositioning linked to the Plan d'Accélération Industrielle and the 2015-2020 State-Agency contract-program, expanding its mandate and branding around entrepreneurship, growth, competitiveness, and stronger support for SMEs and very small businesses.



SEPTEMBER 2015

Opening of Technopark Tangier

Technopark Tangier opened as the third site in the Technopark network, extending the model to northern Morocco to support startups, SMEs, and innovation-driven entrepreneurship in the Tangier-Tetouan-Al Hoceima region.

2016

JUNE 2016

Presentation of the Maroc Digital 2020 National Strategy

Presented before His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist him, Maroc Digital 2020 set out Morocco's new national digital strategy, aimed at accelerating digital transformation through stronger e-government, digital governance, interoperability, IT investment, and SME digital competitiveness.

Maroc Digital 2020 set several headline targets, putting 50% of administrative procedures online, reducing the digital divide by 50%, and connecting 20% of Moroccan SMEs, but one of its most lasting contributions was institutional rather than statistical. The strategy helped drive the creation of the Agence de Développement du Digital in 2017, giving Morocco a permanent operational body to implement the state's digital agenda across the economy, public administration, and the broader digital ecosystem. ADD would later launch Startup Hub Maroc and co-organize GITEX Africa Morocco. In that sense, one of Maroc Digital 2020's most important legacies was not only the targets it set, but the institution it helped put in place.

2017

JANUARY 2017

Inauguration of University Mohammed VI Polytechnic

His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist him, inaugurated University Mohammed VI Polytechnic in Benguerir, establishing a research, higher education, and innovation institution positioned as a bridge between Morocco, Africa, and the wider world.

SEPTEMBER 2017

Creation of the Agence de Développement du Digital

Law No. 61-16 created the Agence de Développement du Digital as a public institution tasked with implementing the state's digital development strategy, promoting digital tools and usage, and helping structure Morocco's digital ecosystem.

OCTOBER 2017

Launch of the Innov Invest Fund

The Caisse Centrale de Garantie officially launched the main components of the Innov Invest Fund, establishing a national financing mechanism for innovative startups and project holders across pre-seed, seed, venture capital, and ecosystem support instruments.

The language used to describe Innov Invest often reduces it to a fund. It was not. It was a financing system, designed as a full pipeline from ideation to venture capital, with grants, debt-like instruments, and equity support distributed across stages. The key innovation was embedding labeled support structures into the process, meaning that founders did not just receive money; they were channeled through incubation and acceleration as a condition of the financing journey. This design acknowledged a lesson from earlier programs: capital without preparation produces poor outcomes. The broader mobilization was presented at roughly MAD 700 million over five years, and a cooperation agreement with Bpifrance signed in November 2017 added a cross-border knowledge dimension.

2018

JANUARY 2018

Introduction of a Tax Incentive for Investment in Innovative Startups

Finance Law No. 68-17 for fiscal year 2018 introduced a tax reduction for participation in the capital of young innovative companies in new technologies, including for companies subject to corporate tax, with the eligible participation capped at MAD 200,000 and the reduction capped at 30% of tax due.

JUNE 2018

Signing of the First Closing of Maroc Numeric Fund II

The closing of Maroc Numeric Fund II was signed under the Innov Invest framework, marking the fund's operationalization as a venture capital vehicle dedicated to innovative startups.

2019

SEPTEMBER 2019

Operationalization of Startup Hub for JEI Label Processing

The Agence de Développement du Digital launched the Startup Hub portal to dematerialize applications for the Jeune Entreprise Innovante (JEI) label and enable eligible startups to benefit from the foreign-exchange measure administered by the Office des Changes, initially allowing up to MAD 500,000 per calendar year for eligible imported digital services.

When the Startup Hub portal went live on September 18, 2019, the JEI label it processed was not primarily a badge of honor. It was a foreign-exchange ticket. Approved startups could pay up to MAD 500,000 per calendar year in foreign currency for imported digital services tied to their activity, a privilege that mattered enormously for companies whose core tools, hosting, subscriptions, and international freelancer payments were priced in dollars or euros. The ceiling was raised to MAD 1 million in 2022, reflecting the growing operational needs of labeled startups. This iterative expansion of a single mechanism shows a policy instrument being adjusted in step with the realities of startup operations.

Crisis Management and Ecosystem Resilience

2020

FEBRUARY 2020

Launch of the Intelaka Program

Following implementation agreements signed before His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist him, Intelaka launched a new national framework for financing and supporting entrepreneurs, very small businesses, and project holders through dedicated guarantee and loan products.

MARCH 2020

Inauguration of StartGate

StartGate was inaugurated at UM6P in Benguerir as a dedicated startup campus for entrepreneurship and innovation, designed to support founders from ideation to market access through incubation, experimentation, prototyping, and connections to investors, corporates, and public institutions.

MARCH 2020

Introduction of the Damane Oxygène Emergency Guarantee Mechanism

The Caisse Centrale de Garantie (Now Tamwilcom) launched Damane Oxygène as an exceptional COVID-19 emergency guarantee product to support companies facing cash flow stress during the lockdown phase, covering up to 95% of working-capital overdrafts intended to meet non-deferrable current expenses.

JUNE 2020

Rollout of Relance TPE and Damane Relance

The Caisse Centrale de Garantie deployed Relance TPE and Damane Relance as COVID-19 recovery guarantee products to finance working-capital needs, with Relance TPE targeting very small businesses and Damane Relance targeting larger firms as part of the measures decided by the Comité de Veille Economique.

The collision of Intelaka and COVID-19 is one of the most striking timing coincidences in the timeline. Intelaka was designed in peacetime, triggered by the Royal Speech of October 2019, set in motion by implementation agreements signed on January 27, 2020 before His Majesty King Mohammed VI, may God assist Him, and publicly launched on February 3. Less than two months later, Morocco was in lockdown and Damane Oxygène was being announced. By June, Relance TPE and Damane Relance were deployed as recovery instruments. In a short span, a single institution was simultaneously running a structural entrepreneurship program, an emergency liquidity lifeline, and a post-confinement recovery mechanism. That is three distinct policy modes, creation, survival, and recovery, operating in parallel through one guarantee body. By September, Relance TPE and Damane Relance alone had supported 15,183 enterprises with MAD 22.4 billion in guaranteed loans.

JUNE 2020

Launch of Maroc PME's New Generation of Support Programs

Through Maroc PME, the Ministry launched a new generation of support programs for the recovery of industrial TPMEs, reconfiguring existing schemes into ISTITMAR and MOWAKABA and introducing TATWIR and NAWAT, with simplified access and payment conditions.

Maroc PME's June 2020 launch was more than a recovery measure. It was also a redesign of existing support infrastructure. ISTITMAR and MOWAKABA were reworked versions of earlier programs, updated with more attractive support rates and simpler access conditions, while TATWIR and NAWAT were added to fill gaps. That matters because it shows a practical policy logic: keep the useful tools, improve their terms, and add new ones where needed. ISTITMAR's additional 5% support for projects outside the Tangier-Casablanca Atlantic axis made that logic especially clear, using incentives to push investment beyond Morocco's main economic corridor.

JULY 2020

Enactment of Morocco's National Cybersecurity Legal Framework

Law No. 05-20 established Morocco's national cybersecurity framework by setting a minimum baseline of rules and security measures to strengthen the reliability and resilience of information systems and support digital trust.

NOVEMBER 2020

UM6P Announces Plug and Play's First Office in Africa

UM6P partnered with Plug and Play, with support from OCP Group, to establish Plug and Play Morocco within the StartGate ecosystem in Benguerir. The initiative was scheduled to launch in January 2021 with an initial focus on smart cities.

DECEMBER 2020

Enactment of Law No. 43-20 on Trust Services for Electronic Transactions

Law No. 43-20 was promulgated on December 31, 2020, establishing Morocco's legal framework for trust services, electronic signatures, electronic seals, timestamps, secure electronic registered delivery, and cryptology.

DECEMBER 2020

Creation of the Mohammed VI Investment Fund

Law No. 76-20 created the Mohammed VI Investment Fund as a state-owned public limited company, establishing a strategic investment vehicle to finance structuring projects, strengthen corporate capital, support productive activity, and deploy thematic and sectoral funds in priority areas.

2021

FEBRUARY 2021

Enactment of the Regulatory Framework for Crowdfunding Platforms

Law No. 15-18 on collaborative financing was promulgated by Dahir No. 1-21-24 on February 22, 2021, creating Morocco's legal framework for crowdfunding platforms and regulating three main categories of collaborative financing, investment, loan, and donation.

MARCH 2021

Launch of the TechTransfer Technology Transfer Call for Projects

The ministries in charge of higher education and industry, alongside CNRST, OMPIC, Fondation OCP, and UM6P, launched the TechTransfer Edition 2021 call for projects on March 16, 2021, mobilizing MAD 60 million to valorize Moroccan research results, support technology maturation and prototyping, and strengthen academia-industry linkages.

Most discussion of Morocco's crowdfunding law focuses on donation and loan models. For the startup ecosystem, the provision with the greatest long-term potential is the investment category, which creates a regulated channel for taking equity stakes in companies through platforms supervised by the AMMC. In a market where early-stage funding is still growing, that matters because it opens a legal path for smaller-ticket equity participation alongside more traditional funding channels. The framework also formally recognizes angel investors, or investisseurs providentiels, and provides a declaration regime for angel-investor networks. The practical impact may also take time to materialize, because beyond regulation, investing in startups depends on a broader cultural shift toward higher-risk early-stage investing, something that usually develops gradually as the ecosystem matures and more success stories emerge.

MAY 2021

Transformation of CCG into SNGFE under the Tamwilcom Brand

Following its 2020 transition into the Société Nationale de Garantie et du Financement de l'Entreprise (SNGFE) under Law No. 36-20, CCG adopted Tamwilcom as its new brand identity, marking the institution's public-facing rebranding.

OCTOBER 2021

Institutionalization of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform at Ministerial Level

Morocco created a dedicated ministerial structure for digital transition and administrative reform, strengthening institutional coordination of the country's digital transformation and public sector modernization agenda.

DECEMBER 2021

Opening of Technopark Agadir

Technopark Agadir opened as a new site in the Technopark network in the Souss-Massa region, extending the Technopark model to Agadir to support startups, digital entrepreneurship, innovation, employability, and market access, with capacity for around 100 startups.

Technopark Agadir reached roughly 70% occupancy within months of opening and ran its coworking space at full capacity almost immediately. These numbers matter because Agadir is not a city usually associated with tech entrepreneurship. Its economy is more closely tied to tourism, agriculture, and fisheries. The rapid occupancy suggested that entrepreneurial demand in Morocco's secondary cities depended less on pre-existing tech identity than on the availability of support infrastructure. The Souss-Massa region had founders; what it lacked was an ecosystem structure built around their needs. That experience strengthened the case for extending the Technopark model beyond Morocco's main economic centers.

Laying the Groundwork for Scale

2022

JANUARY 2022

Enhancement of the Foreign Exchange Allowance for JEI

With the entry into force of the 2022 General Instruction on Foreign Exchange Operations, Morocco increased the annual foreign-exchange allowance for young innovative new-technology companies to MAD 1 million, up from MAD 500,000, for eligible e-commerce and imported digital services. IGOC 2022 also introduced, for these companies, the possibility of carrying out certain foreign investment operations.

MARCH 2022

Announcement of the Forsa Program

The government announced Forsa in March 2022 as a national entrepreneurship support and financing program targeting 10,000 project holders in its first edition, with a MAD 1.25 billion 2022 budget and a model combining training, accompaniment, and financing of up to MAD 100,000, including a MAD 10,000 grant.

When Forsa launched in 2022, the government expected to finance 10,000 projects in its first edition. Over 100,000 applications arrived in about two weeks. By mid-May, the count exceeded 150,000 dossiers. That demand shock exposed a gap that no policy document had quantified: the number of Moroccans ready and willing to start a business vastly exceeded what any existing program had been designed to absorb. Forsa ultimately supported roughly 21,200 project holders across its 2022 and 2023 editions, combining training, support, and financing. The question the demand numbers raised was how to build support infrastructure at a scale proportional to the actual entrepreneurial ambition in the country.

APRIL 2022

Launch of the Moroccan Retail Tech Builder

Launched in Rabat, the Moroccan Retail Tech Builder was introduced as Morocco's first venture builder dedicated to the digitalization of the commerce sector, created through a partnership between the Ministry of Industry and Trade, UM6P, and the OCP Foundation to support around 100 retail-tech startups and project holders.

AUGUST 2022

Introduction of the AMMC Fintech Portal

The AMMC introduced its Fintech portal as a dedicated interface for project holders to engage with the Authority and obtain guidance on the legal and regulatory framework applicable to fintech activities linked to the capital market.

DECEMBER 2022

Enactment of Framework Law No. 03-22 Forming the Investment Charter

Framework Law No. 03-22 was promulgated on December 9, 2022, establishing Morocco's new Investment Charter, replacing the 1995 charter, and setting a new investment support architecture built around one main mechanism, specific support mechanisms, and a strengthened National Investment Commission.

2023

MAY 2023

Inaugural Edition of GITEX Africa Morocco in Marrakech

Morocco hosted the first edition of GITEX Africa Morocco in Marrakech from May 31 to June 2, 2023, with the ADD as host under the Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform, positioning the event as a flagship continental platform for technology, startups, investors, and digital ecosystem building.

JUNE 2023

Launch of the New Edition of the Innov Invest Fund

Tamwilcom launched a new edition of the Innov Invest Fund targeting the financing of 800 startups over five years and opening a new selection cycle for support structures focused on ideation, incubation, and pre-acceleration.

The new edition of Innov Invest launched in June 2023 raised the ambition of the mechanism to 800 startups over five years and expanded the support-structure network from 16 partners to a target of up to 20. One of its most important features was a more explicit organization around lifecycle stages, notably idéation, incubation, and pré-accélération, with dedicated support structures positioned on those segments. That granularity reflected several years of operational learning about how startup needs differ from one stage to another.

AUGUST 2023

Upgrade of the OPCC Legal Framework under Law No. 58-22

Law No. 58-22 strengthened Morocco's venture capital and private equity framework by amending the OPCC regime, notably through the creation of OPCC with streamlined operating rules (OPCC-RFA) reserved for professional investors, alongside changes to authorization, supervision, and dissolution procedures.

NOVEMBER 2023

Inauguration of Technopark Essaouira

Technopark Essaouira was inaugurated as the fifth site in the Technopark network, extending the model to Essaouira to support startups, SMEs, and innovation-driven entrepreneurship in the region.

DECEMBER 2023

Signature of the MTNRA-CDG-CDG Invest Framework Partnership for Startup Support and Financing

The Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform, CDG, and CDG Invest signed a framework agreement to structure and implement an offer for the support and financing of Moroccan startups, while also facilitating access to markets and promoting a more competitive digital ecosystem at the national and international levels.

2024

MARCH 2024

Approval of the Fintech Fund by the Bank Al-Maghrib Board

Bank Al-Maghrib Board approved the creation of the Fintech Support Fund, with an initial endowment of MAD 100 million and the possibility of additional contributions from national and international partners.

The approval of the Fintech Support Fund by Bank Al-Maghrib's Board in March 2024 was the result of a gradual sequence rather than a standalone decision. The One Stop Shop Fintech had already been in place since 2019, and by 2023 the Bank was explicitly pointing to the need for a dedicated fund. The March 2024 decision formalized that direction with an initial endowment of MAD 100 million and the possibility of additional contributions from national and international partners. Bank Al-Maghrib's 2024 financial statements then recorded an annual contribution of MAD 30 million to the fund.

APRIL 2024

Launch of the Expression of Interest for Startup Funds by FM6I

In collaboration with the Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform and CDG, the Mohammed VI Investment Fund launched an expression of interest to select management companies responsible for creating and managing funds dedicated to Moroccan startups, as part of a broader effort to better structure startup financing across development stages.

MAY 2024

Unveiling of Bank Al-Maghrib's OSSF Portal

Following the creation of the One Stop Shop Fintech (OSSF) in 2019, Bank Al-Maghrib launched its digital OSSF portal during GITEX Africa 2024 to centralize regulatory information, digitize the fintech support journey, enable secure exchanges, and improve request tracking for project holders.

SEPTEMBER 2024

Introduction of the Digital Morocco 2030 National Strategy

Officially launched on September 25, 2024, Digital Morocco 2030 introduced Morocco's new national roadmap for digital transformation, combining public-sector digitalization, ecosystem development, and digital talent and job creation targets.

What makes Digital Morocco 2030 distinctive is the precision with which it treats the startup ecosystem. The strategy does not refer to startups only in general terms. It assigns them explicit numerical ambitions: 1,000 labeled startups by 2026, 3,000 by 2030, MAD 2 billion in startup fundraising by 2026, MAD 7 billion by 2030, and one to two unicorns by 2030. That level of quantification matters because it turns startup development into a clearly stated policy objective rather than a broad component of digital transformation. It gives the ecosystem a more concrete horizon and makes progress easier to track over time.

The Tipping Point

2025

JANUARY 2025

Creation of the Morocco Fintech Center

Bank Al-Maghrib and public-private stakeholders established the Morocco Fintech Center (MFC) as a non-profit national hub dedicated to financial innovation and the structuring of Morocco's fintech ecosystem, with a mandate to support fintechs and innovative project leaders through guidance, incubation, acceleration, skills development, regulatory orientation, and access-to-finance support.

The founding assembly of the Morocco Fintech Center reflected a high degree of institutional coordination across Morocco's public, financial, and academic spheres. Both relevant ministries, all three financial regulators, FM6I, Tamwilcom, ADD, two universities, and major financial institutions were represented from the outset. What made the structure notable was not just the number of actors involved, but the fact that public authorities, regulators, financial institutions, academia, and ecosystem enablers were brought into the same governance framework from the outset. That gave the center a broader institutional base than a purely regulator-led or purely private-sector initiative would have had.

MARCH 2025

Nationwide Rollout of OMPIC's Electronic Company Creation Platform

Following a pilot phase launched in Rabat in February 2023 and a gradual territorial rollout, OMPIC generalized the DirectEntreprise electronic company creation platform across the Kingdom, providing a single digital interface for incorporation formalities with the main public bodies involved in business registration.

APRIL 2025

Launch of the National Program for Research, Development and Innovation 2025-2028

The Ministry of Higher Education, Scientific Research and Innovation, the OCP Foundation, the CNRST, and UM6P officially launched the first edition of PNARDI on April 7, 2025 in Benguerir, with a MAD 1 billion four-year co-financing envelope to strengthen research infrastructure, support scientific talent, and accelerate innovation and technology transfer.

APRIL 2025

Third Edition of GITEX Africa Morocco in Marrakech

Following two successful editions, GITEX Africa Morocco returned to Marrakech from April 14 to 16, 2025, bringing together more than 45,000 participants and over 1,400 exhibitors from more than 130 countries, further reinforcing Morocco's role as a continental platform for technology, startups, investors, and digital ecosystem building.

Between GITEX Africa's first edition in 2023 and its third in 2025, the event expanded materially in size and reach. The inaugural edition brought together more than 900 exhibitors, startups, and delegations from 95 countries. By 2025, the event had grown to more than 45,000 participants, over 1,400 exhibitors from more than 130 countries, along with more than 350 investors and 650 government entities. That growth mattered in practical terms because it gave Moroccan startups broader exposure to investors and partners while giving Morocco a recurring platform to project its digital and startup ecosystem internationally.

JUNE 2025

Launch of Morocco Accelerator in Partnership with Plug and Play

Technopark Morocco and Plug and Play launched the Morocco Accelerator through a strategic partnership signed in Casablanca, introducing a three-month acceleration program designed to support more than 60 Moroccan startups over two years through mentorship, technological expertise, investor access, and integration into international innovation networks.

JULY 2025

Publication of the Decree Establishing the TPME Support Mechanism

Following its inclusion in Framework Law No. 03-22 as one of the Charter's four support mechanisms, the TPME-specific support scheme was further defined by Decree No. 2.25.342, which established a dedicated incentive framework based on employment creation, territorial incentives, and priority activities.

JULY 2025

Signature of the Tripartite Agreement for the Creation of an Engineering School Dedicated to Digital Transition and AI

A tripartite agreement was signed for the creation of the École Supérieure d'Ingénieurs en Transition Numérique, Digital et Intelligence Artificielle, as well as the development of specialized training programs in these fields.

JULY 2025

Attribution of Morocco's 5G Licenses

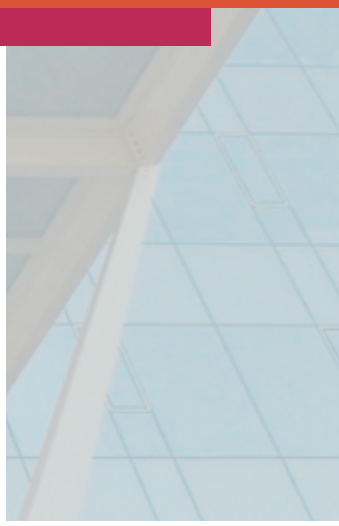
Following the call for competition launched by the ANRT, Morocco awarded 5G licenses to the country's three national mobile operators, with commitments that should support 45% population coverage by end-2026 and 85% by end-2030, alongside nearly MAD 80 billion in planned 5G investment and operating expenditure through 2035.

The 5G license awards in July 2025 were not just a telecom milestone. The commitments attached to the three licenses, 45% population coverage by end-2026, 85% by end-2030, and nearly MAD 80 billion in planned investment and operating expenditure through 2035, effectively set part of the infrastructure base on which the next generation of digital businesses will operate. For startups building IoT applications, industrial automation tools, telemedicine platforms, or real-time data services, 5G is not a marginal upgrade. It is the connectivity layer that makes certain products more viable at scale.

AUGUST 2025

Preparation of the Preliminary Draft Law on Crypto-Assets

Preliminary Draft Law No. 42.25, dated August 5, 2025, proposed Morocco's first legal framework for crypto-asset issuance, trading, custody, and crypto-asset service providers.



SEPTEMBER 2025

Signature of the MoU between MTNRA and Mistral AI for Digital Innovation

The Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform and Mistral AI signed a memorandum of understanding in Rabat to advance local AI skills, applied research, knowledge transfer, startup emergence, industrial AI use cases, and the responsible deployment of artificial intelligence in Morocco.

NOVEMBER 2025

Signature of the Partnership Agreement between MTNRA and Keiretsu Forum MENA

The Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform signed a partnership agreement with Keiretsu Forum MENA in Rabat on November 19, 2025 to strengthen Morocco's startup ecosystem by connecting local startups with international investors, attracting private investment, and supporting their integration into global business networks.

NOVEMBER 2025

Launch of the Catalytic Support Mechanism for Startup Funds

The MTNRA, the Ministry of Economy and Finance, FM6I, CDG, and Tamwilcom signed an agreement launching a catalytic support mechanism for startup funds, with Tamwilcom operationalizing the scheme through first-loss risk coverage or direct investment for startup funds selected under the FM6I call. A first list of nine preselected fund managers was also announced, with projected investment of nearly MAD 2.5 billion in Moroccan startups.

The catalytic support mechanism launched in November 2025 drew strong international interest from the outset. Of the 47 applications submitted under the FM6I process, 33 were international and 2 were mixed consortiums, showing that Morocco's startup market was already attracting attention from global venture-capital managers once a structured de-risking framework was put in place. The first nine preselected management companies are expected to mobilize nearly MAD 2.5 billion for Moroccan startups, making the mechanism a channel for attracting external capital into the ecosystem.

DECEMBER 2025

Publication of Bank Al-Maghrib's Fintech Regulatory Pathway Guide

Bank Al-Maghrib published its Guide du parcours Fintech auprès de Bank Al-Maghrib, providing project holders with structured guidance on their regulatory pathway and on the process put in place by the Bank to support fintech initiatives.

DECEMBER 2025

Inauguration of StartGate Rabat

UM6P inaugurated StartGate Rabat on December 11, 2025, extending the StartGate model first launched in Benguerir and establishing a new startup campus in Rabat to strengthen links between startups, institutional stakeholders, investors, and economic actors.

DECEMBER 2025

Official Deployment of the Startup Venture Building Offering

Following the October 2024 call for expressions of interest, the Startup Venture Building offering was officially deployed in Rabat through contracts signed with six selected providers, under a MAD 700+ million mechanism targeting more than 800 startups over three years.

The Startup Venture Building offering, deployed on December 17, 2025, marked a new scale in Morocco's startup support architecture: more than MAD 700 million, a target of over 800 startups over three years, and implementation contracts signed with six selected support and acceleration structures. The question that will ultimately define VB's success is whether the startups coming through the mechanism become fundable, meaning whether they reach a stage at which private investors, including the startup fund managers selected under the catalytic mechanism, choose to invest.

Laying the Foundations (2000-2009)

The period from 2000 to 2009 marked the construction of the institutional and legal foundations that would later support Morocco's startup ecosystem. During these years, public action focused on building the core enabling environment for private initiative, innovation, and investment. The establishment or consolidation of key institutions such as OMPIC, ANAPEC, CNRST, the Regional Investment Centers, and ANPME created the first layer of public infrastructure for entrepreneurship. These bodies addressed essential functions that remain central to ecosystem development today, including intellectual property protection, employment intermediation, research coordination, investment facilitation, and SME support.

At the same time, Morocco began to position digital transformation as a strategic national priority. The first e-Maroc strategy and, later, e-Maroc 2010 reflected an early recognition that digitalization would be a lever for administrative modernization, economic competitiveness, and social inclusion. These strategies were not yet startup policies in the contemporary sense, but they established a broader policy logic in which digital access, enterprise modernization, skills development, and online public services were treated as interconnected priorities. This was a decisive step in creating a national environment in which future technology entrepreneurship could emerge.

The same period also saw the gradual modernization of the legal framework governing business and innovation. The introduction of the Labor Code, the General Tax Code, the law on electronic exchange of legal data, the venture capital regime under Law No. 41-05, and the personal data protection framework under Law No. 09-08 all contributed to a more structured and predictable business environment. In parallel, the operational launch of Innovation TIC and the Maroc Innovation initiative signaled an increasing public interest in linking research, technology, and enterprise creation. While the ecosystem was still at an early stage, the decade established the institutional vocabulary and policy instruments that would make later startup-focused interventions possible.

Technopark Casablanca occupies a particularly important place in this first phase. Its inauguration symbolized the emergence of a more visible and organized support space for technology companies and innovative entrepreneurs. Beyond its physical function, the Technopark model introduced an early ecosystem-building logic centered on concentration, support services, networking, and sectoral specialization. In that sense, the 2000s were not simply a preparatory decade. They were the period in which Morocco began to assemble the public architecture required for a modern entrepreneurial economy.

Structuring the Entrepreneurial Base (2010-2014)

Between 2010 and 2014, Morocco moved from institution-building toward the structuring of a more operational entrepreneurial base. If the previous decade laid the groundwork, this period focused on making support mechanisms more targeted, more financial, and more accessible to firms with growth potential. Measures such as Damane Capital Risque, Maroc Numeric Fund, and the creation of Maroc Numeric Cluster reflected a shift toward more specialized instruments designed to stimulate innovation, investment, and digital entrepreneurship.

This phase was also characterized by a stronger articulation between digital transformation and enterprise development. Maroc Numeric 2013 had already framed digital modernization as a national objective, but the years that followed saw a clearer effort to translate that orientation into operational mechanisms. Dedicated financing tools, cluster initiatives, and the territorial extension of the Technopark network all contributed to creating a more tangible support ecosystem for entrepreneurs and innovative SMEs. The opening of Technopark Rabat illustrated this territorial logic,

extending the entrepreneurship support model beyond Casablanca and anchoring it more firmly in Morocco's regional innovation landscape.

The period also strengthened the financial and regulatory environment in which future startups would operate. The legal framework for Casablanca Finance City helped position Morocco as a regional financial platform, while the consumer protection law and the creation of the DGSSI reinforced important dimensions of trust, security, and regulatory modernization in the digital economy. The enactment of Law No. 103-12 on credit institutions and similar bodies was especially significant, as it modernized the banking framework and introduced the status of payment institution. In retrospect, this reform helped prepare the legal terrain for subsequent fintech development and for a broader diversification of financial services actors.

Overall, this was the stage in which Morocco's entrepreneurship agenda became more structured and more implementation-oriented. Support was no longer limited to broad institutional or legal foundations. It increasingly took the form of dedicated vehicles, targeted financial mechanisms, specialized clusters, and territorially distributed support infrastructure. The ecosystem was still in formation, but its main operational pillars were becoming more visible.

Institutionalizing the Startup Ecosystem (2015-2019)

The years from 2015 to 2019 marked an important transition from general entrepreneurship support toward a more explicit startup ecosystem approach. During this period, Morocco's policy architecture became more specialized, more coordinated, and more aligned with the needs of innovative companies across their early stages of development. This was evident in both the evolution of the financing framework and the emergence of a more structured digital governance model.

A major step in this transition was the modernization of the venture capital and private equity framework through Law No. 18-14. By broadening and updating the legal regime for capital investment vehicles, Morocco improved the institutional conditions for equity financing and strengthened the foundations of a more mature investment market. This reform was complemented by the repositioning of ANPME as Maroc PME, which embodied a wider vision of enterprise support centered on growth, competitiveness, and entrepreneurship. Together, these developments signaled an evolution in public policy, from supporting small businesses as a category to recognizing the need for differentiated instruments adapted to firms with innovation and scaling potential.

This period also brought significant advances in digital governance. Maroc Digital 2020 set out a renewed digital transformation agenda, while the creation of the Agence de Développement du Digital gave the state a dedicated implementation vehicle capable of structuring, coordinating, and accelerating digital development efforts. The establishment of ADD was particularly important because it strengthened institutional continuity in a domain that had previously depended more heavily on strategy documents than on a permanent operational actor. With ADD, digital policy gained a clearer center of gravity.

At the ecosystem level, the launch and operationalization of Innov Invest represented a turning point. Rather than offering a single financing product, the mechanism introduced a broader pipeline covering ideation, pre-seed, seed, and venture support, while also mobilizing support structures around startup development. This was a meaningful institutional innovation, because it acknowledged that startup emergence depends not only on capital, but also on accompaniment, selection, incubation, and preparation for investment. The launch of Maroc Numeric Fund II, the Startup Hub portal, and the processing of the JEI label further reinforced that logic by making parts of the ecosystem more legible and more usable for founders.

The territorial expansion of the Technopark network during this period also deserves attention. With the opening of Technopark Tangier, the model continued to extend geographically, helping diffuse

startup support capacities beyond the country's traditional economic centers. At the same time, the inauguration of University Mohammed VI Polytechnic in Benguerir introduced a major institutional asset for the future innovation ecosystem, strengthening Morocco's long-term ability to connect higher education, research, entrepreneurship, and technology transfer.

In sum, the 2015-2019 period can be understood as the phase in which Morocco began to institutionalize startup support more clearly. Financing instruments, digital governance, territorial support infrastructure, and innovation-oriented public actors increasingly formed part of a coherent ecosystem-building trajectory.

Crisis Management and Ecosystem Resilience (2020-2021)

The period from 2020 to 2021 demonstrated the resilience and adaptability of Morocco's entrepreneurial support system in the face of an exceptional global shock. Rather than interrupting the ecosystem's development, the COVID-19 crisis accelerated the deployment of several public mechanisms designed both to preserve economic continuity and to sustain entrepreneurial momentum. This dual dynamic, crisis response combined with continued ecosystem building, defines the significance of the period.

The launch of Intelaka early in 2020 reflected a strong national commitment to expanding access to finance for entrepreneurs, project holders, and very small businesses. With dedicated guarantee and lending products, preferential conditions, and a broad target base, the program strengthened the financing architecture available to emerging businesses across the country. Although its early implementation coincided with the pandemic, Intelaka quickly became one of Morocco's flagship entrepreneurship support mechanisms and contributed to deepening the inclusiveness of the financing landscape.

As the health crisis intensified, Morocco rapidly deployed emergency and recovery tools through Damane Oxygène, Relance TPE, and Damane Relance. These mechanisms played a stabilizing role by helping firms preserve liquidity, cover operating expenses, and resume activity. Their scale and speed highlighted the capacity of public financial institutions to act in a countercyclical manner while maintaining support for the productive fabric. For the broader ecosystem, these interventions were important not only because they protected businesses during a crisis, but also because they reinforced trust in the state's capacity to adapt financing policy to changing economic conditions.

At the same time, the period produced significant advances in ecosystem infrastructure and institutional modernization. StartGate Benguerir introduced a new entrepreneurship campus model linked to incubation, prototyping, market access, and founder support, enriching Morocco's support landscape with a high-potential platform anchored in UM6P's broader innovation environment. Maroc PME's new generation of support programs also demonstrated the ability of existing institutions to recalibrate their tools in response to new constraints and new opportunities.

The legal and institutional framework continued to deepen as well. The national cybersecurity law, the law on trust services for electronic transactions, and the crowdfunding framework all contributed to a more modern and secure environment for digital activity, digital entrepreneurship, and alternative financing channels. The transformation of CCG into SNGFE, later publicly branded as Tamwilcom, also marked an important institutional evolution, signaling a broader and more strategic approach to guarantee and enterprise financing policy.

Finally, the institutionalization of digital transition and administrative reform at ministerial level gave Morocco's digital agenda stronger political visibility and more direct coordination capacity. This was an important signal. Even under crisis conditions, digital transformation, entrepreneurship, and innovation remained national priorities. As a result, the 2020-2021 period should be read not only as a phase of resilience, but also as a phase of institutional consolidation.

Laying the Groundwork for Scale (2022-2024)

The years 2022 to 2024 represent a new phase in Morocco's startup policy trajectory, one centered on preparing the ecosystem for greater scale, stronger coordination, and higher international visibility. By this stage, the challenge was no longer simply to create institutions or pilot mechanisms. It was to deepen support structures, expand financing pathways, strengthen regulatory interfaces, and define a more ambitious national vision for digital and startup development.

Several initiatives launched during this period reflected a more deliberate effort to build scale-ready support platforms. Forsa introduced a large national entrepreneurship support program combining training, accompaniment, and financing. The Moroccan Retail Tech Builder added a venture-building model focused on commerce digitalization, showing that public support was becoming more sector-specific and more sophisticated in its approach. These programs illustrate a broader evolution in policy design, with increasing attention given to founder journeys, market use cases, and the practical conditions of venture creation.

On the regulatory side, the period saw a clear improvement in the quality of institutional interfaces available to innovators. The AMMC fintech portal and the digitalization of Bank Al-Maghrib's One Stop Shop Fintech process both contributed to a more accessible and more navigable environment for fintech project holders. These developments were important because they reduced some of the informational and procedural friction often associated with regulated innovation. In doing so, they helped strengthen the relationship between emerging ventures and the public authorities responsible for supervising financial activity.

At the same time, Morocco continued to strengthen its broader investment and financing architecture. The enactment of the new Investment Charter created a renewed national framework for private investment support and established several mechanisms that would later become more directly relevant for smaller firms and startups. The relaunch of Innov Invest introduced a refreshed financing pipeline for innovative startups, while the FM6I expression of interest for startup funds signaled a new ambition to structure financing across the full startup lifecycle, from pre-seed to more advanced stages. The upgrade of the OPCC framework under Law No. 58-22 further reinforced this capital market dimension by improving the attractiveness and flexibility of Morocco's investment vehicle regime.

This period also marked a sharp increase in Morocco's continental and international positioning. The inaugural edition of GITEX Africa in Marrakech significantly raised the country's profile as a convening platform for technology, startups, and investors. More than a major event, it became a visible expression of Morocco's ambition to act as a digital and entrepreneurial gateway between Africa and the wider world. That visibility dynamic was then reinforced by the official launch of Digital Morocco 2030 in September 2024.

Digital Morocco 2030 gave the ecosystem a clearer long-term horizon. By articulating targets for digital jobs, startup labeling, fundraising, and public-service digitalization, the strategy transformed a set of separate initiatives into a more legible national ambition. In that sense, the 2022-2024 period should be interpreted as the moment when Morocco's startup and digital agenda moved from ecosystem strengthening to scale preparation.

The Tipping Point (2025)

The year 2025 stands out as a decisive moment in the evolution of Morocco's startup ecosystem. More than a continuation of previous efforts, it marks a phase in which multiple strategic tracks matured simultaneously and began to operate at a different level of density, coordination, and ambition. What makes 2025 distinctive is not the existence of one single flagship reform, but the convergence of capital, talent, infrastructure, regulation, and institutional execution within the same year. This convergence gives 2025 the character of a tipping point.

One of the clearest signals of this shift was the strengthening of ecosystem infrastructure and support platforms. The creation of the Morocco Fintech Center introduced a dedicated national hub for financial innovation, bringing together regulators, ministries, public institutions, universities, financial actors, and ecosystem stakeholders around a shared support framework. This was a significant step in structuring fintech development, not only through regulation but through incubation, acceleration, skills development, and ecosystem coordination. In parallel, the inauguration of StartGate Rabat extended the StartGate model beyond Benguerir and reinforced the role of startup campuses as interfaces between founders, institutions, investors, and strategic sectors of the economy.

A second defining feature of 2025 was the acceleration of capital market structuring for startups. The launch of the catalytic support mechanism for startup funds, backed by MTNRA, the Ministry of Economy and Finance, FM6I, CDG, and Tamwilcom, translated a long-prepared financing agenda into an operational de-risking instrument for venture capital funds. This mattered because it moved public action beyond direct support to founders and into the structuring of the investment industry itself. The same logic was visible in the official deployment of the Startup Venture Building offering, which established a large-scale mechanism combining support and financing across the startup lifecycle. Together, these measures suggest that Morocco entered a new stage in which the objective was no longer only to stimulate startup creation, but to build a more durable and more investable pipeline.

This capital-side strengthening was complemented by new channels for international investor connectivity. The partnership agreement with Keiretsu Forum MENA aimed to facilitate relations between Moroccan startups and international angel investors, while the accelerator partnership between Technopark Morocco and Plug and Play connected local startups to one of the world's most recognizable open innovation platforms. These initiatives expanded the ecosystem's external interfaces and reinforced the idea that Moroccan startups should be supported not only domestically, but also through global networks of mentorship, capital, and market access.

The year also brought visible progress in business environment modernization. OMPIC's nationwide rollout of the DirectEntreprise platform generalized electronic company creation across the Kingdom and simplified one of the most important administrative steps in the entrepreneurial journey. This kind of reform may appear procedural, but it is in fact highly strategic. By digitizing incorporation at national scale, Morocco strengthened the usability, accessibility, and efficiency of the formal business creation process. The TPME mechanism under the Investment Charter also became operational in 2025, turning a previously established policy commitment into a concrete support instrument with direct relevance for smaller firms and emerging ventures.

At the same time, Morocco deepened the long-term capability layers required for innovation-led growth. The launch of PNARDI 2025-2028 represented an important effort to strengthen research excellence, scientific infrastructure, talent mobilization, and technology transfer. Its significance lies in the fact that it connects research policy more directly to national development priorities and to the broader innovation economy. In the same spirit, the signature of the agreement to create a specialized engineering school dedicated to digital transition, digital technologies, and artificial intelligence reflected a stronger policy focus on future-oriented skills and human capital formation.

These initiatives indicate that 2025 was not only about startups as firms, but also about the wider ecosystem conditions, research capacity, specialized talent, and institutional partnerships, needed to sustain innovation over time.

The digital and technological dimension of 2025 was equally significant. The attribution of 5G licenses prepared the next generation of connectivity infrastructure and created conditions for future advances in digital services, industrial use cases, and emerging technology applications. The memorandum of understanding signed between MTNRA and Mistral AI added an international knowledge-transfer dimension to Morocco's AI agenda, linking local capacity building with applied research and startup development. Meanwhile, the publication of the preliminary draft law on crypto-assets and the release of Bank Al-Maghrib's Fintech regulatory pathway guide reflected a more mature and forward-looking regulatory posture. Rather than remaining outside new technological developments, Moroccan institutions increasingly moved to frame them, guide them, and organize their development within a clearer legal and supervisory environment.

The visibility and convening power of the ecosystem also reached a new level in 2025. The third edition of GITEX Africa Morocco reinforced the country's role as one of the leading technology gathering points on the continent. At this stage, the event was no longer simply a showcase. It had become part of Morocco's broader ecosystem diplomacy, strengthening the country's attractiveness to startups, investors, technology firms, and institutional partners from across Africa and beyond. This international dimension matters because scale in innovation ecosystems increasingly depends on the ability to attract flows of talent, capital, knowledge, and partnerships across borders.

Taken together, the developments of 2025 suggest a qualitative change in Morocco's startup policy trajectory. Earlier years had built institutions, launched mechanisms, and clarified priorities. In 2025, many of those efforts began to align at once. Financing mechanisms became more sophisticated, startup support platforms became more connected, digital and regulatory

modernization advanced in parallel, and research and talent policies were more clearly linked to innovation outcomes. This multi-layered acceleration is what gives 2025 its strategic importance. It marks the transition from ecosystem construction to ecosystem scaling.

Viewed across the full 2000-2025 sequence, Morocco's policy trajectory reveals a steady progression from foundational institution-building to a more integrated and scale-oriented ecosystem strategy. The early 2000s established the legal and institutional base. The early 2010s structured the entrepreneurial environment through more operational and financial tools. The second half of the 2010s institutionalized startup support more explicitly through digital governance, financing pipelines, and ecosystem coordination. The 2020-2021 period demonstrated resilience and continuity under crisis conditions. The 2022-2024 period laid the groundwork for scale through stronger financing, improved regulatory interfaces, and a clearer national digital ambition. Finally, 2025 brought these accumulated layers into sharper alignment.

The result is a policy narrative defined by cumulative construction rather than isolated interventions. Morocco's startup ecosystem did not emerge from a single reform or a single program. It has been built progressively through the interaction of digital policy, investment policy, research policy, business environment reform, public financing mechanisms, and institution-building. In that broader trajectory, 2025 appears as the moment when these different strands began to converge more visibly into a national scale-up dynamic.

Interview with

Driss Lemjaouri

Director of Ecosystems and Digital Entrepreneurship, Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform

When you assessed Morocco's startup ecosystem, what were the main structural gaps that required intervention?

Driss Lemjaouri: Our diagnostic reveals two critical structural gaps within Morocco's startup ecosystem. First, the market was not yet generating a sufficiently robust pipeline of high-quality deal flow. Second, even when promising ventures emerged locally, they often encountered significant barriers to appropriate growth financing domestically as they matured — a constraint that, in certain cases, compelled founders to seek foreign capital or relocate entirely to more venture-capital-friendly markets.

To address this, the Ministry's ambition extended well beyond isolated intervention at a single point in the value chain to encompass support across the entire startup journey. This meant strengthening the pipeline of emerging startups, reinforcing the broader support infrastructure, and ensuring continuity of financing across every stage of growth. Our overarching objective has been to establish a comprehensive public framework — one that enables startups to emerge, structure themselves appropriately, secure early-stage support, and ultimately scale from Morocco with strong, sustainable long-term potential.

What distinguishes the government's current approach from earlier forms of startup support?

Driss Lemjaouri: What distinguishes our current approach is the combination of institutional continuity and strategic reinforcement. Morocco had already established meaningful foundations through earlier public initiatives, notably the Innov Invest programme and the ecosystem that developed around it. Today's approach builds directly upon those foundations, integrating them within a more cohesive national framework for digital innovation.

Our intent has been to provide entrepreneurs, investors, and support organizations with a single, coherent trajectory rather than a fragmented series of disconnected interventions. In this respect, the current approach represents both a continuation of, and an upgrade to, what came before: a deliberate shift from isolated support mechanisms toward a unified national architecture for innovation — one that aligns startup creation, corporate structuring, and

access to financing within a single, coherent national vision.

What concrete mechanisms are now being put in place to support startups across their lifecycle?

Driss Lemjaouri: Our approach rests on a foundational principle: support must span the full lifecycle of a startup. A startup's financing journey does not begin with venture capital. In its earliest phase, it typically relies on personal savings and, in some instances, crowdfunding. Beyond that initial stage, startups require progressive access to grants, public support mechanisms, and, over time, instruments such as interest-free loans, concessional loans, and eventually venture capital. Our intent is to prevent founders from being pushed prematurely into equity financing, and instead to align each financing instrument precisely with the corresponding stage of development.

This lifecycle-based approach also requires stronger support structures. While Morocco already benefited from an initial layer of ecosystem operators established under earlier public initiatives, our objective has been to reinforce this layer, elevate the quality and capability of these operators, and attract international players to establish local teams and transfer know-how — particularly in the fields of acceleration and scale-up.

At the founder level, we are introducing a dedicated 'living stipend' mechanism, designed to support professionals who leave salaried employment to launch a startup. This instrument covers up to 70% of prior salary, capped at MAD 40,000 gross per month, for a duration of up to twelve months. The rationale is straightforward: experienced professionals often bring stronger execution capacity to a venture, yet may hesitate to make the transition given their personal financial obligations. This mechanism is designed to remove precisely that friction.

On the financing side, our venture capital track was conceived as a continuation of earlier public action, but with considerably broader scope. It was opened to both Moroccan and international fund managers, with the dual aim of mobilizing additional capital and bringing international expertise capable of helping Moroccan startups scale beyond the domestic market. The call for expressions of interest attracted 47 applications, roughly two-thirds of them from international funds, resulting in the selection of nine fund management companies.

The mechanism was also designed around a deliberately broader definition of what constitutes a 'Moroccan startup.' Beyond companies legally established in Morocco, this definition extends to startups domiciled abroad that maintain a genuine productive base within the Kingdom — particularly where local development, R&D, and skills transfer are involved. Selected management companies may also invest in startups not yet established in Morocco, provided they commit to establishing local operations within a defined timeframe.

Finally, the Ministry's catalytic investment track is endowed with MAD 400 million, with the ambition of helping leverage approximately MAD 2.5 billion in total public and private investment — particularly toward the least-served and highest-risk segments of the market. This track was designed as an innovative, venture-capital-friendly mechanism, built around a first-loss, junior-tranche structure intended to absorb early losses in the riskiest segments and thereby more effectively crowd in additional private capital.

Beyond financing, what guiding approach is the government taking to address the remaining bottlenecks facing startups?

Driss Lemjaouri: The Ministry's approach to addressing the remaining bottlenecks facing startups has been pragmatic and incremental, rather than predicated on the arrival of a single, comprehensive legal instrument capable of resolving every issue at once. The priority has been to activate concrete levers quickly, to address each issue according to the maturity of the relevant partners, and to adopt a problem-solving posture rather than a purely legal or theoretical one. In practice, this means tackling each structural issue on its own terms whenever doing so allows the market to be activated faster and more effectively.

This also reflects a broader principle underpinning our public action: the perceived solution is not always the real underlying problem. For example, certain actors may frame their needs primarily in fiscal terms, when the more fundamental issue is, in fact, access to financing across the startup lifecycle. The objective, therefore, has consistently been to respond to the root need rather than

simply to the perceived remedy.

Another critical bottleneck concerns access to demand — particularly public demand. Public procurement remains, globally, a major growth lever for innovative companies, and Morocco has made meaningful progress in this direction through the evolution of its public procurement framework. The 2023 decree introduced, for the first time, the concepts of innovative purchasing (achat innovant) and spontaneous bids (offre spontanée), legally empowering innovative companies to approach public administrations directly with concrete solutions to defined problems. The next challenge is now operational in nature: ensuring that these regulatory openings translate into practical, usable opportunities from which startups can genuinely benefit.

Why does Morocco believe it can position itself as an attractive hub for startups and innovation?

Driss Lemjaouri: Morocco's attractiveness as a hub for startups and innovation stems from a convergence of several factors. First, there is continuity in public action and a long-term strategic horizon that gives both investors and founders greater confidence. When innovation and investment are typically approached on a five-to-ten-year basis, long-term visibility matters enormously. In this respect, Morocco's trajectory is not built around short-term cycles, but is guided by a clear national vision extending to 2030 and beyond.

Second, the country benefits from a broader, collaborative ecosystem dynamic. The progress being made in digital innovation is not the achievement of a single institution, but the cumulative result of coordinated efforts across public and private stakeholders alike. While this momentum is more visible today than ever, it builds directly on earlier foundations, including prior digital strategies and mechanisms.

Third, Morocco continues to reinforce the practical foundations of its digital economy — encompassing dedicated support mechanisms, international openness, digital infrastructure, data and cloud ambitions, and a positioning that draws on geography, institutional trust, and international partnerships. Our ambition extends well beyond simply attracting capital: we are building an environment in which startups can establish genuine operations, scale sustainably, transfer know-how, and generate long-term value directly from Morocco.

Ultimately, the 2030 horizon is, in itself, a strategic opportunity. It should not be viewed merely as a milestone, but as a broader moment of digital transformation across sectors — from mobility and tourism to platforms, services, and AI-enabled experiences. In this sense, Morocco's positioning is not only institutional or geographic in nature, but increasingly project-driven and future-oriented.

By 2030, what should success look like for Morocco's startup ecosystem?

Driss Lemjaouri: For me, the defining measure of success is sovereignty. The most important outcome for any country is not simply the production of 'unicorns' — however symbolically significant these may be — but rather whether that country is building genuine technological sovereignty through an ecosystem capable of generating its own innovation.

In concrete terms, true success translates into startups generating measurable impact within the country: expanding market-share, creating high-value employment, generating localized intellectual property and contributing meaningfully to the digitalization of Morocco's own public and private systems.

By 2030, the real objective is to strengthen Morocco's own innovation capacity and technological base so that startups become a primary driver of national socio-economic development and long-term global competitiveness. Ultimately, that is what a sustainable ecosystem success should look like.

The financing of the earliest stages of startup creation and initial development has long been one of the major obstacles to promoting innovative entrepreneurship in Morocco. These stages are often considered too risky by private investors, who are reluctant to enter alone, making public intervention necessary to play a catalytic role.

The Innov Invest Fund, a public initiative managed by Tamwilcom, formerly CCG, on behalf of the Ministry of Economy and Finance, was launched at the end of 2017 with support from the World Bank. Its objective is to help reduce this gap through a structured financing offer adapted to each stage of innovation maturity. Its deployment has been carried out progressively with ecosystem actors, including incubators, clusters, honor loan associations, seed funds, and venture capital funds.

Tamwilcom's interventions under F2I have helped energize the startup ecosystem and demonstrate its potential. Over 500 startups have been supported through financing exceeding 100 million dirhams in the form of grants and loans.

Building on this impact, since 2024, Tamwilcom has introduced a more refined segmentation of the support journey, in collaboration with around ten local partner support structures operating across the ideation, incubation, and pre-acceleration segments.

In collaboration with the International Finance Corporation, IFC, this journey was recently strengthened through Tamwilcom's partnership with Flat6Labs, one of the leading startup accelerators in the MENA region. The objective is to prepare startups for venture capital fundraising, a critical stage where many fail due to insufficient structuring.

Through the financing continuum proposed by Tamwilcom, F2I's partner support structures help enrich the deal flow for seed and venture capital funds, creating a ripple effect that goes beyond direct financing.

Since the third edition, over 15 calls for projects have been launched, supporting more than 150 founders and channeling over 20 million dirhams in grants and loans to more than 60 pre-seed startups. The sectors benefiting from this support map out the landscape of Moroccan innovation, with retailtech accounting for 19%, cleantech for 16%, edtech and agritech for 7% each, and fintech, healthtech, and entertainment for 6% each.

In parallel, and to stimulate the highly risky venture capital segment, four public-private seed and venture capital funds were structured under F2I over the 2018 to 2024 period, with a total size exceeding 1 billion dirhams. These vehicles have invested more than 380 million dirhams in around 40 startups operating across various verticals, including agritech, fintech, industry 4.0, cleantech, health, big data, and AI.

Tamwilcom has now launched a new ambitious and proactive strategy for the 2026 to 2030 period, named Jossour 2030. This new strategy continues to place startups at the center of its priorities, in support of public strategies such as the national "Digital Morocco 2030" vision.

In this context, partnerships have been concluded with the Ministry of Digital Transition and Administrative Reform, MTNRA, to support technology startups through the deployment of two offers:

Venture Building offer, Startup VB

This offer provides structured support from prototyping to acceleration, combined with a financing mechanism deployed by six support operators, four of them international (500 Global, Renew Capital, Flat6Labs, OST), alongside Technopark and CEED.

The Startup VB offer aims to support over 800 startups nationwide over a three-year period, mobilizing a total budget of more than 700 million dirhams. This mechanism seeks to enable the emergence of a new generation of innovative startups that can become Morocco's future national digital champions and sustainably strengthen the country's digital economy.

This offer also includes a living stipend, a grant designed to support, for the first time in Morocco, the voluntary transition of experienced professionals toward innovative entrepreneurship.

Venture Capital offer, Startup VC

The Startup VC offer aims to invest in nine startup funds whose management companies were preselected under the call for expressions of interest launched by FM6I in collaboration with CDG Invest and MTNRA. The VC offer includes a risk-sharing mechanism designed to channel more capital toward this asset class by significantly reducing investor risk.

This is an unprecedented mechanism to support the seed and growth stages of Moroccan startups. Through this offer, the objective is to mobilize more than 1.5 billion dirhams in investments over the next five years across nearly 100 Moroccan startups.

This initiative confirms the potential of Morocco's venture capital industry and the commitment of institutional partners to contributing to the emergence of the Kingdom as a global innovation hub.

Interview with

Lamiae Benmakhlouf

General Director, Technopark

Technopark has evolved significantly since its launch in the early 2000s. How would you describe its development over time, from its original mandate to the role it plays today in Morocco's innovation ecosystem?

Lamiae Benmakhlouf: Technopark was launched as a royal project at the beginning of His Majesty's reign, at a time when internet access itself was still limited. The initial idea was to create Morocco's first incubator for tech startups. From the start, it was set up as a public-private structure, with a governance model designed to preserve agility, financial autonomy, and accountability.

The first phase was Casablanca. Between 2001 and 2010, Technopark Casablanca helped propel the first generation of Moroccan tech startups by addressing very concrete constraints: affordable premises, free internet access, and a space where an entrepreneurial community could begin to form. Over time, that offering expanded. From 2007 onward, Technopark began bringing in ecosystem actors and building a broader ecosystem around startups, with networking, support services, and an increasingly integrated model.

The second phase was regionalization. After Casablanca proved successful, the model expanded to Rabat, Tangier, Agadir and Essaouira. But this was never a pure duplication exercise. Each regional Technopark had to be adapted to the maturity, priorities, and sector profile of its region. Agadir, for example, was designed differently, with a stronger ecosystem-building function and links to the region's specific priorities. Today, other projects are underway or in development, including in Khémisset, Tiznit, Fès, and Oujda, though they are not all at the same stage of completion.

Today, Technopark is no longer limited to providing workspace for startups. It combines affordable premises with support services, ecosystem partnerships, market access, and, since 2023, ministry-backed programs covering pre-incubation, incubation, and acceleration. These programs are not limited to Technopark residents, reflecting Technopark's broader evolution into a more strategic ecosystem enabler.

Morocco has made regionalization a strategic priority, yet startup activity remains concentrated in Casablanca. From your

perspective, what does it take to build viable regional startup ecosystems and retain talent locally?

Lamiae Benmakhlouf: Technopark Casablanca is almost always at full occupancy, and there is often a waiting list of two to four months, depending on the period. The real question is not simply why talent leaves. It is how to retain young people in their regions by creating meaningful local opportunities through startups and entrepreneurship.

Each region already has core building blocks: a university, a Regional Investment Center, and at least one priority sector. What is needed is alignment between ministries, regional actors, universities, incubators, and ecosystem operators around a clear regional ambition.

Take Oujda, for example. There is strong technical talent there, but much of that value is created elsewhere. The challenge is to create the local support mechanisms and opportunities that make it possible for people to build and stay. That matters because startups are a real source of job creation. In 2025, the 450 startups supported by Technopark created approximately 1,600 to 1,700 jobs, compared to 1,200 the year before and 900 the year before that.

Building regional ecosystems also means acting earlier, by exposing young people to entrepreneurship sooner, and putting in place a jointly defined roadmap backed by pooled financing. No single actor can build a regional startup ecosystem alone. It has to be a collective effort involving public actors, regions, universities, and private-sector stakeholders.

From your day-to-day work with startups, what are the main bottlenecks founders face today?

Lamiae Benmakhlouf: The first bottleneck is market access. Startups can spend one to two years investing in R&D and bootstrapping, only to find that customer access takes so long that the market needs may already have shifted. This is particularly acute in public and corporate procurement, where formal mechanisms may exist, yet access remains extremely difficult in practice.

Even when startups win contracts, payment terms are often not respected, which creates a major working-capital problem. Founders are not only asking whether they can access the market, but also whether they will be paid on time.

The second major bottleneck is the incompleteness of the financing value chain. While early-stage financing has improved, important gaps remain in the transition from pre-seed to seed, as well as across later stages of growth. This creates discontinuity in startup financing and leaves some ventures without the capital needed to move from one stage of development to the next.

What advice would you give founders building in Morocco today?

Lamiae Benmakhlouf: The starting point should be simple: what real need am I solving? Too many founders start from a solution without first doing the competitive analysis, understanding what already exists, or clarifying where the real innovation lies.

Second, governance matters very early. If a founder is not technical, they need a strong technical counterpart within the core team. A technology startup cannot rely entirely on external development or on an arrangement in which control over the platform is fragile.

Third, founders need to be much more proactive in identifying the incentives and support mechanisms that already exist. The problem is that this information is fragmented across sectors and institutions.

Fourth, founders need to strengthen how they position, present, and market their startup. Many teams are technically strong but pitch in a way that is too technical, even to investors.

More broadly, the ecosystem also needs a more supportive culture. Encouragement, trust, and better alignment across actors matter if Morocco wants to strengthen its position as an innovation hub.

Interview with

Mustapha Lahlali

Executive Director,
Morocco Fintech Center

What gaps in Morocco's fintech ecosystem led to the creation of the Morocco Fintech Center?

Mustapha Lahlali: The talent and the ideas were already there. What was missing was the connective tissue. A founder with a payment or an insurance idea had to work out alone which of the regulators had jurisdiction, which licence applied, whom to call inside a bank, and where to find early funding. Each institution — Bank Al-Maghrib, the AMMC, the ACAPS, the ministries, the banks, the incubators — was doing useful work, but in parallel rather than together. The result was long, uncertain timelines, and a great deal of energy spent on navigation instead of on building.

The Morocco Fintech Center was created in January 2025 to close that gap: a single, neutral point of entry for fintech project holders, and a single sectoral interlocutor for the ecosystem. We started with 15 founding members, and we are now 18, bringing regulators, public institutions, banks and private players around one shared ambition: the development of Morocco Fintech Ecosystem to become a regional leader.

How would you assess the maturity of Morocco's fintech ecosystem today?

Mustapha Lahlali: Emerging, but no longer experimental. We count roughly 70 active fintechs, concentrated in payments, with growing activity in insurtech, regtech, inclusive credit, capital markets and asset management. The pipeline is real: On the acceleration side, the programme we launched in 2025 in partnership with UM6P selected 19 fintechs out of 94 applications, spanning banking, insurance and capital markets. Our 2026 ideation call for projects attracted 117 applications, 70% from Morocco and 22% from the diaspora — and the projects were more advanced than we had expected, most of them already somewhere between prototype and first customers. Two funnels, one conclusion: the volume of projects is no longer our binding constraint.

What is not yet mature is usage. Cash still circulates at exceptional levels, merchant acceptance of digital payments remains low, and financial inclusion gaps persist in rural areas and among women. So I would say we have moved from a collection of startups to a structured ecosystem. We have not yet become an industry. That is precisely the transition we are working on.

Where do fintech projects still struggle most between ideation, authorization, market entry, and scale?

Mustapha Lahlali: Two moments, mainly. The first is between ideation and authorization. Founders often design a product and only afterwards discover which regulatory perimeter it falls into — sometimes discovering that it falls into two, or into none that is clearly defined. Redesigning at that stage is expensive and discouraging. Our answer is to bring the regulatory conversation forward, into the first weeks of a project rather than the last.

The second is between the pilot and the contract. Obtaining a proof of concept with a bank or a payment institution is no longer the hard part; converting it into a signed, integrated, revenue-generating relationship is. Between the two sit procurement, security review, integration capacity and internal prioritisation, and many young companies simply run out of cash while they wait. Scale, in our market, is much less a technology problem than a commercial and organisational one.

How is the MFC helping fintechs navigate regulation and engage more effectively with regulators?

Mustapha Lahlali: Through our Bridge pillar, which works in both directions. Downstream, we give founders access to the information and to the people: orientation through our common-window function, guidance on which regulatory pathway applies to their use case, and direct meetings with the authorities. In our last cohort alone, we organised 27 sessions with regulators.

Upstream, we collect the friction points founders encounter, document them, and bring them back to the authorities in a structured way rather than as anecdotes. We are also supporting discussions on an open finance framework and on the conditions for a regulatory sandbox. What has really changed is the quality of the dialogue: regulators now hear about a use case while it is being built, not until a file has been submitted.

What needs to change for pilots with banks and corporates to become recurring commercial relationships?

Mustapha Lahlali: Three things. First, an internal sponsor with a budget. A pilot run by an innovation team with no P&L rarely survives; a pilot owned by a business line that needs the solution usually does. Second, a defined onboarding path for fintechs — standard contracts, a proportionate security and compliance review, clear timelines. When a startup waits nine months for a third-party risk assessment, the pilot dies of exhaustion rather than of failure. Third, access to data and APIs on predictable terms, which is exactly why the open finance work matters so much.

We are starting to see movement. Coming out of our last cohort, more than a dozen agreements are being signed or are at an advanced stage of discussion with banks and payment institutions, and four solutions are already commercialised.

What position can Morocco realistically build in African fintech over the next three to five years, and what would success look like?

Mustapha Lahlali: Morocco Fintech Center's first years have focused on consolidating the ecosystem and federating its stakeholders around a shared ambition. By strengthening collaboration, improving coordination and building trust, Morocco has laid the foundations for a more resilient, sustainable and competitive Fintech ecosystem.

The next phase is about growth. It is about enabling Moroccan Fintechs to scale domestically, achieve critical mass and, from this solid foundation, expand into regional and international markets. Our banking groups already operate across the continent; that footprint is an asset few of our peers have.

The objective is to position Morocco not only as a place where Fintechs emerge, but as a platform from which they can successfully grow beyond national borders.

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The Next Phase of Morocco's Startup Ecosystem

Morocco enters the next phase of its startup ecosystem development at a more consequential moment than at any point in the previous decade. The country has established clearer evidence of entrepreneurial potential, founder talent, and institutional ambition. Over the coming years, the key test will be whether that accumulated momentum can translate into repeatable company outcomes, stronger commercialization, more disciplined capital formation, and a clearer path from startup creation to scale.

This outlook reflects that shift. Across the stakeholder consultations, the tone is measured and increasingly demanding. The ecosystem will be judged by its ability to generate traction, growth, and durable businesses.

The coming years could mark Morocco's first true execution phase

If 2024 and 2025 were years of ecosystem design, signaling, and institution-building, the coming years are likely to test whether Morocco can convert that progress into tangible startup outcomes. The foundations are stronger than they were in previous cycles. Morocco now has a more explicit startup strategy, a clearer financing continuum, stronger support structures, and a more deliberate policy focus on market access, founder support, and scale.

The central question is whether Morocco can operationalize that architecture effectively. Across the stakeholder consultations, the emphasis has clearly shifted from intent to delivery. Contributors increasingly focus on deployment quality, founder maturity, capital discipline, and commercialization capacity.

Ecosystem strategies often break down during delivery. Support mechanisms may exist while founders still struggle to navigate them. Funding vehicles may be launched while deployment remains slow. Procurement reforms may be introduced while startups continue to face difficulties accessing

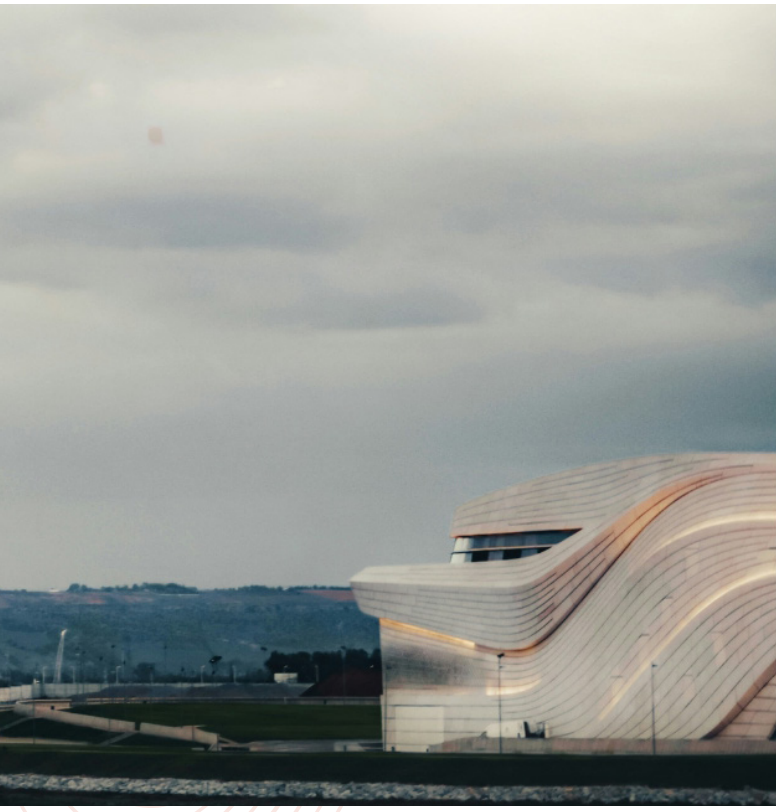
buyers. Morocco's progress will depend on whether institutions can execute with enough speed, coordination, and consistency to turn momentum into visible startup outcomes.

Domestic conditions are improving amid more pronounced external risk

Morocco enters this next phase with stronger domestic conditions for startup activity than in previous years. At the same time, the external environment has become materially more fragile. Regional conflict, energy-market volatility, and shipping disruption have all increased the risk of imported inflation, higher operating costs, and broader business uncertainty.

The coming years are therefore likely to combine improving domestic ecosystem conditions with external geopolitical and macroeconomic pressures that raise the cost of doing business and increase uncertainty for investors, corporates, and customers.

For startups, especially those exposed to logistics, enterprise sales, or cross-border expansion, execution discipline will matter even more. If external volatility persists, the strongest companies will be those that can preserve margins, adapt quickly, and convert demand despite a less stable operating environment.



The funding environment should improve, with discipline shaping its quality

The strongest common theme across investors is that the coming years should bring a better funding environment than the one founders faced in earlier periods. Stakeholders broadly expect more capital to circulate, more structured co-investment, and a more visible continuum between pre-seed, seed, and follow-on rounds. That view is consistent with the financing architecture now taking shape.

Better capital availability does not automatically produce healthier capital formation. A major concern repeated in the stakeholder consultations is valuation distortion. Several contributors noted that some founders, especially at the early stage, are pricing themselves against much deeper ecosystems without the same traction, speed, or scale dynamics.

The coming years could therefore produce stronger funding activity alongside continued weaknesses in investor-founder alignment. More money entering the market will help, although it may also inflate expectations if founders interpret public momentum as automatic validation.

The central theme for the period ahead is funding normalization. The ecosystem is likely to reward teams that are realistic on pricing, clear on milestones, and able to demonstrate commercial traction. The strongest startups will raise on terms that preserve room for follow-on capital and durable governance.

The center of gravity should start moving from pre-seed formation to Series A readiness

Beyond capital availability, a second issue is becoming more visible: the ecosystem still narrows sharply as companies approach maturity. The country is generating more startups than before, although the number of venture-scale companies with defensible products, repeatable revenue, and institutional readiness for larger rounds remains limited.

That gap will be central over the coming years. Multiple investors pointed to a stronger emerging class of Series A opportunities than Morocco had in prior periods, and some explicitly expect the next few years to be shaped by larger rounds, more structured syndication, and a deeper follow-on market.

This is also where the financing framework matters most. Its role extends beyond supporting company creation to strengthening continuity across the funding lifecycle and preventing pre-seed growth from outpacing the development of later-stage capital.

The quality of Morocco's ecosystem will increasingly be judged by the number of startups that become institutionally investable. That means better reporting, cleaner governance, stronger unit economics, clearer go-to-market execution, and more mature founders. The ecosystem's credibility will rise fastest if Morocco begins producing a visible layer of companies that can absorb larger tickets without breaking.

Market access will be the real battleground

One of the clearest conclusions from the stakeholder consultations is that market access has become the harder constraint. Startups can be incubated, accelerated, introduced, and even funded, yet still fail to secure enough meaningful customers quickly enough.

The next phase is likely to be defined heavily by customer conversion. Morocco needs to increase the rate at which startups convert pilots into contracts, integrations into recurring revenue, and early visibility into repeatable procurement or enterprise sales.

This makes execution on the demand side especially important. Smoother access to public and private buyers could materially improve the survival and scaling odds of local ventures. If that gap remains unresolved, the ecosystem risks overproducing funded startups that remain commercially underpowered.

Corporates should become far more important, first as LPs, then as customers, partners, and acquirers

Another major shift visible in the stakeholder consultations is the growing role of corporates. Several investors see corporate participation becoming more structural, especially through fund commitments, partnership programs, and eventual strategic transactions. Morocco's next stage will increasingly depend on whether large institutions, banks, industrial groups, and service operators begin behaving as real ecosystem demand engines.

Corporate involvement is likely to deepen first at the capital-allocation level. Over time, that should spill over into customer acquisition, distribution partnerships, data access, embedded services, and eventually M&A.

That sequence makes sense for Morocco. In ecosystems with thinner late-stage VC depth, corporates often help de-risk startups commercially before becoming strategic acquirers. This is an area where Morocco could make visible progress over the coming years.

Talent quality will matter more than talent volume

Stakeholders are broadly aligned on one point: Morocco needs to develop more founders and early teams that combine technical execution, business judgment, sector knowledge, managerial maturity, and the resilience required for venture building.

The coming years may expose a clearer divide inside the ecosystem between teams capable of building a product and those capable of building a company. Access to startup programs alone will carry less weight as execution quality becomes more important.

This matters for investors as much as for founders. Several contributions suggest that some of Morocco's strongest companies are led by lower-profile founders with sharper execution and stronger traction. The coming years may reward discipline over visibility.

Investor-led venture builders, founder education, and operator-heavy support models could therefore have real impact by improving founder readiness and shortening the time between idea and investability.

Regionalization will be one of the key tests for Morocco's startup ecosystem

While Casablanca and Rabat are expected to remain the main centers of capital, support infrastructure, and founder density, the next phase of ecosystem development will increasingly depend on Morocco's ability to build stronger entrepreneurial pipelines across other regions.

That means building stronger local capacity through universities, incubators, regional investors, public support mechanisms, and founder communities aligned with each region's economic strengths.

If executed well, regionalization could widen the national startup funnel, surface overlooked talent, and generate more sector-specific ventures rooted in local opportunities, whether in agritech, industry, logistics, climate, tourism, or health.

The key question over the coming years is whether entrepreneurial potential outside the main hubs can be supported with enough continuity, coordination, capital, and market access to translate into scalable companies.

Diaspora leverage could become one of Morocco's most important multipliers

The stakeholder consultations also point to a structural advantage Morocco has not fully monetized yet: its diaspora. Over the coming years, diaspora engagement could develop into a more practical growth lever.

Diaspora founders, operators, angels, and mentors can help Morocco in several ways at once: by bringing pattern recognition, improving founder ambition, strengthening mentorship, and deepening investor trust.

This is especially valuable in an ecosystem still trying to deepen founder experience, investor trust, and access to high-quality networks. More systematic circulation of talent, capital, expertise, and mentorship could provide significant value without requiring every successful Moroccan abroad to relocate permanently.

If Morocco begins to institutionalize that circulation more effectively, diaspora participation could become a major accelerator for the next cycle.

Internationalization will increasingly separate local promise from regional scale

For many Moroccan startups, the domestic market alone will not be enough to support venture-scale outcomes. That makes internationalization one of the clearest dividing lines over the coming years. The strongest startups will be able to translate local traction into regional or cross-border expansion.

Morocco has several structural advantages that support this path, including geographic proximity to Europe, stronger links to Francophone Africa, growing connectivity with Gulf markets, and a diaspora that can open commercial and investor networks abroad.

These advantages create a credible platform for outward expansion, although execution will determine which companies can use them effectively. Internationalization should increasingly become a measure of startup quality, separating companies that are locally relevant from those that are genuinely scalable.

AI will increasingly act as a competitiveness layer across the ecosystem

AI is likely to become one of the most important forces shaping Morocco's startup ecosystem over the coming years. Its influence will extend horizontally across how startups build, compete, and scale, rather than remaining confined to a standalone vertical.

Across the stakeholder consultations, the message is consistent. AI is becoming part of the baseline expectation for software, operations, and product development, especially in B2B and digital services. For Moroccan founders, this creates a real opportunity. AI-native or AI-enabled products could help more startups overcome some of the scale limits of the domestic market.

AI is also likely to increase selection pressure across the ecosystem. Startups capable of using it to improve product quality, efficiency, and defensibility will strengthen their position. Weaker models may become more exposed where their value proposition can be replicated easily by larger incumbents.

Morocco appears to have part of what it needs to benefit from this shift, especially technical talent and growing founder ambition. Turning AI into a real ecosystem advantage will also require better access to data, stronger infrastructure, and clearer commercialization pathways. AI is therefore likely to act as both a growth lever and a filter on startup quality.

Fintech appears especially well positioned

If one vertical appears particularly well placed for the next phase, it is fintech and adjacent infrastructure. Stakeholders describe a market that is becoming more concrete and deployable. Banking-as-a-Service, digital payments, financial inclusion products, embedded finance, and cash-to-digital transition layers are increasingly being treated as active market segments.

That view is reinforced by the institutional environment. The Morocco Fintech Center has now been formalized as a central ecosystem platform, bringing together regulators, public institutions, investors, banks, and universities to support fintech development and accelerate digital financial infrastructure.

Compliance, licensing pathways, integration timelines, and enterprise sales cycles will remain difficult. Fintech nevertheless appears to have three advantages: it addresses a real domestic pain point, aligns with national digitization priorities, and benefits from stronger institutional support than before. That makes it one of the strongest candidates for real breakout momentum over the coming years.

Deeptech should advance, although a broad breakout remains unlikely in the near term

Deeptech is different. The stakeholder consultations suggest that Morocco is progressing on the ingredients needed for future deeptech emergence, including stronger sovereignty language, greater attention to local IP, and growing awareness of commercialization gaps. Official startup strategy also places clear weight on innovation, national resilience, and the local generation of strategic capabilities.

The more realistic expectation for the coming years is selective progress. Morocco may generate stronger pipelines in a few areas, particularly where university, industrial, and national-priority interests overlap, while the broader bottleneck remains commercialization.

Technical invention alone will not be enough. Teams will need business translation, procurement pathways, pilot environments, and patient capital. Until that layer becomes thicker, deeptech will remain promising but uneven.

Exits, M&A, and liquidity are now central

A real ecosystem cannot mature through startup creation and fundraising alone. At some point, capital has to circulate back. That is why one of the most important themes across stakeholder consultations is the need for exits, or at least for visible forms of liquidity.

IPOs are unlikely to become the main story for venture-backed startups in the near term. The market could still enter an important transition if it begins generating more acquisitions, consolidations, corporate buyouts, secondaries, and strategic mergers. Several stakeholders already pointed in that direction, especially those who see M&A as the natural next step in ecosystem maturity.

A few credible liquidity events would do more for founder ambition, LP appetite, and investor confidence than a large number of ecosystem panels. They would show that startup equity in Morocco can convert into real outcomes. A continued absence of such events would leave an important part of the ecosystem incomplete.

Taken together, the stakeholder consultations point to a clear conclusion. Morocco enters the next phase with stronger fundamentals and more visible infrastructure than in previous years. Its trajectory will now depend on the conversion of that momentum into company outcomes.

The priorities are clear: more investable companies, better buyer access, stronger follow-on financing, and clearer signs of liquidity and founder recycling. Progress across these areas could mark the beginning of a more self-reinforcing cycle for the ecosystem. Partial progress would preserve the gap between ambition and outcomes.

The coming years will therefore be decisive in showing whether Morocco's startup ecosystem can move from coordinated ambition to durable outcomes.

Recommendations for Founders

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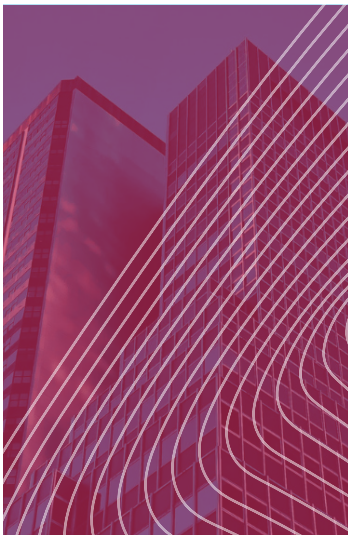
This year's edition of the Morocco Startup Ecosystem Report introduces a new dedicated section, Recommendations for Founders, which is intended to become a recurring feature in future editions. The aim is to surface the specific, contextual guidance that matters most in a given year, grounded in what stakeholders across the ecosystem are actually seeing, funding, and building.

In 2025, Morocco's startup ecosystem entered a more structured phase. Several local venture capital players moved beyond their initial launch phase and into a more mature period of deployment and portfolio management, while international investor interest became more visible on the ground. At the same time, the Ministry of Digital Transition continued to put greater structure behind founder support, yet recurring friction points persisted.

What follows is a synthesis of input from investors, institutional operators, public-sector leaders, and experienced founders interviewed for this report. Their perspectives converge around twelve areas where founders can meaningfully shift their own trajectory, regardless of what the broader ecosystem does or does not yet deliver.

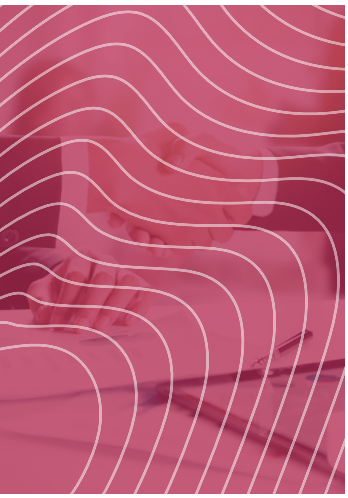
Build the Right Company

Lead with the Problem, Not the Product



Too many Moroccan founders build solutions in search of a problem. The pattern is familiar: a technically capable team develops a platform because the technology interests them, without first validating whether the market has an unmet need, whether incumbents already serve it adequately, or whether the target customer will pay for the improvement. The starting point for any venture should be a simple but essential question: what real need am I solving?

Investors consistently flag rigorous competitive benchmarking, both local and international, as a baseline expectation. Before building, founders should be able to articulate why the problem is real, why existing solutions do not adequately address it, and why the current context creates a credible opening for a new entrant. Without that level of validation, even a well-built product risks solving the wrong problem.



Work with Incumbents, Not Against Them

Morocco's market structure differs from the ecosystems that founders most often benchmark against. Unlike Egypt, Nigeria, or Kenya, where more fragmented legacy systems created broader greenfield openings for digital-first players, Morocco has relatively strong, well-established institutions across banking, insurance, telecom, logistics, and retail. As a result, startups that try to compete head-on often struggle, while those that position themselves as enablers tend to have a clearer path. In Morocco, the stronger strategy is often to help incumbents move faster, digitize operations, reach underserved segments, or improve customer acquisition. The practical lesson is to study the incumbent landscape early and identify where your startup can plug into existing value chains rather than assume it can replace them.

Prioritize Distribution and Market Access Earlier

Moroccan startups spend their first twelve to eighteen months refining a product in isolation, only to discover that market access is the real challenge. Stakeholders consistently rank it among the ecosystem's most serious bottlenecks, ahead of many of the issues founders tend to focus on first. Startups invest heavily in building, bootstrap through the early phase, and then hit a wall: procurement channels are hard to unlock, large corporates move slowly, and the time required to secure a first meaningful contract can be long enough to undermine momentum or even the product's relevance. Founders should therefore treat distribution as a first-order problem from day one, not something to solve after the product is built. That means identifying potential buyers early, testing access channels during product development, and putting as much effort into go-to-market as into the product itself. The founders who break through are usually the ones who start building distribution early, not late.

Think Regionally from Day One, but Prove Product-Market Fit First

One of the sharpest strategic divides among stakeholders concerns how founders should think about geographic scope. The consensus is clear: building exclusively for the Moroccan domestic market limits a startup's ceiling in ways that make venture-scale outcomes unlikely. The disagreement is about which direction to expand and, critically, when.

Some investors advocate a Francophone Africa-first strategy, arguing that founders should think beyond Morocco from the outset and position themselves for expansion into markets where language, business practices, and regional connectivity can create a more natural path to scale. Others push for the GCC as the natural next market, given higher purchasing power, deeper average contract values, and cultural proximity. A third camp sees Europe as the scaling destination. Morocco should be treated as a launchpad, not as the final market: a testing ground where a few key reference clients validate the product before expansion toward larger or more mature markets.

However, a critical counterpoint emerged from founders who have actually scaled. People talk too quickly about international expansion. Before announcing plans to be in multiple countries, a founder needs to know whether customers in their own market are genuinely using the product, recommending it, and coming back. The practical takeaway is that product architecture, pricing, and go-to-market should be designed with expansion in mind from the start, but the actual move abroad should be earned through local traction, not assumed.

Build It on Strong Foundations

Build the Right Team and Governance

Team quality is one of the most important investment criteria cited by nearly every investor interviewed for this report. The emphasis goes beyond technical competence. Investors assess whether the founding team has the resilience to pivot, the domain expertise to navigate sector-specific challenges, and the governance maturity to withstand the pressures of scaling. At some point, nearly every startup will face setbacks, strategic adjustments, or moments where the original approach no longer works. The strongest signal founders can send is a combination of sector depth, strong execution capacity, and a team structure that can adapt under pressure.

Use the Support Infrastructure That Already Exists

Morocco's support ecosystem has expanded, but many of its opportunities remain unevenly visible or poorly understood by founders. The information gap is real, and founders should not wait for it to be solved systemically. The more effective posture is to assume that useful support exists, then make it a founder's job to find it, understand it, and use it strategically. In practice, that means actively mapping the ecosystem, speaking to the right people, tracking relevant programs, and treating support mechanisms as part of the execution plan rather than as peripheral extras. Founders who do this early are better positioned to test, build, and de-risk their business before seeking outside capital.

Protect Your Cash Flow Against Late Payments

Late payment on closed deals is one of the most underappreciated threats to startup survival in Morocco. The problem is structural. Laws governing payment timelines exist, but enforcement remains inconsistent. Founders cannot solve this problem alone, but they can plan for it. Building payment milestones into contracts, negotiating partial upfront payments, maintaining cash reserves beyond what revenue forecasts alone would suggest, and diversifying the client base to avoid dependence on a single large buyer are all defensive measures. Founders entering B2B or B2G markets should also connect with ecosystem actors who can advocate on their behalf, as several investors described actively intervening alongside portfolio companies to help ensure timely payment.

Raise and Scale with Discipline

Ground Your Valuation in Local Reality

The single most consistent message from investors across the spectrum is that Moroccan startup valuations remain disconnected from what the ecosystem can support. Founders regularly approach investors with multimillion-dollar expectations, benchmarked against Silicon Valley or European rounds, in a market where ticket sizes, exit horizons, and revenue ceilings operate on a fundamentally different scale. In practice, that disconnect can become a serious handicap. An overstretched valuation may create momentum in the short term, but it often narrows the investor pool, complicates negotiations, and raises expectations for later rounds that the business may not yet be in a position to meet.

Expect the Fundraise to Take Much Longer Than Planned

Founders should expect the fundraising process to take significantly longer than planned. A common pattern across the ecosystem is founders entering a raise with the assumption that a round will close within a couple of months, only to discover that the reality is far more drawn out. Negotiations take time, due diligence takes time, legal documentation takes time, and getting all the relevant parties aligned takes time. Those delays can be amplified when the round involves foreign holding structures or cross-border legal setup. Several investors pointed to cases where a flip from a Moroccan entity to a U.S. structure alone could take three months or more, materially stretching the closing timeline, while others described deals expected to close in 2025 that were still stuck in legal setup at year-end. The gap between a verbal commitment and cash actually reaching the company's account remains one of the most underestimated variables in the local fundraising environment. Founders should therefore build a buffer of at least several additional months into their financial planning, preserve runway accordingly, and avoid making irreversible commitments on the assumption that a signed term sheet means the money is effectively secured.

Choose Investors for Fit, Not Just Cash

In a market where capital is becoming more available but investor expertise remains uneven, the choice of who to raise from matters as much as the amount raised. Different funds bring different strengths beyond the check: some can support European expansion, others understand African market entry, and others can open doors to corporate buyers that would otherwise take years to reach. By contrast, some investors add little beyond capital and can become a source of friction when their expectations, reporting style, or governance approach do not match the company's stage. One of the most useful diligence steps founders can take is also the simplest: speak to other founders in the fund's portfolio. Those conversations often reveal far more about how an investor behaves, what they actually unlock, and whether they create drag or reduce it.

Be Deliberate About Offshore Structuring

A growing trend among Moroccan founders is incorporating holding companies abroad, typically in Delaware, Dubai, or Singapore, often on the advice of investors or accelerators seeking familiar legal frameworks. The practice is not inherently wrong, but several stakeholders warned that founders are often following the trend without fully understanding the legal, fiscal, and operational consequences.

Some investors argue firmly that Delaware registration should be the default for startups seeking international capital, pointing to the speed of setup and the comfort it provides foreign funds. Others counter that this can create unnecessary complexity and that Morocco's domestic legal framework is increasingly adequate for venture transactions. The recommendation is simple: make the decision based on a specific capital strategy, a concrete investor base, and qualified legal advice, not because it appears to be the standard path.

Become Series A-Ready Before You Think You Need to Be

A recurring observation from later-stage investors is that too many Moroccan startups reach the point where they should be raising a Series A and discover they are not ready, not because the business lacks promise, but because the operational foundations were never built. Series A investors expect more than growth. They want clean financial reporting, clear unit economics, strong documentation, and governance that can withstand institutional scrutiny. These are not things founders can assemble a few weeks before a raise. They need to be built early and maintained consistently. In Morocco, the startups that move into larger rounds most effectively are usually the ones that started operating with that level of discipline well before they needed it.

Morocco's startup ecosystem in 2025 is a market in transition. Real capital is being deployed, real companies are scaling, and real institutional support is beginning to take clearer shape. But the pipeline of fundable startups remains narrow, market access is still constrained, and the entrepreneurial culture needed to sustain long-term startup growth is still forming.

The founders who will define the next chapter of this ecosystem are the ones who approach it with clear eyes: realistic about the constraints, ambitious about the opportunities, and disciplined about the fundamentals. Stakeholders interviewed for this report consistently expressed confidence in Morocco's long-term trajectory. The question is not whether the ecosystem will mature, but how quickly founders will build in a way that matches where it is heading. What the ecosystem now needs most is a stronger base of founders willing to think bigger, build better, and pursue outcomes that match the scale of the opportunity ahead.

130 Methodology

This report has been developed through a structured research methodology designed to provide a rigorous and balanced analysis of Morocco's startup ecosystem. The approach reflects the report's ambition to serve as a credible reference for decision-makers across the entrepreneurial, institutional, academic, and investment landscape.

The research framework combines secondary research, quantitative analysis, and qualitative consultation. Together, these components ensure that the report captures both the formal structure of the ecosystem and the practical realities experienced by its actors.

Secondary Research and Quantitative Analysis

The research process begins with the collection of raw data from multiple relevant sources. These include startup and investment databases, company announcements, investor communications, official registries where relevant, and credible media reporting. Data points may relate to startup creation, funding rounds, investor activity, sector classification, geography, ecosystem milestones, and selected founder- or talent-related dynamics.

Because startup ecosystem data is rarely standardized, a major part of the methodology lies in data cleaning and normalization. This includes removing duplicate entries, reconciling conflicting figures, aligning naming conventions, standardizing categories, and clarifying whether transactions or entities meet the report's inclusion criteria. The methodology also seeks to distinguish, wherever possible, between announced activity and verifiable activity.

Cross-checking is a core element of the process. Key data points are reviewed against multiple references when available, especially in cases involving funding events, investor attribution, company location, or sector identification. Where conflicting information cannot be fully resolved, the report applies judgment based on source reliability, recency, and consistency with broader ecosystem evidence.

Stakeholder Consultations

A meaningful assessment of Morocco's startup ecosystem must be informed not only by published data, but also by the perspectives of the people shaping and navigating it. For this reason, stakeholder consultation forms a core component of the research process.

The report incorporates input from a range of ecosystem actors, including founders, investors, public institutions, corporates, and other key stakeholders. These perspectives are gathered through interviews, written exchanges, targeted questionnaires, and validation discussions. The objective is to capture practical insight into how the ecosystem operates in practice, where its main bottlenecks lie, and which opportunities are considered most significant by those working within it.

This consultative approach is especially important in areas where public data remains incomplete. Topics such as access to capital, market readiness, public support effectiveness, ecosystem fragmentation, talent development, commercialization barriers, and regional imbalance often require interpretation that goes beyond what is formally disclosed.

As part of this consultative process, the report also included a selected set of featured interviews. The interviews featured in the report were selected based on their relevance to the ecosystem and their contribution to the report's analytical objectives.

Founder Survey on Challenges and Bottlenecks

To complement the broader research process, the report also incorporates findings from a dedicated survey distributed to founders. The survey was designed to capture first-hand insight into the main challenges, constraints, and bottlenecks faced by startups operating in Morocco. This includes issues related to access to capital, customer acquisition, talent, regulation, operational scaling, market readiness, and the effectiveness of existing support mechanisms.

The survey adds a structured bottom-up

dimension to the methodology by ensuring that the experiences of founders are directly reflected in the analysis. It helps surface patterns that may not be fully visible through secondary research, transaction data, or stakeholder interviews alone, particularly where challenges are operational, informal, or insufficiently documented in public sources. To ensure transparency, respondents were required to identify themselves as part of the survey process. Care was also taken to include founders across different stages, sectors, and cities in order to improve the breadth and balance of the findings.

Deal Identification and Treatment

A dedicated component of the methodology focuses on the identification, verification, and classification of startup deals. This includes tracking publicly announced funding rounds, acquisitions, exits, and other relevant transactions across company announcements, investor communications, database records, media reporting, and stakeholder input. Particular attention is paid to confirming whether a transaction was completed, when it occurred, which parties were involved, and how it should be categorized within the report.

For the purposes of the report, a Moroccan startup is defined as either a startup headquartered in Morocco, or a startup headquartered abroad that was founded by at least one Moroccan founder and maintains a significant presence and operations in Morocco.

Given the still limited disclosure of startup transactions in Morocco, the methodology also seeks to uncover undisclosed deals and surface missing details on reported transactions. Stakeholder consultations are especially valuable in this regard, as they help validate transactions, confirm investor participation, clarify timing, and fill gaps related to round size, structure, or context.

Where information cannot be sufficiently verified, it is treated cautiously and either qualified or excluded. This approach helps strengthen the accuracy, consistency, and credibility of the report's deal analysis.

Local Investor Mapping

The report includes a dedicated mapping of local investors within Morocco's startup ecosystem. For the purposes of this section, only investors identified as primarily Moroccan were included. International investors with a presence, activity, or exposure to the Moroccan market were not classified as local investors and were therefore excluded from this specific mapping to ensure consistency in the report's analytical framework.

At the same time, the role of international investors is reflected elsewhere in the report. A number of international investors who contributed to the research process are featured through quotes and through the perspectives they shared in helping shape selected sections of the analysis.

Currency Conversion Methodology

Unless otherwise stated, USD equivalents are approximate and based on monthly average reference exchange rates for the relevant transaction month. Original disclosed currencies are retained for accuracy.

Data Cut-off Date

The analysis presented in this report reflects information collected, reviewed, and verified up to June 30, 2026. Developments occurring after this cut-off date were not incorporated into the final analysis unless explicitly stated otherwise.

Confidentiality and Attribution

Confidentiality requests made by contributors were fully respected throughout the research and drafting process. Where applicable, these inputs were incorporated into the analysis on a non-attributed basis, without disclosing the identity of the individual, organization, or specific context of the contribution. Direct quotes and named references were included only with the contributor's consent.

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